SORT 1 / 684

ENTRYWAY

Landing Zone

Decide what stays.

Empty the tray and the paper stack onto the floor. Keys that open nothing, loyalty cards, dead batteries and last month's flyers leave now. Every piece of mail gets a verdict of act, file, or recycle before anything goes back on the surface.

STRAIGHTEN 2 / 684

ENTRYWAY

Landing Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Put the tray where your hand actually opens on the way in, not where the furniture happens to be. Keys and sunglasses in the tray, one upright folder for act-on paper, and the charger plugged in at the far end away from anything that drips.

SHINE 3 / 684

ENTRYWAY

Landing Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Lift the tray out and wipe under it, then wipe the tray itself. Keys shed grit and coins leave a gray film that tells you exactly how long it has been since anyone did this.

SAFETY 4 / 684

ENTRYWAY

Landing Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

The charging cable and the umbrella drip line must not share a spot. Check what else is on the outlet feeding the dock, because a lamp, a seasonal heater and a four-port charger on one strip is this room's usual overload.

STANDARDIZE 5 / 684

ENTRYWAY

Landing Zone

Write down what good looks like.

Photograph the cleared tray with the folder standing beside it, print it small, and tape it inside the coat cupboard door at the height people glance while hanging a coat. The tray then teaches itself.

SUSTAIN 6 / 684

ENTRYWAY

Landing Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

The folder rides to the sofa with you after dinner, one sheet at a time, and each adult works their own. Slip shows from the doorway: a second pile beside the tray, or a folder too fat to stand up. Recovery is one five minute sitting with the recycling bin at your feet, not a re-sort of the surface. This zone drifts faster than ...

> **THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN**
> One tray holding keys and sunglasses, one wallet and one phone per adult, a single upright folder with fewer than ten sheets of paper standing in it, and bare surface on both sides of the tray.

SORT 7 / 684

ENTRYWAY

Coat and Outerwear Zone

Decide what stays.

Take every coat down. Anything that did not go outdoors once through the last cold season leaves, and so do the single gloves you kept in case the other one turned up. Off-season coats go to a bedroom closet, not to the far end of the same rail.

STRAIGHTEN 8 / 684

ENTRYWAY

Coat and Outerwear Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Hooks for what goes on and off daily, hangers only for the wool coat that creases. Set the lowest hook at the height of the shortest person who uses it, and keep the two hooks nearest the door empty for visitors.

SHINE 9 / 684

ENTRYWAY

Coat and Outerwear Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Brush the shoulders of the hanging coats, wipe the shelf where dust settles on top of the hat bin, and tip out the umbrella stand. There is always water and grit in the bottom of it.

SAFETY 10 / 684

ENTRYWAY

Coat and Outerwear Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Hang your full weight on each hook before you trust it with a soaked winter coat. Hooks driven into plasterboard without an anchor pull out later, with the coat still attached and a lump of wall behind it.

STANDARDIZE 11 / 684

ENTRYWAY

Coat and Outerwear Zone

Write down what good looks like.

Write the contents and the season on the shelf bin, hats and gloves, winter, so whoever reaches up for it in October knows without opening the lid whether they have the right bin.

SUSTAIN 12 / 684

ENTRYWAY

Coat and Outerwear Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

Whoever loads the washing machine walks the rail on the way past, under a minute, returning whatever was left on a chair back or the bannister. The count does the telling: two hooks stay empty, so a full rail read from the doorway means the room is already over. Recovery is carrying the two coats nobody wore this month up to a ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

One coat per person on the rail, one bag, hats and gloves together in a single labeled bin on the shelf above, umbrellas standing in the stand, and at least two hooks left empty.

SORT 13 / 684

ENTRYWAY

Shoe and Boot Zone

Decide what stays.

Pull every shoe out and pair them up on the floor. Odd shoes, outgrown children's pairs and the sneakers with the split sole all go, and so does the tin of polish that has dried solid.

STRAIGHTEN 14 / 684

ENTRYWAY

Shoe and Boot Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Daily pairs on the rack at a height you can reach standing up, boots in the tray because they will always come in wet, off-season pairs boxed in a closet. Nothing at all on the floor between the door and the rack.

SHINE 15 / 684

ENTRYWAY

Shoe and Boot Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Take the boot tray outside and hose it. The salt and grit sitting in it is precisely what scratches your hallway floor. Wipe down the rack shelves too, they hold more dried mud than they look like they do.

SAFETY 16 / 684

ENTRYWAY

Shoe and Boot Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Wet soles on a hard floor are how people go down in this room. The tray has to catch the drip, and anything that walked in soaked stays on the tray until it is dry rather than being carried through the house.

STANDARDIZE 17 / 684

ENTRYWAY

Shoe and Boot Zone

Write down what good looks like.

Give each person their own named shelf on the rack, the name written at the shelf edge, so a third pair has visibly nowhere to stand and nobody has to count.

SUSTAIN 18 / 684

ENTRYWAY

Shoe and Boot Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

Shoes come off inside the door and go onto the rack before the coat, while both hands are still free, each person to their own named shelf. A two second act on arrival, or a ten minute job on Saturday. The floor is the signal: one pair standing off the rack means a shelf is full. Recovery is one person's overflow going to a ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Two pairs per person on the rack, soles down, boots standing in the tray, one pair of slippers each, and a clear stretch of floor a full stride wide between the door and the rack.

SORT 19 / 684

ENTRYWAY

Entry Console or Bench

Decide what stays.

Tip the drawer out onto the bench. Dead batteries, pens that do not write, single earbuds, sunscreen from three summers ago and takeout menus all go now. Anything you would not want while wearing your outdoor shoes belongs in a different room.

STRAIGHTEN 20 / 684

ENTRYWAY

Entry Console or Bench

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Divide the drawer into named sections and hold to them: dog leash and waste bags, sunscreen and insect spray, a flashlight, one pen. Bags and the vacuum go underneath the bench, never on the seat.

SHINE 21 / 684

ENTRYWAY

Entry Console or Bench

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Take the drawer fully out and tip the sand and crumbs out of its corners. Wipe the seat itself, which collects the same grit as the floor because people sit on it in outdoor clothes.

SAFETY 22 / 684

ENTRYWAY

Entry Console or Bench

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Fix the console to the wall if it is taller than it is deep, because children climb open drawer fronts like a ladder. Move the box cutter and the scissors out of the shallow drawer that opens at toddler head height.

STANDARDIZE 23 / 684

ENTRYWAY

Entry Console or Bench

Write down what good looks like.

Write the three permitted top items on a card and tape it inside the drawer, so the cap survives everyone who did not read this book.

SUSTAIN 24 / 684

ENTRYWAY

Entry Console or Bench

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

Whoever clears the dinner table carries the plates past the bench and takes the top back to three on the way through, which adds nothing to a trip already being made. The seat is the signal, not the top: if you cannot sit down to lace a boot without lifting something, the bench has stopped being a bench. Recovery is one armful ...

> **THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN**
> Three items or fewer on the top, a seat with nothing on it at all, and a drawer where every divided section has one named category and you can see the base of the drawer between things.

SORT 25 / 684

ENTRYWAY

Door, Mat, and Immediate Floor

Decide what stays.

Nothing is stored on this patch of floor, so the recycling bag, the parcel waiting to go back and the sports kit all move tonight. Give outgoing returns one named spot in another room and carry the rest to where they actually belong.

STRAIGHTEN 26 / 684

ENTRYWAY

Door, Mat, and Immediate Floor

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Two mats and only two. Coarse outside to scrape, absorbent inside to dry. The inside mat needs to be long enough that both feet land on it while walking, and most are not, which is exactly how the grit gets past.

SHINE 27 / 684

ENTRYWAY

Door, Mat, and Immediate Floor

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Vacuum the inside mat on both faces, then take it outdoors, beat it and wash it. Run a cloth along the bottom edge of the door and along the threshold strip, because that dark line is all the grit the mat never caught.

SAFETY 28 / 684

ENTRYWAY

Door, Mat, and Immediate Floor

Fix what could hurt somebody.

A curled mat corner and a mat that slides on hard floor are the two ways this threshold puts somebody down. Grip or tape the edges flat, and dry the floor immediately when someone comes in soaked rather than leaving it to evaporate.

STANDARDIZE 29 / 684

ENTRYWAY

Door, Mat, and Immediate Floor

Write down what good looks like.

Run a thin line of tape around where the mat should sit, so a mat kicked out of position is obvious to anyone walking in rather than only to you.

SUSTAIN 30 / 684

ENTRYWAY

Door, Mat, and Immediate Floor

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

The mat sits on the route back to the vacuum cupboard, so whoever ran the vacuum straightens and cleans it last, every time. Overnight the job is smaller: the last person in nudges it back inside its taped outline with a foot. Slip is visible before you reach the door, as a curled corner outside the tape or a gray line of grit ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

A coarse mat outside the door and an absorbent one inside, both lying dead flat with no curled corners, nothing whatsoever on the floor inside the door's swing, and a door that latches on the first push.

SORT 31 / 684

KITCHEN

Primary Prep Counter

Decide what stays.

Take everything off the counter and set it on the dining table, then let only three things back: what you cut on, what you cut with, and what you season with. The vitamins, the second cutting board, the bread bag and the pile of receipts find homes elsewhere or leave.

STRAIGHTEN 32 / 684

KITCHEN

Primary Prep Counter

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Put the board where you already stand without thinking, then build outward from it. Knives on a wall strip or in a block on your dominant side, oil and salt behind the board rather than beside it, mixing bowls in the cabinet directly underneath so you can reach one without turning around.

SHINE 33 / 684

KITCHEN

Primary Prep Counter

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Lift the toaster and the kettle instead of wiping around them, because crumbs collect under the appliance feet and never move. Run a damp cloth along the seam where the counter meets the backsplash, and shake the toaster crumb tray out over the bin.

SAFETY 34 / 684

KITCHEN

Primary Prep Counter

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Knives belong in a block, on a magnetic strip, or in a bladed sleeve in a drawer, never loose among the utensils and never blade-up in the drying rack. Keep the kettle and toaster cords off the sink side of the counter, where a wet hand meets them.

STANDARDIZE 35 / 684

KITCHEN

Primary Prep Counter

Write down what good looks like.

Mark the clear run so it is not a matter of opinion. A short strip of tape under the counter lip, or the outline of the board itself, tells everyone in the house where the work surface starts and that it stays empty.

SUSTAIN 36 / 684

KITCHEN

Primary Prep Counter

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

Whoever presses start on the dishwasher puts the board back down onto bare counter, about a minute, and that settles the whole run. The board is the gauge: if it will not sit flat, or you have to move something to lay it down, the clear run has gone. Recovery is sweeping the strays into a basket and carrying the basket out of ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

One clear run of counter at least as wide as your largest cutting board, holding only the board, the knife block or strip, and the salt. The kettle and the toaster stand back against the wall with their cords ...

SORT 37 / 684

KITCHEN

Cooking Zone

Decide what stays.

Empty the utensil crock into a box and cook for a week, returning to the crock only what your hand actually reaches for. The warped plastic turner, the corn holders, and the third pair of tongs are still in the box at the end of the week, which is your answer.

STRAIGHTEN 38 / 684

KITCHEN

Cooking Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Arrange by the moment of need, not by shape. Oil, salt, and the turner within one reach of the burner, spices in a shallow drawer or tiered rack where you read the lids from above rather than shuffling jars, pans stored on the side you plate from.

SHINE 39 / 684

KITCHEN

Cooking Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Lift the burner grates off and soak them while you wash the splash wall and the underside of the hood with dish soap. Take the hood filter out and run it through hot soapy water, because a saturated filter stops pulling steam and starts dripping it back down.

SAFETY 40 / 684

KITCHEN

Cooking Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Turn every pan handle inward so it cannot catch a sleeve or a small hand reaching up. Keep the dish towel, the paper roll, and the oil bottle off the burner side of the stovetop, and know where the fire blanket or extinguisher is before a pan is smoking. If the stovetop burns gas, three things belong in this pass. Know where ...

STANDARDIZE 41 / 684

KITCHEN

Cooking Zone

Write down what good looks like.

Photograph the stovetop and one step of surround in its ready state and tape the photo inside the nearest cabinet door, so ready is a picture anyone can match rather than a standard only you hold.

SUSTAIN 42 / 684

KITCHEN

Cooking Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

The reset runs inside the cooking: while the pan comes up to heat, the spice goes back to the front of the rack and any loose utensil drops into the crock. Whoever is cooking does it, in time already spent waiting. The signal is the landing space, and if there is nowhere clear to set a hot pan down the zone has slipped ...

> **THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN**
> Oil, salt, and pepper within one reach of the burners. A utensil crock holding no more than six tools, every one of which you used this month. Pot holders on a hook you can find without looking, the spices you ...

SORT 43 / 684

KITCHEN

Sink and Dishwashing Zone

Decide what stays.

Pull everything out from under the sink and line it up on the floor. Combine the three half-empty bottles of the same spray, bin what has separated or lost its label, and move out anything that is not dish, sink, or plumbing related, because that cabinet gets damp and is the wrong home for spare bulbs, paper goods, or vases.

STRAIGHTEN 44 / 684

KITCHEN

Sink and Dishwashing Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Soap and brush live in a caddy you can lift with one wet hand, so wiping under them takes no planning. Dishwasher tablets go in a container beside the machine rather than across the room, and the towel gets a bar within reach of somebody already standing at the basin.

SHINE 45 / 684

KITCHEN

Sink and Dishwashing Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

The sponge is the dirtiest object in the room: wring it out and stand it on edge after every wash, and retire it the day it smells while dry. Scrub the drain flange, wipe the rubber seal all the way around the dishwasher door, and pull the dishwasher filter out and rinse it, because a filter that has never come out since the ...

SAFETY 46 / 684

KITCHEN

Sink and Dishwashing Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Never store bleach beside an ammonia or toilet cleaner under this sink, and never combine them in the basin; keep them apart, capped, and labels facing out. If small children live here or visit, this is the one kitchen cabinet that genuinely earns a latch.

STANDARDIZE 47 / 684

KITCHEN

Sink and Dishwashing Zone

Write down what good looks like.

Write the empty-sink standard on a card taped inside the cabinet door: dishes in the machine or washed, basin wiped, brush standing, towel hung. A standard is the best way you know today, written down.

SUSTAIN 48 / 684

KITCHEN

Sink and Dishwashing Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

Whoever switches the kitchen light off empties the basin and wipes it dry, two minutes, and that person is different every night, which is why the rule hangs on the switch rather than on a name. The morning tells you: one bowl left overnight is a full sink by tomorrow night, because a basin with something in it reads as ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

An empty sink with a dry basin and a wiped drain flange. One brush and one sponge standing upright where they drain rather than lying in a puddle. The drying rack either empty or holding only what is still ...

SORT 49 / 684

KITCHEN

Upper Cabinet Zone

Decide what stays.

Count the mugs, then count the people who drink from them. The conference giveaway, the chipped one, and the one nobody ever chooses off the shelf come out first, because chips and crazed glaze are the easy calls and they shorten the argument about the rest.

STRAIGHTEN 50 / 684

KITCHEN

Upper Cabinet Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Put dinner plates and everyday bowls at eye level on the side nearest the dishwasher or the table, glasses beside them, and send the serving platters and the punch bowl to the top shelf, where a step stool is an honest once-a-year cost.

SHINE 51 / 684

KITCHEN

Upper Cabinet Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Take each shelf completely empty before wiping, because the band of dust at the back is how you find out it has not been cleared in years. Wipe the underside of the cabinet nearest the stovetop, where a greasy film settles that you only see when you look at it from an angle.

SAFETY 52 / 684

KITCHEN

Upper Cabinet Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Heavy and breakable do not belong above head height. The stack of casserole dishes or the cast iron lid stored overhead is the one that eventually comes down on somebody, so move that weight low. Use a real step stool, never a chair edge and never an open drawer front.

STANDARDIZE 53 / 684

KITCHEN

Upper Cabinet Zone

Write down what good looks like.

Label the shelf edge rather than the contents: plates, bowls, glasses, mugs. Then anyone emptying the dishwasher can put things away correctly without asking you where they go.

SUSTAIN 54 / 684

KITCHEN

Upper Cabinet Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

Emptying the dishwasher is the check, done by whoever is emptying it, so the household audits this zone several times a week without an extra minute. The signal comes to your hand: a clean mug you cannot lift without moving another, or a plate with nowhere obvious to go. Either means the shelf is over its limit, and recovery is ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Everything used daily sits between shoulder and eye height, one category per stack, no plate stack more than about six high. Every mug can be lifted without moving another mug. The top shelf holds only what ...

SORT 55 / 684

KITCHEN

Lower Cabinet and Cookware Zone

Decide what stays.

Empty the entire cabinet onto the floor, which is the only way you will ever find the third saucepan and the wok bought for one weekend. Keep what actually cooked something in the past year. Nonstick worn through to the metal in the middle is not a spare, it is finished, and it goes to metal recycling rather than to the back of ...

STRAIGHTEN 56 / 684

KITCHEN

Lower Cabinet and Cookware Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Nest by size but cap any stack at three, with a cloth or a sheet of paper between coated surfaces. Lids stand in a rack or on a rail inside the door, and baking sheets go on edge in a divider so you stop lifting three to reach the fourth.

SHINE 57 / 684

KITCHEN

Lower Cabinet and Cookware Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Wipe the shelf floor itself, where oil creeps down from pan bases and holds dust into a tacky film that resists a dry cloth. While everything is out, twist every pan handle and tighten any rivet or screw that moves.

SAFETY 58 / 684

KITCHEN

Lower Cabinet and Cookware Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Keep the cast iron and the full stockpot on the cabinet floor, never above waist height, and lift them from a squat rather than bending over the open door. If a stack slides when the door is closed hard, it will one day land on a foot, so build the stack so it survives a slam.

STANDARDIZE 59 / 684

KITCHEN

Lower Cabinet and Cookware Zone

Write down what good looks like.

Size the divider slots to your actual pans and write the pan on the front edge of each slot, so the wide skillet slot cannot quietly become the place lids get dropped.

SUSTAIN 60 / 684

KITCHEN

Lower Cabinet and Cookware Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

When the pans come off the drying rack they go back into their named slots, done by whoever set them there to dry. The stovetop is the tell. A pan that sleeps on the burner is not laziness, it is a slot that costs a crouch to reach, and the pan is reporting that honestly. Recovery is changing the slot rather than the person ...

> **THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN**
> Every pan comes out and goes back in one motion. Pans nested no more than three deep or stood on edge in a divider, lids in a rack or on a door rail instead of loose, baking sheets standing on end, and the two ...

SORT 61 / 684

KITCHEN

Utensil and Utility Drawers

Decide what stays.

Tip one drawer at a time onto a dish towel and put back only what you have used since the season changed. Two can openers means one leaves. The takeout chopsticks, the rubber bands, the unlabeled key, and the loose batteries are not cooking tools and do not go back in.

STRAIGHTEN 62 / 684

KITCHEN

Utensil and Utility Drawers

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Dividers go in before anything else, and you name the drawer before you fill it. Flatware nearest the dishwasher, cooking tools nearest the stovetop, measuring spoons and the scale beside the baking cupboard, and wraps in the drawer you can pull open while holding a dish in your other hand.

SHINE 63 / 684

KITCHEN

Utensil and Utility Drawers

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Lift the insert right out and tip the grit, because the crumbs that jam a drawer collect underneath the divider and in the runner track. Wipe both runners and check that the drawer closes flush again before you refill it.

SAFETY 64 / 684

KITCHEN

Utensil and Utility Drawers

Fix what could hurt somebody.

The peeler, the mandoline blade, and the loose paring knife are exactly what your fingers meet when you rummage without looking. Give every blade a sheath, a sleeve, or its own shallow tray at the front where you see it before you reach past it.

STANDARDIZE 65 / 684

KITCHEN

Utensil and Utility Drawers

Write down what good looks like.

Write the name inside each drawer front: flatware, cooking tools, wraps and bags, utility. The name is the rule, and anything that does not match the name does not go in that drawer.

SUSTAIN 66 / 684

KITCHEN

Utensil and Utility Drawers

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

Putting the shopping away is the moment: the new roll of foil goes in on end, and anything that migrated into the wrong drawer travels back on the same pass. Whoever unpacks owns it, and it adds a minute. The signal reaches your hand daily, because a drawer that needs a second push holds more than its category allows. Recovery ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Each drawer has one job and a name written inside its front edge. Flatware sits in a divided insert with nothing loose beside it. Foil, cling film, and baking paper stand on end so you can read the boxes from ...

SORT 67 / 684

KITCHEN

Refrigerator and Freezer

Decide what stays.

Work one shelf at a time so nothing sits out warming while you decide. Anything frozen past recognition and unlabeled goes, and every opened jar, sauce, and dressing gets judged against the date on its lid rather than by smell, because dressings and sauces go on smelling fine long after they should have gone.

STRAIGHTEN 68 / 684

KITCHEN

Refrigerator and Freezer

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Raw proteins go on the lowest shelf, where a leaking package cannot drip onto anything below it. Dairy goes inside the body of the fridge rather than in the door, where the temperature swings every time it opens. Produce goes in the drawers with the humidity slider actually set, and the eat-first bin goes at the front at eye ...

SHINE 69 / 684

KITCHEN

Refrigerator and Freezer

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Pull the crisper drawers right out and wash them in the sink, because the sticky ring under a drawer is where a forgotten cucumber ended. Vacuum the condenser coils at the back or underneath, and wipe the door gasket in its folds, since a gasket usually fails from grime long before it fails from age.

SAFETY 70 / 684

KITCHEN

Refrigerator and Freezer

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Raw meat sealed and stored below ready-to-eat food is nearly the whole of cross contamination prevention in one move. Keep the rear vents clear so the compartment actually holds its temperature, and put a cheap thermometer on the middle shelf so you know what the fridge is running at instead of assuming.

STANDARDIZE 71 / 684

KITCHEN

Refrigerator and Freezer

Write down what good looks like.

A roll of tape and a marker live on top of the fridge, and nothing goes in without a name and a date on the lid. If it is not named and dated, it is not stored, it is abandoned.

SUSTAIN 72 / 684

KITCHEN

Refrigerator and Freezer

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

Writing the shopping list is the trigger, and the writer does it: empty the eat-first bin of anything past, then write the list from the gaps that leaves. Ten minutes, replacing a job you were doing anyway. Two signals read with the door open are an eat-first bin that is filling rather than emptying, and a container with no ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Raw meat sealed on the lowest shelf. Leftovers in clear containers at eye level, each with a name and a date on the lid. One bin marked for what must be eaten this week, sitting where the door opens straight ...

SORT 73 / 684

PANTRY

Dry Goods Shelves

Decide what stays.

Bring down every bag and box, open the ones already opened, and smell the flour and the oats. Stale, webbed, or bought for one recipe you cooked two summers ago means it leaves today.

STRAIGHTEN 74 / 684

PANTRY

Dry Goods Shelves

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Rice, pasta and oats go at chest height, in the arc your arm makes when you are already holding a pan. The specialty flours and the lentils you reach for once a month go on the shelf above, where standing on your toes is an honest signal about how often you use them.

SHINE 75 / 684

PANTRY

Dry Goods Shelves

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Empty the shelf, vacuum the corners and the front lip where flour dust settles, then wipe with mild soap and dry fully before anything returns. Damp shelf plus grain dust is how a pantry starts to smell.

SAFETY 76 / 684

PANTRY

Dry Goods Shelves

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Fall, cut, or crush: cereal boxes and heavy grain containers stacked above shoulder height come down on somebody's head the moment the bottom one is pulled. Heavy containers low, light boxes high, nothing stacked more than two deep.

STANDARDIZE 77 / 684

PANTRY

Dry Goods Shelves

Write down what good looks like.

One container style for staples, one label per container carrying the item and the date you opened it, so a low level and an old date both read from three steps away. "A standard is the best way you know today, written down."

SUSTAIN 78 / 684

PANTRY

Dry Goods Shelves

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

New stock loads in behind the open bag, never in front of it, at the moment the shopping is unpacked. Say that out loud to everyone who unpacks bags, including children, because one person loading from the front undoes a season of doing it right. Two open bags of the same thing is the signal, visible from the doorway. Recovery ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Every opened bag is either sealed in a container with its opening date written on it, or gone. Pasta, rice and oats stand as one block, breakfast cereal as another, and you can read the level in every ...

SORT 79 / 684

PANTRY

Canned and Jarred Goods

Decide what stays.

Take every can and jar out, turn each one until you find the date, and put the dented, rusted and bulging ones straight into the bin rather than back on the shelf. Then count duplicates, because four jars of the same pasta sauce is telling you exactly what you keep buying blind.

STRAIGHTEN 80 / 684

PANTRY

Canned and Jarred Goods

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Rows by meal rather than by size. Tomatoes, coconut milk and stock together because they cook together, beans and tuna together because they are lunch, and tall jars behind short cans so nothing disappears.

SHINE 81 / 684

PANTRY

Canned and Jarred Goods

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Wipe the sticky rings where a honey jar or a sauce lid has wept, and wash the threads of the jars you open most. A sticky shelf edge is how ants find their way to you.

SAFETY 82 / 684

PANTRY

Canned and Jarred Goods

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Poison, choke, or strangle: a can with a domed lid, a weeping seam, or a hiss as it opens is spoiled rather than merely old. It does not get tasted, decanted, or given to the dog. "Find it, and fix it now."

STANDARDIZE 83 / 684

PANTRY

Canned and Jarred Goods

Write down what good looks like.

Label each row with its category and put the back row up on a riser so it sits above the front row. Once you can read every label without moving a can, the gap where the chopped tomatoes used to be is your shopping list writing itself.

SUSTAIN 84 / 684

PANTRY

Canned and Jarred Goods

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

Before the shopping list gets written, walk the can rows and read the gaps. A missing tin of tomatoes is far easier to see on a shelf than to remember at a table, and the recycling trip is the smaller version anyone can do in passing. Slip reads instantly as a label turned away or a can standing in front of another. Recovery is ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Cans sit in rows on risers with every label facing you: tomatoes together, beans together, soup together. No dented seams, no domed lids, no jar hidden behind another jar, and the oldest date in each row ...

SORT 85 / 684

PANTRY

Baking Zone

Decide what stays.

Test the leaveners rather than guessing: a spoon of baking powder into hot water should fizz hard, and yeast in warm sugared water should foam. The dead ones go, along with the brick of hardened brown sugar and the cocoa that has turned gray.

STRAIGHTEN 86 / 684

PANTRY

Baking Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Build one lift-out bin holding flour, sugar, bicarb, vanilla and a scoop, so starting a bake is one trip to the shelf instead of six. Cutters and piping tips live in a second bin behind it, because they are the end of a bake and never the beginning.

SHINE 87 / 684

PANTRY

Baking Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Flour turns to paste under a damp cloth, so brush or vacuum the shelf dry first and wipe afterwards. Wash the scoop rather than burying it back in the flour between bakes.

SAFETY 88 / 684

PANTRY

Baking Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Poison, choke, or strangle: almond meal, nut flours and sesame share this shelf with everything else, and one shared scoop carries traces straight into a birthday cake. Give each allergen its own sealed container and its own scoop, and stand it at the end of the row where nobody grabs it by mistake.

STANDARDIZE 89 / 684

PANTRY

Baking Zone

Write down what good looks like.

Write the opening date on the lid of every leavener the day you open it, because the printed date stops meaning much once air is in the tin. The bin sits in the same spot with the same contents, so a missing scoop or an absent vanilla shows before the butter is out.

SUSTAIN 90 / 684

PANTRY

Baking Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

When the bake comes out to cool there is a natural wait, and that is the reset: scoop washed, flour topped up, bin back on its shelf, by whoever baked. Three minutes, inside a pause that was already yours. The scoop is the tell. If it is not in the bin, somebody borrowed from this zone for something that was not a bake, and the ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Flour, sugar and brown sugar in sealed containers you can open one-handed. Baking powder, bicarbonate of soda and yeast together in one small box with their dates showing. Cutters, cases and piping tips in a ...

SORT 91 / 684

PANTRY

Snack and Lunch Zone

Decide what stays.

Match every lid to a container and bin the orphans in both directions, the lidless tubs and the lids for tubs that died. Then pull the snack boxes with two bars rattling in the bottom, combine them, and flatten the empty cartons.

STRAIGHTEN 92 / 684

PANTRY

Snack and Lunch Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Pre-approved snacks go into an open bin the child can reach without a stool. The ones that start an argument go on the shelf above their eye line. Lunch bags and ice packs stand next to the containers rather than in a drawer in another room.

SHINE 93 / 684

PANTRY

Snack and Lunch Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Empty the bin and wipe it out, because crushed crackers and dried fruit-pouch drips collect in the bottom corners. Check every lunch bag for the sandwich nobody mentioned, and wash the liners.

SAFETY 94 / 684

PANTRY

Snack and Lunch Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Poison, choke, or strangle: whole nuts, hard sweets and grapes go straight from an open bin into a small mouth. Set the bin's contents by the youngest person in the house who can reach it, and think about a classmate's allergy before a nut bar goes into a shared lunch hall.

STANDARDIZE 95 / 684

PANTRY

Snack and Lunch Zone

Write down what good looks like.

The bin is the rule made visible. What is in it is allowed, what is not in it needs asking, and a photo taped inside the pantry door shows what a properly stocked bin looks like.

SUSTAIN 96 / 684

PANTRY

Snack and Lunch Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

When the lunchboxes are emptied in the evening, lids go back onto their containers and the bin gets filled to its marked line before anybody sits down. Filling to a line is a job a seven year old can own outright, about a minute. The line is also the signal: a bin below it in the morning means yesterday's refill did not happen ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

One open bin at child height holding only snacks you have already said yes to, and a higher shelf holding the ones that need an adult. Every reusable container has its own lid sitting on it, and the number of ...

SORT 97 / 684

PANTRY

Backstock and Bulk Zone

Decide what stays.

Open up the back of this zone and meet what you forgot you owned: the second sack of rice, the twelve-pack of a sauce nobody liked, the case of sparkling water from a party in another season. Anything you hold more than one spare of moves forward into the working shelves this month or it leaves.

STRAIGHTEN 98 / 684

PANTRY

Backstock and Bulk Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Weight decides height. Sacks and cases go on the floor or the bottom shelf on a board, paper towels and paper napkins go up top because they are light, and everything sits one row deep so you never move a case to see a case.

SHINE 99 / 684

PANTRY

Backstock and Bulk Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Sweep the floor of this zone and check the underside of the bottom case for damp, where a concrete floor or an outside wall is sweating. Cardboard that has gone soft is warning you about moisture before your food does.

SAFETY 100 / 684

PANTRY

Backstock and Bulk Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Fall, cut, or crush: a stacked column of cases is stable right up until somebody pulls the second one from the bottom. Stack no higher than your chest, bend at the knees for the rice sack, and never store a heavy case overhead where getting it down means catching it.

STANDARDIZE 101 / 684

PANTRY

Backstock and Bulk Zone

Write down what good looks like.

Write a maximum for each line on the shelf edge, two of this, one of that, and mark every pack with its arrival month as it goes in. Undated bulk is where the saving quietly expires out of sight.

SUSTAIN 102 / 684

PANTRY

Backstock and Bulk Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

The gap is the signal and the trip is the trigger. When a working container runs empty, its replacement comes off the front of backstock and the item goes on the list in the same movement, by the person who emptied it. No stock take, ever, and the writing costs twenty seconds. Slip is a pack stacked in front of another, or a ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Sacks of rice, cases of canned tomatoes and packs of paper towels, each written on with the month it arrived, all standing at or below waist height. A maximum number written on the shelf edge for each line ...

SORT 103 / 684

DINING ROOM

Dining Table

Decide what stays.

Clear the whole table onto the floor in one armful, then sort what came off by owner rather than by type. The homework, the unopened mail, and the half-finished craft project each go back to a person, not back to the table.

STRAIGHTEN 104 / 684

DINING ROOM

Dining Table

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Placemats, trivets, and the napkin basket belong in the nearest sideboard drawer, one step from where you set the table. Anything you find yourself carrying in from the kitchen twice a day is sleeping in the wrong drawer.

SHINE 105 / 684

DINING ROOM

Dining Table

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Run a fingernail down the leaf seam and the joint where the top meets the pedestal, because that is where crumbs collect and stay. Wipe the chair rungs and the underside lip of the table where hands grip it to pull a chair in.

SAFETY 106 / 684

DINING ROOM

Dining Table

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Lift and rock each chair to find a loose rung or a joint that has started working, and turn any chair that moves to face the wall so nobody sits on it before the joint is glued. Keep a trivet in the table's own drawer so a hot dish never lands on bare wood, and keep tall candles well clear of the runner ends.

STANDARDIZE 107 / 684

DINING ROOM

Dining Table

Write down what good looks like.

The centerpiece is the table's only permanent resident and its footprint is the boundary. Photograph the table both set and cleared, and tape both pictures inside the sideboard door so the right state is not something anyone has to remember.

SUSTAIN 108 / 684

DINING ROOM

Dining Table

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

When the plates go to the sink, the homework, the mail and the craft box ride in the same trip, carried by the people who ate. Nothing waits for a second journey, because a second journey does not happen. The test is laying a place: if you have to move something first, the table has stopped being a table. Recovery is giving ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

One centerpiece on bare wood and nothing else, every chair pushed all the way in with nothing hanging off its back, placemats and trivets in the sideboard drawer one step away, and no paper anywhere on the ...

SORT

109 / 684

DINING ROOM

Buffet or Sideboard Surface

Decide what stays.

Take everything off the wood, including the picture frames and the candlesticks, and give every piece of paper a verdict tonight: act on it, file it, or recycle it. Burnt-down candle stubs, dried flowers, and chargers belonging to other rooms leave now.

STRAIGHTEN

110 / 684

DINING ROOM

Buffet or Sideboard Surface

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Keep the end nearest the table entirely bare for setting dishes down, and group whatever display you keep at the far end near the lamp. Serving spoons and the trivet stack live in the top drawer directly beneath that bare end.

SHINE

111 / 684

DINING ROOM

Buffet or Sideboard Surface

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Lift each object rather than dusting around it, then work the wax drips off with a plastic card and gentle warmth, and treat the pale rings left by cold glasses. Dust behind the frames and along the back edge where the wall meets the wood.

SAFETY

112 / 684

DINING ROOM

Buffet or Sideboard Surface

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Trace the lamp cord from the shade to the outlet and count everything else sharing that plug, because a sideboard collects a lamp, a charger, and a warming tray on one socket hidden behind heavy furniture nobody pulls out. Move any candle sitting within arm's reach of a curtain or a wall hanging.

STANDARDIZE

113 / 684

DINING ROOM

Buffet or Sideboard Surface

Write down what good looks like.

The taped run stays bare, always, and the display group is three objects at most. If you cannot set the roasting pan down without moving something first, the standard has already slipped.

SUSTAIN

114 / 684

DINING ROOM

Buffet or Sideboard Surface

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

Nothing sleeps on this wood overnight except the lamp and the three display pieces, so the last thing off it each night is whatever arrived that day, removed by whoever set it down. The taped run is the gauge and it reads from across the room: if you could not set a roasting pan on it now, the standard has gone. Recovery is ...

> **THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN**
> A taped run of bare wood at the end nearest the table long enough for the roasting pan, three display objects grouped at the lamp end, no paper on the wood, and the lamp cord the only cord in sight.

SORT

115 / 684

DINING ROOM

Buffet or Sideboard Storage

Decide what stays.

Pull every tablecloth, runner, and napkin out and lay them across the table so you can see which sets are actually complete. Partial napkin sets, cloths with stains you have already tried and failed to lift, and serving pieces orphaned from sets you no longer own are finished.

STRAIGHTEN

116 / 684

DINING ROOM

Buffet or Sideboard Storage

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Give linens one drawer and serving pieces another, and stand the big platters on edge behind a divider so you stop lifting three to reach the fourth. Roll each cloth with its matching napkins inside it so one pull brings out everything the table needs.

SHINE

117 / 684

DINING ROOM

Buffet or Sideboard Storage

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Wipe the shelves and the drawer runners while they are empty, then smell the linens, because a musty note means something went away damp and needs rewashing before it goes back. Check the silver-plate serving pieces for tarnish while you can see all of them at once.

SAFETY 118 / 684

DINING ROOM

Buffet or Sideboard Storage

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Heavy stoneware platters and the punch bowl go on the lowest shelf and never above shoulder height, because they come down while your hands are already full. If taper candles and long matches live loose in a low drawer, move them to a latched drawer or a high shelf out of a child's reach.

STANDARDIZE 119 / 684

DINING ROOM

Buffet or Sideboard Storage

Write down what good looks like.

Tape a count card inside the door: two cloths, one runner, eight napkins, four serving spoons. A ninth napkin arriving as a gift means an older one becomes a rag that same evening.

SUSTAIN 120 / 684

DINING ROOM

Buffet or Sideboard Storage

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

A tablecloth out of the dryer goes back rolled with its napkins inside before it touches the back of a chair, done by whoever folds that load. The count card inside the door is a ten second check: four serving spoons on the card and three in the drawer means one is in a cupboard somewhere else. Recovery is finding that one ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Two tablecloths rolled with their matching napkins inside them in one drawer, serving bowls nested by size in the next, the large platters standing on edge behind a divider, taper candles of one length in a ...

SORT 121 / 684

DINING ROOM

China or Display Cabinet

Decide what stays.

Take every piece out and split it into three groups: complete sets, chipped or crazed pieces, and lone survivors of sets that are long gone. A chipped rim cannot be mended and is not safe to drink from, so that whole group leaves together.

STRAIGHTEN 122 / 684

DINING ROOM

China or Display Cabinet

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Tureens and heavy serving pieces on the bottom shelf, plates and bowls at hand height, ceremonial pieces up top. Stack plates no more than eight high with felt or a paper plate between them, and stand cups single file instead of nesting them into each other.

SHINE 123 / 684

DINING ROOM

China or Display Cabinet

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Wash by hand in a plastic basin with a towel in the bottom, never the dishwasher for gilt rims or hand painting, and dry each piece straight away rather than leaving it to drain. Clean the cabinet glass inside and out and wipe the shelf liners while the shelves are bare.

SAFETY 124 / 684

DINING ROOM

China or Display Cabinet

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Strap the cabinet to a wall stud, because a tall glass-fronted case loaded with plates is the heaviest tip-over risk in this room and its shelves are the right shape for a child to climb. Do not serve food or drink from decorative antique or hand-painted pieces of unknown origin, since older glazes can carry lead.

STANDARDIZE 125 / 684

DINING ROOM

China or Display Cabinet

Write down what good looks like.

Photograph the finished shelves and tape the picture inside the door so the china goes back the same way after every holiday. When a shelf no longer matches its photo, something is missing or broken and you find out that day rather than next Christmas.

SUSTAIN 126 / 684

DINING ROOM

China or Display Cabinet

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

After any meal that used the good china it is hand-washed, dried and back behind the glass before the kitchen light goes off, which is the host's job rather than the morning's and, for six settings, twenty minutes at the sink. The photo inside the door is the check, so a shelf that no longer matches it means something is ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Plates stacked no more than eight high with felt between them, cups standing single file rather than nested, glasses rim up on a clean liner, tureens on the bottom shelf, the cabinet strapped to a wall stud ...

SORT 127 / 684

DINING ROOM

Beverage or Coffee Station

Decide what stays.

Line up every tea box, syrup bottle, and pod sleeve and check the dates, then open the travel mugs and match them to their lids. Anything past date, any mug missing its lid, and the promotional glassware you have never once poured into are out.

STRAIGHTEN 128 / 684

DINING ROOM

Beverage or Coffee Station

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Set the station in the order your hands actually move: machine, then grounds or pods, then mugs, then spoons and sugar, then the way out toward the table. Leave a hand's width behind the kettle so its steam is not hitting the underside of a shelf.

SHINE 129 / 684

DINING ROOM

Beverage or Coffee Station

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Descale the machine on the interval its manual gives, lift the drip tray grate and wash underneath it where mold starts, and get the sticky ring from under the syrup bottle. Rinse the kettle and look at the element for scale while you are there.

SAFETY 130 / 684

DINING ROOM

Beverage or Coffee Station

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Water and electricity share this counter, so give the machine and kettle their own outlet, keep cords back from the edge where a sleeve can hook them, and never refill a plugged-in machine over its own base. If wine or spirits live here, they belong behind a latch or high up, not on an open shelf at a child's eye level.

STANDARDIZE 131 / 684

DINING ROOM

Beverage or Coffee Station

Write down what good looks like.

Mugs are capped at daily drinkers plus two, and the bean or pod jar carries a marked fill line that tells you when to buy more. Everything sits on one tray you can lift with one hand, so the counter underneath cleans in a single wipe.

SUSTAIN 132 / 684

DINING ROOM

Beverage or Coffee Station

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

The reset happens while the coffee is already brewing, by whoever is first up: wipe the tray, top the bean jar to its marked line. Forty seconds inside a wait that was happening anyway. Two signals need no touching, a jar below its line and mugs standing outside the tray because the cap has been passed. Recovery is one wipe and ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Machine, grounds, mugs, then spoons and sugar running left to right along one liftable tray, mugs capped at the number of daily drinkers plus two, a marked fill line on the bean jar, and a hand's width of ...

SORT 133 / 684

LIVING ROOM

Sofa and Seating Zone

Decide what stays.

Pull everything off the seats and dig the seams out: the laundry that migrated here, the second and third throw blanket, the magazines wedged behind the armrest, the coins and hair ties down the back. Sort into leaves-the-room, goes-in-the-wash, and lives-here.

STRAIGHTEN 134 / 684

LIVING ROOM

Sofa and Seating Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

The remotes get one tray, and it goes on the arm people actually reach from while sitting, not the arm nearest the television. Throws get one basket at the end of the sofa, and reading matter gets one slot, so nothing has to be lifted off a cushion before someone sits.

SHINE 135 / 684

LIVING ROOM

Sofa and Seating Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Vacuum the seams and the deck under the cushions with the upholstery tool, then wipe the arms and the headrest where hands and hair oil land. Rotate and flip the cushions so the seat nobody chooses takes a turn at the wear.

SAFETY 136 / 684

LIVING ROOM

Sofa and Seating Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Check the recliner footrest and the sofa bed hinge, and make it a rule that both close slowly with a look at the floor first, because that is where a child sits. Throws that trail off the sofa onto the floor are what people step on when they stand up in the dark, so the basket keeps them off the walkway.

STANDARDIZE 137 / 684

LIVING ROOM

Sofa and Seating Zone

Write down what good looks like.

Put the rule on the basket label itself: throws folded into the basket, nothing stored on a seat. "A standard is the best way you know today, written down."

SUSTAIN 138 / 684

LIVING ROOM

Sofa and Seating Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

The last person out at night squares the cushions and drops the throws in the basket. It takes the length of turning the lamp off, and it belongs to whoever is turning it, because the last one out is different every night. The signal is a seat: if somebody cannot sit down without lifting something first, the room has failed at ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Every seat on the sofa and every armchair is sittable without lifting a single thing off it. Throws folded to one size in one basket, at most one cushion per seat left in place, and both remotes in the tray on ...

SORT 139 / 684

LIVING ROOM

Coffee Table

Decide what stays.

Clear the whole top onto the floor and put back only what somebody used in the last two days. The candle burned down to the foil, the coasters nobody uses because they sit on the far corner, the three-month-old magazines and the takeout menus all go now.

STRAIGHTEN 140 / 684

LIVING ROOM

Coffee Table

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

The tray sets the table's entire standing inventory. Coasters go on it within arm's reach of whoever sits on the sofa, so a mug lands on a coaster without anyone leaning across the table.

SHINE 141 / 684

LIVING ROOM

Coffee Table

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Lift the tray and wipe the whole top including the ring marks, then get the underside edge and the lower shelf where crumbs and dust collect unseen. A glass top needs two passes, one for grease and one dry, or every fingerprint shows by lamplight.

SAFETY 142 / 684

LIVING ROOM

Coffee Table

Fix what could hurt somebody.

A glass top or a hard square corner sits at exactly the height of a toddler's forehead, so corner guards or a different table is the real fix, not vigilance. A candle here is surrounded by throws, magazines and paper, which is the wrong neighborhood for an open flame.

STANDARDIZE 143 / 684

LIVING ROOM

Coffee Table

Write down what good looks like.

Photograph the finished tray and tape the print inside the media cabinet door, so clear stops being one person's opinion about this table. The tray is the written rule made physical: four coasters, the remote actually in use, and at most one book or one plant beside it. Nothing has been banned from the room, it simply lives ...

SUSTAIN 144 / 684

LIVING ROOM

Coffee Table

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

Whoever carries the last mug to the kitchen takes everything else that does not belong with them, in the same trip, and there is never a second one. The tray does the judging so nobody has to argue: if it does not fit on the tray, it does not live on the table. Slip shows as the surface disappearing, noticed from the doorway ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

One tray holding four coasters and the remote in use, plus at most one book or one plant beside it. No mugs, no charging cables, no post, and the wood or glass showing across most of the top.

SORT 145 / 684

LIVING ROOM

Media Center

Decide what stays.

Unplug and lay out every cable, then name the device each one serves. The composite leads, the disc player nobody has loaded in a year, the streaming stick from two televisions ago and the charger with the old connector all leave. Discs and games get one decision each: sell, lend, or recycle.

STRAIGHTEN 146 / 684

LIVING ROOM

Media Center

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Bundle the cables by device path with velcro ties so one console can be pulled out without disturbing the sound bar. Controllers and remotes get one ventilated bin, set at the height of whoever plays, not on top of the unit where they slide behind it.

SHINE 147 / 684

LIVING ROOM

Media Center

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Vacuum the dust off the console and amplifier vents and the whole back panel of the television, because dust is what turns a warm device into a hot one. Wipe the screen with a dry microfiber cloth only, never a spray.

SAFETY 148 / 684

LIVING ROOM

Media Center

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Heat and power are the two hazards behind this unit: keep the vents unblocked, never run one power strip into another, and look at every cable for a cracked or scorched section as you handle it. Anchor the television to the wall or to the unit, because a screen tipping off the front edge is the single worst thing this room can ...

STANDARDIZE 149 / 684

LIVING ROOM

Media Center

Write down what good looks like.

Label both ends of a cable the day it goes in and label the strip's outlets to match, so a cable that belongs to nothing is obvious at a glance. See Chapter 14, visual controls.

SUSTAIN 150 / 684

LIVING ROOM

Media Center

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

The rule fires on an event rather than a clock: nothing gets switched on until its cable is labeled at both ends, by whoever plugged it in. Two minutes with a marker while the bundle is already in your hand. Slip is one unnamed cable at the strip, worth chasing because an unnamed cable usually feeds something the house no ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Every cable labeled at both ends, running in one bundle to a single labeled power strip. Nothing plugged in that serves a device you no longer own, a clear hand's gap of air around the amplifier and console ...

SORT 151 / 684

LIVING ROOM

Bookshelves and Display

Decide what stays.

Take one shelf down at a time so every book passes through your hands. Duplicates, the manuals for appliances you replaced, the free paperbacks from a conference and anything water-damaged go now. Empty frames, the dead plant and the souvenirs you stopped seeing years ago go with them.

STRAIGHTEN 152 / 684

LIVING ROOM

Bookshelves and Display

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Group by how you actually hunt for a book, which for most people is subject first and author second, never color. The heavy art and reference volumes go on the bottom shelves where a fall does no harm, and the hand's width of slack at the end of each shelf is where the next book lands.

SHINE 153 / 684

LIVING ROOM

Bookshelves and Display

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Dust the top edges of the books themselves, not just the shelf boards, and wipe the shelf fronts where hands grab to pull a spine out. Do the very top of the tallest unit, which is where this room's dust actually settles and where nobody ever looks.

SAFETY 154 / 684

LIVING ROOM

Bookshelves and Display

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Strap the unit into the wall studs, because a tall bookcase loaded high will come over when a child uses the shelves as a ladder, and it lands loaded. Keep the stone and glass objects on the lowest shelves, and use a step, never the arm of the sofa, to reach the top.

STANDARDIZE 155 / 684

LIVING ROOM

Bookshelves and Display

Write down what good looks like.

Bookends plus a small labeled marker at the front of each group makes a misfiled book visible from the doorway, without pulling a single spine out.

SUSTAIN 156 / 684

LIVING ROOM

Bookshelves and Display

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

When you finish a book it goes back into its group that same evening, put there by whoever read it, which keeps the shelf honest without anyone auditing it. The slack is the signal, a hand's width of empty shelf at the end of every row, and the first row to lose it is the row to work on. Books lying flat on top of standing ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Each shelf has a hand's width of empty space at one end, books standing upright between bookends with nothing stacked flat on top of them, frames and objects gathered in two or three groups instead of spaced ...

SORT 157 / 684

LIVING ROOM

Side Tables and Lighting

Decide what stays.

Empty the little dish and the drawer onto the seat of the chair. The reading glasses with the wrong prescription, the dried-out pens, the foreign coins, the loose tablets, the charger for a phone nobody in the house owns and the coasters that never made it back to the coffee table each get a verdict now.

STRAIGHTEN 158 / 684

LIVING ROOM

Side Tables and Lighting

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

One tray per table sets the limit, and it sits on the side the person in that chair reaches from without leaning. The phone charger gets a single clip at the table edge so the cable stays up on the table instead of hanging into the walkway.

SHINE 159 / 684

LIVING ROOM

Side Tables and Lighting

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Wipe the bulb and the inside of the shade while the lamp is off and cool, then the table top and the ring marks hiding under the tray. A dusty bulb throws noticeably less light, and light is the whole reason this table has a lamp on it.

SAFETY 160 / 684

LIVING ROOM

Side Tables and Lighting

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Water and electricity meet here more than anywhere else in the room, so the glass goes on the opposite side of the tray from the lamp base and the charger. Loose tablets in an open dish sit at chair height, which is grab height for a toddler, and the lamp cord must never cross the path between the chair and the door.

STANDARDIZE 161 / 684

LIVING ROOM

Side Tables and Lighting

Write down what good looks like.

Four items on the tray is the rule, and it holds because a fifth thing has nowhere to sit but the bare table top, where you can see it from the doorway.

SUSTAIN 162 / 684

LIVING ROOM

Side Tables and Lighting

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

Plugging your phone in for the night is the moment whatever does not belong on the side table travels to its own room with you. Each table belongs to whoever sits in that chair, which matters here more than anywhere else. The fifth item announces itself, because the tray holds four and a fifth has nowhere to sit but bare wood ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

One small tray per table with no more than four items on it, a coaster under the glass, a bulb that lights and has been wiped, and the lamp cord clipped down the table leg so no cable crosses the floor to the ...

SORT

163 / 684

LIVING ROOM

Floor and Circulation Path

Decide what stays.

Walk the route with a laundry basket and put every floor item in it: shoes, toys, yesterday's bag, the pile of post, the box that has sat beside the sofa for a month. Anything belonging to another room gets carried there before you let yourself sit down.

STRAIGHTEN

164 / 684

LIVING ROOM

Floor and Circulation Path

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Floor baskets go against a wall or under the side table, never in the route, and each one gets a named category so it does not turn into a bin nobody empties. The route itself is permanently off limits for storage, including "just for tonight".

SHINE

165 / 684

LIVING ROOM

Floor and Circulation Path

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Vacuum the route, then move the sofa and chair legs and do underneath, because that is where pet hair and dust build up out of sight. Shake or vacuum the rug on both sides and press the gripper pad to check it is still tacky.

SAFETY

166 / 684

LIVING ROOM

Floor and Circulation Path

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Curled rug corners, the lamp cord crossing the route and toys left in the dark are the three falls this room produces, and they happen at night to whoever is up first. Keep the route to the door clear at its full width in case you ever have to leave the house in a hurry. "Find it, and fix it now."

STANDARDIZE

167 / 684

LIVING ROOM

Floor and Circulation Path

Write down what good looks like.

Full width, always, and you check it by walking the route with a full basket in both hands rather than by standing in the doorway looking at it.

SUSTAIN

168 / 684

LIVING ROOM

Floor and Circulation Path

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

When the vacuum comes out, anything still on the floor at the end goes into the basket and gets returned before the vacuum is put away, by whoever ran it. Checking is not done from the doorway: walk the route with a full basket in both hands, and if you have to turn sideways, the path has gone. Recovery is the basket trip, five ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

A continuous clear route from the doorway past the sofa to the other exit, wide enough for two people to pass and for the vacuum to run through without being lifted. Rug edges lying flat on a grippy pad, no ...

SORT

169 / 684

FAMILY ROOM

Primary Media Zone

Decide what stays.

Pull every disc case, spare remote, headset, and loose cable out of the cabinet onto the floor. Anything that pairs with a console or a television you no longer own leaves today, and that usually includes two or three remotes you have been keeping in case.

STRAIGHTEN

170 / 684

FAMILY ROOM

Primary Media Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Give each console its own shelf with the controllers and headset that belong to it, and stand disc cases upright in one row instead of stacking them flat where the bottom four become unreachable.

SHINE

171 / 684

FAMILY ROOM

Primary Media Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Brush the vent slots on each console and the back panel of the television with a vacuum brush head, wipe the controller grips and thumbstick collars with a barely damp cloth, and finish the screen with a dry microfiber cloth only.

SAFETY 172 / 684

FAMILY ROOM

Primary Media Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Put your hand on the television and push gently. If it rocks, the anti-tip strap or the mount bolts need attention before you touch anything else in this room. Then move the power strip off the carpet and out of the line people walk between the sofa and the door.

STANDARDIZE 173 / 684

FAMILY ROOM

Primary Media Zone

Write down what good looks like.

While the cabinet is open, label both ends of every cable, and tape a small card inside the cabinet door listing which controller and which headset belong to which console.

SUSTAIN 174 / 684

FAMILY ROOM

Primary Media Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

When the credits roll, controllers go back on their dock and remotes into the tray before the television goes off, done by whoever was holding them. The dock reports its own slip: an empty cradle means a controller is loose in the house, and you look now rather than at the start of the next game. Recovery is finding that one ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

One console per shelf with its own controllers docked beside it, disc cases standing spine out in a single row, every cable labeled at both ends, the power strip off the carpet, and nothing resting on top of a ...

SORT 175 / 684

FAMILY ROOM

Toy and Play Zone

Decide what stays.

Tip every bin out onto the mat and make four piles: played with this month, broken, missing its other half, and outgrown. Anything with a cracked seam, a corroded battery compartment, or a missing wheel gets repaired today or leaves today, because it will not get repaired later.

STRAIGHTEN 176 / 684

FAMILY ROOM

Toy and Play Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

One category per open bin, no lids, all on the lowest shelf: blocks, vehicles, dolls and figures, pretend food, art toys. A lid is one more step than a four-year-old will take at the end of a play session.

SHINE 177 / 684

FAMILY ROOM

Toy and Play Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Wash hard plastic toys in mild soapy water and dry them fully, because a damp block goes back into a closed bin and stays damp. Fabric dolls and soft blocks go through the machine in a wash bag, and the play mat gets lifted so you can vacuum the crumbs underneath it.

SAFETY 178 / 684

FAMILY ROOM

Toy and Play Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

For any child under three in the house, hold each small part against the middle of a toilet paper tube. If it passes through, that toy belongs in the older child's room, not in a bin at floor height in the shared room. Keep the tallest bin below the child's shoulder so nothing gets pulled down onto a face.

STANDARDIZE 179 / 684

FAMILY ROOM

Toy and Play Zone

Write down what good looks like.

Photo labels on the bin fronts, and one printed picture of the finished shelf taped at child eye height on the wall beside it. Match the picture is an instruction a five-year-old can follow without an adult refereeing.

SUSTAIN 180 / 684

FAMILY ROOM

Toy and Play Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

Pickup is bought, not asked for. The story starts when the mat is empty, so the children clear while an adult holds the book, five minutes in a room this size. The bins are a gauge a child can read, because a bin that will not take its category back with the lid off has outgrown the shelf. Recovery is rotating one whole ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Five or six open bins with no lids on the lowest shelf, one category each, a photo of the contents taped to the front face where a child looking down sees it, the play mat rolled against the wall, and enough ...

SORT 181 / 684

FAMILY ROOM

Board Game and Puzzle Zone

Decide what stays.

Open every box and count the pieces against the list printed on the rules sheet. Cards, tokens, and dice go into their own bags inside the box. A game you cannot finish counting is a game you cannot finish playing, and it leaves the shelf until it is settled.

STRAIGHTEN 182 / 684

FAMILY ROOM

Board Game and Puzzle Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Games lie flat and stack by height, heaviest at the bottom, tallest boxes on the lower shelf. Puzzles get their own short stack, because they are the ones that come down most often and go back least carefully.

SHINE 183 / 684

FAMILY ROOM

Board Game and Puzzle Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Wipe the box lids and edges, which pick up a surprising film in a room where people eat. Check for soft or bowed corners on the bottom boxes, and shorten any stack that is crushing the box beneath it.

SAFETY 184 / 684

FAMILY ROOM

Board Game and Puzzle Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Dice, tokens, and the small metal pieces from older games are exactly toddler-mouth sized, and this floor is shared with the play mat. Keep game boxes above the reach of the youngest child in the house, and never park a heavy stack on the highest shelf where it comes down on a face.

STANDARDIZE 185 / 684

FAMILY ROOM

Board Game and Puzzle Zone

Write down what good looks like.

Tape on the short edge with the name, plus a date written on the lid the last time the box passed a count. Anyone can see at a glance which boxes are verified and which are due.

SUSTAIN 186 / 684

FAMILY ROOM

Board Game and Puzzle Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

The count happens as the box goes back, not as it comes out, done by whoever played. Two minutes at the end of a game instead of ruining the start of the next one. The lids carry the dates, so slip reads from the doorway: a box with no date, or an old one, has not been verified since. Recovery is counting that one box and ...

> **THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN**
> Boxes lying flat in stacks no more than five high, each with a strip of tape on the short edge naming the game so you can read it from the doorway, every loose piece bagged inside its own lid, and not one box ...

SORT 187 / 684

FAMILY ROOM

Blanket and Comfort Zone

Decide what stays.

Hold every throw up to the window light. Pilled through, thinned along the fold lines, or holding a smell that survives washing: those become car blankets, pet bedding, or rags, and they leave this room today.

STRAIGHTEN 188 / 684

FAMILY ROOM

Blanket and Comfort Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

One basket, and the rim is the limit. Fold every throw to the same rectangle so the stack squares up and anyone can see at a glance whether one has gone missing or one too many has crept in.

SHINE 189 / 684

FAMILY ROOM

Blanket and Comfort Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Wash everything in the basket, including the throws that look clean, because this is where pet hair and popcorn oil concentrate. Vacuum the basket's inside corners before the clean throws go back.

SAFETY 190 / 684

FAMILY ROOM

Blanket and Comfort Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Look at where blankets end up when nobody is folding them. A throw laid over a radiator, across a floor heater, or hung on a lamp shade is the quiet fire risk in this room, and the basket rule exists partly to keep them off those surfaces.

STANDARDIZE 191 / 684

FAMILY ROOM

Blanket and Comfort Zone

Write down what good looks like.

The count is one throw per regular seat plus one spare. Write that number on a small label inside the basket rim, so whoever is folding can see the rule without being told it.

SUSTAIN 192 / 684

FAMILY ROOM

Blanket and Comfort Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

When the last lamp goes off, whatever is on the sofa gets folded and dropped in the basket on the way past, by whoever is turning it off. The fold is the point, to one rectangle, so the count stays readable. Anything draped over a radiator, a chair arm or the sofa back is the slip signal, visible without opening anything ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

One basket holding four throws folded to the same rectangle so the fold edges line up, two floor cushions stacked beside it, and nothing draped over the sofa back, the radiator, or the arm of a chair.

SORT 193 / 684

FAMILY ROOM

Charging and Device Zone

Decide what stays.

Lay every cable and plug out in a line and match each one to a device that is in this house and currently working. What is left unmatched is not spare, it is dead weight, and it goes to an electronics recycling point rather than back into the drawer.

STRAIGHTEN 194 / 684

FAMILY ROOM

Charging and Device Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

One strip, one slot per device, the owner's name on the slot. Shorten each cable to the length that just reaches its slot, then clip the excess so the ends stay up on the surface instead of hanging toward the floor.

SHINE 195 / 684

FAMILY ROOM

Charging and Device Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Wipe each cable end and check the last few centimetres near the plug, where the sheath cracks first. Blow or brush the lint out of the charging ports, because packed lint is why a plug stops seating properly long before the cable is actually broken.

SAFETY 196 / 684

FAMILY ROOM

Charging and Device Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Nothing charges on a cushion, a blanket, or a stack of paper. Lithium batteries need air, and a battery pack that is swollen, bulging at the seam, or too hot to hold is a stop now situation, not a weekend job. Put your hand on every device on the station once during this pass.

STANDARDIZE 197 / 684

FAMILY ROOM

Charging and Device Zone

Write down what good looks like.

Name labels on the slots, not just on the cables, so an empty slot reads as a missing device rather than as free space. Keep the strip itself in view instead of pushed behind furniture, where a scorched socket or a chewed cable would go unnoticed.

SUSTAIN 198 / 684

FAMILY ROOM

Charging and Device Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

When the dishwasher is started for the night, devices come to the station and stay until morning, called by the adult who starts the machine. The named slots do the auditing, because an empty slot at bedtime reads as a missing device rather than free space. Recovery is fetching that device, thirty seconds. The failure to watch ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

One power strip on a hard surface, four or five labeled cables each ending at a named slot, the empty slots visible during the day, and no charger plugged into any other socket in the room.

SORT 199 / 684

FAMILY ROOM

Craft and Activity Zone

Decide what stays.

Test every marker on a scrap of paper, because the cap tells you nothing and the scrap tells you everything. Throw the dried glue sticks, the paint that has separated and will not stir back together, and any kit whose instruction sheet is gone and cannot be found online.

STRAIGHTEN 200 / 684

FAMILY ROOM

Craft and Activity Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Pack the bins by what gets made, not by what the material is, so the drawing bin holds paper, pencils, and the sharpener together rather than sending a child to three shelves. One lidded bin lifts out and carries to the table in one hand, and goes back the same way.

SHINE 201 / 684

FAMILY ROOM

Craft and Activity Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Scrape dried glue and paint off the work surface with a plastic scraper before you wipe, get into the cracks where glitter sits, and stand the brushes bristle up so they dry without bending.

SAFETY 202 / 684

FAMILY ROOM

Craft and Activity Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

The glue gun is the real hazard here. It has no obvious off signal, its tip stays hot long after the last bead, and it gets left plugged in on a surface a child can reach. Give it a fixed cooling spot on a hard tile and unplug it before you clean up, not after. Keep the craft knife, the seed beads, and anything solvent based on ...

STANDARDIZE 203 / 684

FAMILY ROOM

Craft and Activity Zone

Write down what good looks like.

One project out at a time, and the label on the front of each lidded bin names what it makes rather than what it holds. That rule is what stops the work surface from filling.

SUSTAIN 204 / 684

FAMILY ROOM

Craft and Activity Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

When the table is being set for dinner, the open project bin closes and goes back on the shelf, whatever state the project is in, by whoever opened it. One project out at a time is the whole standard, so two open bins is the slip and you can count it from the door. Recovery is closing one, seconds, and genuinely allowed even ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Four lidded, labeled bins (paper and card, drawing, glue and tape, kits in progress), scissors standing point down in a cup out of the youngest child's reach, one completely clear work surface, and exactly one ...

SORT 205 / 684

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Bed and Bedding Zone

Decide what stays.

Strip the bed and pull out everything underneath it. Sheets worn thin at the hip, blankets gone pilled and scratchy, and pillows that stay folded in half when you bend them are finished; they leave as rags or textile recycling, not as spares for a guest who never comes.

STRAIGHTEN 206 / 684

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Bed and Bedding Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Store each sheet set folded inside one of its own pillowcases so the flat sheet and the fitted sheet stop traveling separately, and keep this bed's linen on one shelf instead of stacked in with guest doubles and kid singles.

SHINE 207 / 684

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Bed and Bedding Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

With the mattress bare, vacuum the whole surface and the seam where the protector tucks under, then run the vacuum head down behind the headboard where dust and hair pack against the wall.

SAFETY 208 / 684

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Bed and Bedding Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Nothing goes under the bed that sticks out into the strip of floor you cross in the dark, and nothing heavy sits on a headboard shelf directly above where your head rests.

STANDARDIZE 209 / 684

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Bed and Bedding Zone

Write down what good looks like.

Write down what a made bed means in this house, down to how many pillows go on and whether the duvet is folded back or pulled flat, so it looks the same on the mornings you do it and the mornings someone else does. A standard is the best way you know today, written down.

SUSTAIN 210 / 684

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Bed and Bedding Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

Make the bed before you leave the room, while the duvet is still thrown back and it takes one pull. In a two person bed it belongs to whoever gets up second, worth agreeing out loud once rather than negotiating every morning. The cover is the signal: a made bed holds the agreed pillows and nothing else, so folded laundry on it ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Bed made the same way every morning: fitted sheet, flat sheet or duvet, two sleeping pillows per person, one throw folded at the foot. Two complete sheet sets for this bed, one on it and one folded on the ...

SORT 211 / 684

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Nightstand Left

Decide what stays.

Empty the drawer onto the bed. Dead pens, chargers for phones you no longer own, hotel earplugs still in their wrappers, and the four books you started and put down all go. A book you are not reading this week belongs on the shelf, not beside your head.

STRAIGHTEN 212 / 684

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Nightstand Left

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Divide the drawer so glasses, lip balm and earplugs each sit in their own section instead of sliding into one heap, and clip the lamp and clock cords down the back leg so nothing loops across the top.

SHINE 213 / 684

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Nightstand Left

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Lift everything off, wipe the top including the ring the water glass has been leaving, then wash the lampshade and the bulb so your reading light is the brightness you actually paid for.

SAFETY 214 / 684

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Nightstand Left

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Water and a power strip do not share this surface. Move the strip off the nightstand top and onto the floor behind it, and if you drink in bed, drink from a bottle with a lid.

STANDARDIZE 215 / 684

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Nightstand Left

Write down what good looks like.

Five things or fewer on the top, countable from the doorway. When a sixth turns up it is almost always a finished book or an empty glass; the book goes to the shelf and the glass goes to the kitchen that night.

SUSTAIN 216 / 684

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Nightstand Left

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

When you reach over to switch off the lamp, put the top back to five before your hand comes back. This side is yours alone and it takes seconds. Five is countable from the doorway, so slip needs no inspection, and the sixth item is almost always a finished book or an empty glass. The book goes to the shelf and the glass to the ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

On top: lamp, a lidded bottle or a coaster, one book, and a small dish holding your glasses. Five things or fewer, with no cable crossing the surface. The drawer has three divided sections with room left in ...

SORT 217 / 684

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Nightstand Right

Decide what stays.

You do not empty this drawer. Bring a bin liner and a box into the room, finish your own side first so there is something to look at, then ask whether they want the same. What they hand you goes. What they keep stays, and you say nothing about it.

STRAIGHTEN 218 / 684

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Nightstand Right

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Agree on the shared edge only: the floor beside this nightstand stays clear because you both walk past it, and the lamp cord runs down the leg for the same reason. What fills the drawer is entirely theirs.

SHINE 219 / 684

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Nightstand Right

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Dust the top, wipe the lamp base and the switch, and vacuum the slot between the nightstand and the bed frame where tissues, hairbands and dust collect where neither of you looks.

SAFETY 220 / 684

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Nightstand Right

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Medication is the one exception to leaving this side alone. Check the dates together, screw the caps down properly, and if a child or a dog gets up onto this bed, move tablets out of the open drawer into a closed box.

STANDARDIZE 221 / 684

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Nightstand Right

Write down what good looks like.

Match the standard, not the contents. Both tops run the same item count and the same lidded drink rule, and what fills each drawer is each sleeper's own business.

SUSTAIN 222 / 684

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Nightstand Right

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

When the sheets come off, both nightstand tops get cleared and wiped in the same pass by whoever is stripping the bed, so one side cannot drift while the other holds. What gets checked is the count and the lidded drink rule, never the drawer, which belongs to whoever sleeps there. Slip is a number rather than a judgment: two ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

The top is clear enough to set a mug down without moving anything first, the lamp cord runs behind the leg rather than across the floor beside the bed, and any medication in the drawer is in date, capped, and ...

SORT 223 / 684

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Dresser Top

Decide what stays.

Work through the pocket sediment: loose change into a jar that lives in another room, receipts binned or photographed, single earrings and snapped chains into one small bag you either take to a repair counter this month or let go. Jewelry you love but never put on moves to a box in the closet, not back onto this top.

STRAIGHTEN 224 / 684

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Dresser Top

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

One tray, and everything that comes out of your pockets at night lands inside it. Fragrance gets its own dish so the bottles stop wandering, and folded clothes never rest here on the way to the drawer.

SHINE 225 / 684

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Dresser Top

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Take the tray and the bottles off, wipe the top, and work at the sticky ring under the fragrance where the sprayer has been misting the wood for years. Wipe the drawer fronts and the handles while the top is bare.

SAFETY 226 / 684

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Dresser Top

Fix what could hurt somebody.

A tall chest of drawers that is not strapped to the wall tips forward when a loaded drawer is open and a child leans on it. Fit an anti-tip strap into a stud, and keep the glass bottles back from the edge so they cannot be knocked onto a hard floor.

STANDARDIZE 227 / 684

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Dresser Top

Write down what good looks like.

The tray is the edge. If the keys, wallet, watch and rings will not sit in it without stacking, thin the keyring or move a ring to the jewelry box rather than starting a second pile beside the tray.

SUSTAIN 228 / 684

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Dresser Top

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

When you empty your pockets at night, everything goes into the tray and nothing goes down beside it. That is the whole habit, it belongs to whoever the pockets are, and it costs no time. The tray is the edge, so slip is obvious: one receipt or one spare set of keys on bare wood, which is how a second pile starts every time ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

One valet tray holding keys, wallet, watch and rings, with nothing sitting outside it. Fragrance bottles grouped on a small dish, set back from the front edge. No folded laundry, no receipts, no loose coins on ...

SORT 229 / 684

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Dresser Drawers

Decide what stays.

Tip one drawer at a time onto the bed. Out go socks whose partners never turned up, waistbands that have given up, the six workout tops you own when you wear two, and the t-shirts from events you no longer think about. Anything stained or holed becomes a rag or textile recycling rather than a donation somebody else has to bin.

STRAIGHTEN 230 / 684

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Dresser Drawers

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Fold everything so it stands on its edge and the drawer reads like a row of files instead of a stack you excavate. Put dividers in for socks and underwear so the small things stop sliding under the folded rows, and move the heaviest categories, jeans and knitwear, into the bottom drawers.

SHINE 231 / 684

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Dresser Drawers

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Empty each drawer completely, vacuum the corners and the runners, wipe the base, and let it dry before anything goes back in. While it is out, check the runners and tighten any screw that has worked loose.

SAFETY 232 / 684

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Dresser Drawers

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Open one drawer at a time. Two loaded drawers out together pulls the weight far enough forward to tip the whole chest, and a child using the open drawers as steps does it faster.

STANDARDIZE 233 / 684

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Dresser Drawers

Write down what good looks like.

One category per drawer, and a hand's width of free space is the fill line. When a drawer needs pressing to close, that category has outgrown its drawer and one item comes out the same day.

SUSTAIN 234 / 684

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Dresser Drawers

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

When clean laundry comes back to the bedroom it gets folded upright and into the drawer then, by whoever carried the basket up, rather than living in a stack until the weekend. Ten minutes for a load. The fill line measures it, a hand's width of free space, so a drawer you press to close is a category that has outgrown its ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Each drawer holds one category: underwear and socks, sleepwear, t-shirts, workout clothes. Everything folded to stand upright so you read the whole drawer from above when it opens. A hand's width of free space ...

SORT 235 / 684

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Primary Closet

Decide what stays.

Pull out anything you have not worn in a year, anything waiting on a repair you are never going to make, and every wire hanger and plastic sheath the dry cleaner sent home. Winter coats and heavy knits go into a labeled bin or the guest wardrobe so the rod carries only what this month asks for.

STRAIGHTEN 236 / 684

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Primary Closet

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Switch to one hanger style so everything hangs at the same depth and the row reads flat, group by type and then by shade, and hang the short items together so the floor under them opens up for the shoe rack. Bags stand up on the shelf rather than nesting inside one another where you forget the inner three.

SHINE 237 / 684

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Primary Closet

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Clear the floor completely, vacuum it and the corners, wipe the shelf edges and the rod itself where hangers leave a gray line, and check the back wall and baseboard for damp before the shoes go back down.

SAFETY 238 / 684

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Primary Closet

Fix what could hurt somebody.

An overloaded rod pulls its brackets out of the plasterboard, and it does it while you are standing underneath reaching in. Lean your weight on it and see, anchor the brackets into a stud, and get the shoe pile off the floor so you are not standing on a heel in the dark.

STANDARDIZE 239 / 684

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Primary Closet

Write down what good looks like.

The rod is full when you cannot slide two fingers between hangers. From there it is one in, one out, and the bare stretch of rod at the end stays bare, because that is where the next coat lands.

SUSTAIN 240 / 684

PRIMARY BEDROOM

Primary Closet

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

Turn every hanger backwards at the start of a season and turn each one the right way round as you wear the item, so the record keeps itself. Slip gets measured with two fingers: when they will not fit between hangers the rod is full, and from there it is one in, one out. Recovery is not a purge, it is reading the hangers still ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

One hanger style throughout, grouped by type and then by shade, every hook facing the same way. Shoes in pairs on a rack instead of a floor heap, bags standing upright on the shelf, belts on one hook. Two ...

SORT 241 / 684

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Bed and Linens

Decide what stays.

Take every sheet set that has been demoted to this room and try each fitted sheet on the actual mattress. If a corner pops off while you are making the bed, it is a rag, not a spare. Fold each pillow in half and let go, and anything that stays folded goes out.

STRAIGHTEN 242 / 684

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Bed and Linens

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Nest each complete set inside one of its own pillowcases so a full change of bedding is a single grab from the shelf, and keep the spare set for this mattress size in this room rather than back in the family linen cupboard.

SHINE 243 / 684

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Bed and Linens

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Vacuum the mattress surface and the seams with the upholstery tool, turn the mattress end to end, and wipe the top edge of the headboard, where dust settles unseen because nobody sits up in this bed.

SAFETY 244 / 684

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Bed and Linens

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Walk from the pillow to the door with the lights off, the way a guest will in the small hours in a room they do not know, and clear anything their shin will find. If the bed sits under a blind, tie the cord up out of reach of a visiting toddler.

STANDARDIZE 245 / 684

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Bed and Linens

Write down what good looks like.

Write on a tag tucked into each bundle: bed size, one fitted, one flat, two cases, one blanket. A standard is the best way you know today, written down.

SUSTAIN 246 / 684

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Bed and Linens

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

Strip and wash the bed the day the guest leaves, not the day before the next one arrives, so the room sits ready rather than pending. One wash, by whoever waved them off. The check is the doorway: a made bed with a second set folded on the shelf is ready, and a bare mattress is a job left for a night you will be short of time ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Mattress protector on, one complete set made up on the bed, a second complete set folded inside its own pillowcase on the shelf, two pillows that spring back when you fold them in half, and nothing under the ...

SORT 247 / 684

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Nightstand

Decide what stays.

Open the drawer and take out what has been hiding in a room nobody uses: dead batteries, a clock radio that lost its time when the power blipped, three paperbacks nobody chose, cough drops fused into their tin. None of it belongs to a guest, and none of it belongs to you either.

STRAIGHTEN 248 / 684

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Nightstand

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Set the lamp on the side a right hand reaches first from the pillow, run the charger head over the top edge of the nightstand so it hangs where a hand lands, and stand the tissue box upright rather than laying it in the drawer.

SHINE 249 / 684

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Nightstand

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Wipe the lamp base and the inner rim of the shade, vacuum the drawer out rather than wiping it, and clean the water ring the last guest left because they could not find the coaster.

SAFETY 250 / 684

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Nightstand

Fix what could hurt somebody.

The water glass, the lamp cord and the outlet all meet in one square foot here, so run the cord behind the nightstand rather than across the top, and keep the glass on the far side from the lamp. Take your own medication out of this drawer entirely, because a visiting child opens drawers before anything else.

STANDARDIZE 251 / 684

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Nightstand

Write down what good looks like.

Tape a small card inside the drawer with the wifi name and password, where the bathroom is, and which way the shower faucet turns. Write it out even for guests you know well, because the whole point is that nobody has to knock on your door at midnight to ask. The card stays in that drawer permanently, and the password is the ...

SUSTAIN 252 / 684

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Nightstand

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

The night before an arrival, switch the lamp on and plug your own phone into each cable while you make the bed, so a dead bulb or a failed cable is found by you rather than by them at two in the morning. Two minutes, host's job. Slip shows when you open the drawer and find something of the household's in it, because a drawer ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

A lamp whose switch you can find by feel in the dark, one charging cable per common connector plugged in and reaching the pillow, a coaster, a box of tissues at least half full, and a drawer that is genuinely ...

SORT 253 / 684

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Dresser

Decide what stays.

This is where the household's undecided things hide behind a closed front: off-season sweaters, a bin of cables, wrapping paper and ribbon, a bag of outgrown baby clothes waiting on a decision about a second child. The sweaters go to your own wardrobe, the cables to the drawer that already holds cables, and the baby clothes get ...

STRAIGHTEN 254 / 684

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Dresser

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Put the empty drawers at the top, where a guest opens first and bends least, and the spare linens underneath, since you fetch those twice a year and they fetch socks twice a day.

SHINE 255 / 684

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Dresser

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Vacuum inside each drawer and wipe the runners, then leave the empty drawers open with the window cracked while you finish the rest of the room. Old wood holds a smell, and a guest's clothes take it on in one night.

SAFETY 256 / 684

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Dresser

Fix what could hurt somebody.

A dresser with two empty top drawers is lighter at the top than it looks, and a visiting child will climb it. Strap it into a stud, and pull each drawer fully out to check that it stops rather than sliding free onto a foot.

STANDARDIZE 257 / 684

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Dresser

Write down what good looks like.

Write on a label inside each empty drawer's front edge: reserved, guest. It stops the household reading a visibly empty drawer as an invitation, which is what happens to every empty drawer in an occupied house. Label the lower drawers by contents as well, spare linens for this bed, so nobody has to open all four to work out ...

SUSTAIN 258 / 684

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Dresser

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

During your own seasonal wardrobe change you open these two drawers in the same trip and confirm they are still empty before the swap counts as done. Thirty seconds inside a job already happening, by whoever is doing the swapping. Slip is exactly one thing: something of the household's in a drawer labeled reserved. Recovery is ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

The top two drawers completely empty and lined, the lower drawers holding spare linens folded to one uniform footprint with a label on the inside front edge, an anti-tip strap fixed to the wall, and the ...

SORT 259 / 684

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Closet

Decide what stays.

Take everything out and put it on the bed. This closet is where the house keeps holiday decorations, a wedding dress in a zipped bag, a box of old phones, and paperwork from two addresses ago. Sort by whether a named person will use it in a named situation, and route the rest out.

STRAIGHTEN 260 / 684

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Closet

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Give the guest the end of the rod nearest the door and nearest the light, put the household bins at the far end, and use matching hangers throughout so the empty six read as an offer rather than as leftovers.

SHINE 261 / 684

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Closet

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Wipe the rod with a damp cloth, because a rod nobody touches grows a fuzz that transfers straight onto a dark shoulder, then vacuum the floor corners where dust gathers undisturbed for months.

SAFETY 262 / 684

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Closet

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Anything stored above the rod sits over the head of whoever is reaching for a hanger. Move heavy boxes down to floor level and keep only light, lidded, labeled bins on the top shelf, with nothing stacked so the top item overhangs the edge.

STANDARDIZE 263 / 684

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Closet

Write down what good looks like.

Mark the guest boundary physically with a strip of tape on the rod or a hanger stop, so the line is visible from the doorway and does not depend on anyone remembering it.

SUSTAIN 264 / 684

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Closet

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

Every time you take a seasonal bin down from this closet you check the taped line and count the empty hangers before shutting the door, which costs the length of standing up. Six matching hangers past the tape is the number, so five is the signal and you read it without moving anything. Recovery is walking the stray garment ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

At least a forearm's width of clear rod with six matching empty hangers on it, a clear floor square big enough for an open suitcase, household bins on the shelf in labeled lidded boxes with nothing loose above ...

SORT 265 / 684

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Welcome and Work Surface

Decide what stays.

Clear the surface completely. It will be holding gift wrap, an ironing pile that never made it back, a printer that has not been switched on this year, and paperwork someone brought in here to deal with in peace. The ironing goes back to the wardrobe it came from, the printer either earns a desk somewhere it gets used or leaves ...

STRAIGHTEN 266 / 684

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Welcome and Work Surface

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Put the welcome bin where a guest sees it the moment they stand in the doorway, and set the luggage rack where a suitcase can open fully without hitting the bed frame or the closet door.

SHINE 267 / 684

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Welcome and Work Surface

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Wipe the desk and the chair seat and back, both of which collect a dust film in an unused room, and check the desk lamp works now rather than during a guest's first evening.

SAFETY 268 / 684

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Welcome and Work Surface

Fix what could hurt somebody.

The classic hazard here is the extension lead run across the floor because the only outlet is behind the bed. Move the desk to the outlet rather than the outlet to the desk, and if a suitcase must live on a folding rack, open it and lean on it to be sure it holds a packed case without folding.

STANDARDIZE 269 / 684

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Welcome and Work Surface

Write down what good looks like.

Photograph the room in its ready state and keep the print inside the lid of the welcome bin, so setting up is matching a picture rather than remembering a list.

SUSTAIN 270 / 684

GUEST BEDROOM

Guest Welcome and Work Surface

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

When you carry the departing guest's sheets to the wash, the welcome bin comes with you and gets restocked on the way back. Host's job, five minutes. The ready-state photo inside the lid is the check, so slip is a comparison rather than a memory: whatever is in the photo and not in the bin is what you are missing. Recovery is ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

A clear desk with a working lamp, a chair pulled up to it, a luggage rack or a taped floor square for the suitcase, one labeled bin holding a spare charger, wifi card, water glass, tissues and a folded spare ...

SORT 271 / 684

KIDS BEDROOM

Bed and Sleep Zone

Decide what stays.

Pull every stuffed animal out onto the floor and count what was actually in the bed. A child sleeps with a handful, not a herd, and the rest are drift from birthdays and fair prizes.

STRAIGHTEN 272 / 684

KIDS BEDROOM

Bed and Sleep Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Give them bedding they can handle alone. One duvet in a washable cover beats a top sheet plus blanket plus quilt, because making the bed becomes a single pull instead of four layers a seven year old will never line up.

SHINE 273 / 684

KIDS BEDROOM

Bed and Sleep Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Strip the bed, vacuum the mattress, and get the strip of floor under it that nobody has seen since the frame went in. Wipe the headboard and the nightlight casing where hands land every night.

SAFETY 274 / 684

KIDS BEDROOM

Bed and Sleep Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Blind and blackout cords hanging near a bed head are a strangle risk at exactly the wrong height. Cleat them high on the wall or change to a cordless blind. Then check the bed to door route, because a night trip to the bathroom should not end over a toy bin.

STANDARDIZE 275 / 684

KIDS BEDROOM

Bed and Sleep Zone

Write down what good looks like.

Tape one photo of the made bed inside the wardrobe door at the child's eye height. Match the picture is a standard a six year old can meet on their own, with no adult needed to rule on what made means.

SUSTAIN 276 / 684

KIDS BEDROOM

Bed and Sleep Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

The bed gets made while the school bag goes onto the shoulder, before anyone leaves the room, and the child does it rather than an adult standing over them. The photo inside the wardrobe door settles what made means, so a six year old can check their own work and nobody referees it. Slip is a duvet that no longer matches the ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Duvet pulled flat with one pillow squared at the head. Three or four stuffed animals on the bed, the rest sitting in an open basket at the foot where they can still be seen. Nightlight cord run behind the bed ...

SORT 277 / 684

KIDS BEDROOM

Toy Storage Zone

Decide what stays.

Tip every bin onto the floor and sort into families first, blocks with blocks, figures with figures. Broken toys, orphan puzzle pieces and party bag plastic go out during the sort, never into a decide later pile that becomes a seventh bin.

STRAIGHTEN 278 / 684

KIDS BEDROOM

Toy Storage Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

One open bin per family and no lids anywhere. A lid is an extra step, and an extra step is the reason a five year old drops the dinosaur on the carpet instead. Heaviest bin on the bottom, the daily favorites at hand height.

SHINE 279 / 684

KIDS BEDROOM

Toy Storage Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Run the hard plastic through a sink of warm soapy water and dry it on a towel. Vacuum the baseboard corners where small parts migrate, and check the bin bottoms for splits before you refill them.

SAFETY 280 / 684

KIDS BEDROOM

Toy Storage Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Anything smaller than a toilet roll tube is a choking hazard for a younger sibling and belongs in a bin they cannot reach. Then check every battery hatch: button batteries are the serious one, so bin any toy whose battery cover has lost its screw.

STANDARDIZE 281 / 684

KIDS BEDROOM

Toy Storage Zone

Write down what good looks like.

Photo label on the front face of every bin, never on a lid, at the child's eye level rather than yours. A picture of six blocks works long before reading does.

SUSTAIN 282 / 684

KIDS BEDROOM

Toy Storage Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

Clearing the carpet is what buys the story, and it happens while the book is being chosen rather than after it. The child does it alone in about five minutes, which is the whole point of putting every photo label at their eye level and never on a lid. Slip is a bin whose picture no longer matches what is inside, or carpet you ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Six open bins, none higher than the child's shoulder, each with a photo of its contents taped to the front face. Blocks in one, vehicles in one, small figures in one. Enough clear carpet to lie down on. One ...

SORT 283 / 684

KIDS BEDROOM

Study Desk

Decide what stays.

Paper first, and every sheet goes to exactly one of three places: live work into the tray, keepsake into the memory box, everything else into recycling. A worksheet from a finished term is recycling even when the marking was good.

STRAIGHTEN 284 / 684

KIDS BEDROOM

Study Desk

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Pens and pencils standing in a cup within a hand's reach of the writing hand, not across the desk where a reach knocks the water bottle over. Books and folders go up onto the shelf so the surface stays a work surface.

SHINE 285 / 684

KIDS BEDROOM

Study Desk

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Clear the whole desk down to bare wood, wipe it, then get the pencil sharpener dust and dried glue out of the drawer runners. Wipe the lamp shade too, because a dusty lamp is a dimmer lamp.

SAFETY 286 / 684

KIDS BEDROOM

Study Desk

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Count the plugs under the desk. A lamp, a laptop charger and a strip plugged into another strip is where an overloaded socket hides, so bring it back to one strip in one wall socket. Scissors and craft knives point down in the cup, and blades go in a closed drawer if a younger child comes in here.

STANDARDIZE 287 / 684

KIDS BEDROOM

Study Desk

Write down what good looks like.

The tray is the standard: if it does not fit in the tray, it is not live work, and it goes to the shelf, the memory box or the recycling. Turn the tray out on the same evening the backpack gets emptied, so it never quietly becomes a second pile.

SUSTAIN 288 / 684

KIDS BEDROOM

Study Desk

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

The desk gets cleared when the laptop lid closes at the end of homework, not the next morning, and the closing lid is a trigger the child can feel. Two minutes. The tray is the standard, so slip is a tray that will no longer close, and anything on the chair means the surface ran out first. Recovery is turning the tray out on ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Desk surface bare except a lamp, a pen cup and one tray holding live work. Laptop charger threaded through a clip on the desk edge so the plug never drops behind the desk. Books on the shelf above, none ...

SORT 289 / 684

KIDS BEDROOM

Clothing Closet

Decide what stays.

Pull anything that is the wrong size. Children's clothes fail in one direction only, too small, so the test is quick: sleeves above the wrist bone, waistbands that leave a mark, shoes where the toe is already touching. The next size up belongs in a box on the top shelf, never mixed into the rod.

STRAIGHTEN 290 / 684

KIDS BEDROOM

Clothing Closet

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Lower the rod. It is one bracket move, and it changes who is capable of using this closet. Then group by type and by color inside each type, so getting dressed is picking from a row rather than digging through a jumble.

SHINE 291 / 684

KIDS BEDROOM

Clothing Closet

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Empty the closet floor completely, vacuum it, and wipe the rod down where hangers have left a gray line. Check the top shelf for the dust that has been settling onto the stored clothes all year.

SAFETY 292 / 684

KIDS BEDROOM

Clothing Closet

Fix what could hurt somebody.

An overloaded rod on plastic end brackets comes down onto a child's head, so hang everything back on and give it one hard downward pull before you trust it. Heavy things, sports kit and boots and skates, live on the closet floor, never on the top shelf where a child pulls them down onto themselves.

STANDARDIZE 293 / 684

KIDS BEDROOM

Clothing Closet

Write down what good looks like.

One hanger style throughout, and the next size box labeled in numbers big enough to read from the doorway. At the start of each season turn every hanger backwards, so the ones still reversed by the end of it tell you what is not being worn.

SUSTAIN 294 / 684

KIDS BEDROOM

Clothing Closet

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

The reversed hanger gets flipped forward as the garment goes back on the rod from the drying rack, so the record keeps itself and the child can do the hanging. At the end of a season the hangers still facing backwards are the answer, and a rod too tight to slide a group apart is the earlier warning. Recovery is the reversed ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Rod lowered so the child reaches a hanger without a stool. Every hanger the same type, all facing the same way. Shirts together, dresses together, jackets together, with a hand's width gap between groups so a ...

SORT 295 / 684

KIDS BEDROOM

Dresser Drawers

Decide what stays.

One drawer at a time, tipped out onto the bed. Out go the single socks with no pair, the underwear with dead elastic, and the pyjama bottoms that now stop above the ankle. Do not open the next drawer until this one is back in.

STRAIGHTEN 296 / 684

KIDS BEDROOM

Dresser Drawers

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

File fold upright so the drawer reads like a card index and the child sees every shirt without excavating. Dividers, or two shoebox lids, stop the rows falling sideways the first time the drawer gets yanked.

SHINE 297 / 684

KIDS BEDROOM

Dresser Drawers

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Pull the drawers right out of the carcass, vacuum the inside of the frame, and wipe the runners. That grit is where the drawer that sticks, and then gets slammed, comes from.

SAFETY 298 / 684

KIDS BEDROOM

Dresser Drawers

Fix what could hurt somebody.

A chest of drawers with two drawers open is a climbing frame, and it tips forward onto the child climbing it. Strap it to a wall stud with an anti tip bracket. Then take the tablet or the toy off the dresser top, because anything a child wants up there is an invitation to climb for it.

STANDARDIZE 299 / 684

KIDS BEDROOM

Dresser Drawers

Write down what good looks like.

A picture label on each drawer front showing what is inside, socks on the socks drawer, so the child both finds and returns without reading. Same category in the same drawer forever, even when that means one drawer stays half empty.

SUSTAIN 300 / 684

KIDS BEDROOM

Dresser Drawers

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

Refolding happens straight out of the laundry basket and into the drawer standing up, never stacked flat on the bed for later. A child of seven can own two of the five drawers outright. The signal is a drawer needing a press to close, or socks lying flat instead of standing, which means the last load went in on top rather than ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Five drawers, one category each, each with a picture label on the drawer front. Socks and underwear standing upright in rows so every pair is visible from above. Every drawer closes with one push, no pressing ...

SORT 301 / 684

KIDS BEDROOM

School and Activity Launch Zone

Decide what stays.

Empty the backpack completely every Friday, turned upside down. Out comes the leftover lunch, the dead permission slip and the newsletter from three weeks ago. Sports kit goes into the wash basket, never back into the bag damp.

STRAIGHTEN 302 / 684

KIDS BEDROOM

School and Activity Launch Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Hook, then shoes, then bag, along the wall in the order they get grabbed. The instrument case stands upright against the wall where it cannot be trodden on, and the lunchbox gets its own small hook, so an empty hook at bedtime tells you it is still in the bag with yesterday's sandwich in it.

SHINE 303 / 684

KIDS BEDROOM

School and Activity Launch Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Wipe the lunchbox seals and the inside of the water bottle lid, which is where the mold actually grows. Turn the backpack over a bin and shake it, then wipe the base where the drink leaked in March.

SAFETY 304 / 684

KIDS BEDROOM

School and Activity Launch Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

A bag left in a dark doorway at seven in the morning is the trip that starts the day badly, so everything hangs and nothing rests on the floor. Then check the things that must never be forgotten: an inhaler, an epipen or a dose of medication belongs in one named pocket that is checked at packing, not remembered at the school ...

STANDARDIZE 305 / 684

KIDS BEDROOM

School and Activity Launch Zone

Write down what good looks like.

A five line checklist taped beside the hook at the child's eye level, in pictures for a younger one and words for an older one. Bag, shoes, lunch, form, kit. Five lines and no more, because a longer list gets skipped.

SUSTAIN 306 / 684

KIDS BEDROOM

School and Activity Launch Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

The launch zone gets packed while the bath is running, every school night, before anyone is tired enough to argue about it. The child runs the five line list taped at their eye height, three minutes. Slip reads from the doorway as a bag that is not zipped or a floor that is not bare. Recovery is running the five lines once more ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Backpack hanging on its hook at child height, packed and zipped. Shoes side by side directly underneath it. Signed forms in the front pocket rather than on the kitchen counter. Sports bag on the second hook ...

SORT 307 / 684

NURSERY

Crib and Sleep Zone

Decide what stays.

Lift everything out of the crib and lay it on the floor where you can see it at once: the quilt, the plush pile, the bumper, the wedge, the stack of muslins. One fitted sheet goes back in. The plush goes to the toy basket, the muslins to the changing station, the quilt to the keepsake box.

STRAIGHTEN 308 / 684

NURSERY

Crib and Sleep Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Put the spares where your hand finds them in the dark. Two fitted sheets and one spare sleep sack in the top dresser drawer means a 3 a.m. sheet change is one drawer, one motion, and no ceiling light.

SHINE 309 / 684

NURSERY

Crib and Sleep Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Strip and hot-wash the sheet, then wipe the mattress cover and every rail, especially the top rail where hands and gums end up. While the mattress is out, run your palm along each slat and put a spanner on the frame bolts; crib hardware works loose over months of being leaned on.

SAFETY 310 / 684

NURSERY

Crib and Sleep Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Drop the mattress to its lowest setting the day your baby can push up onto hands and knees, because the next thing they learn is pulling to stand. Move the crib clear of the blind cord, the lamp flex, and the monitor cable; any cord reachable from inside the rails is a strangling risk that comes down or gets shortened today ...

STANDARDIZE 311 / 684

NURSERY

Crib and Sleep Zone

Write down what good looks like.

Photograph the empty crib with its single sheet and tape the picture inside the closet door. Anyone who puts your baby down, including a visiting grandparent, can see what the crib is supposed to look like without asking you.

SUSTAIN 312 / 684

NURSERY

Crib and Sleep Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

Every time the sheet comes off for the wash, the crib goes back together with a sheet and nothing else, by whoever is changing it. Ten seconds, and not a weekly check but the act of remaking the bed itself. The signal is anything crossing the rail: a muslin over the top rail, a toy at the foot, a folded blanket. All of it comes ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

A bare mattress with one fitted sheet pulled tight to the corners, the sleep sack folded on the dresser, the monitor mounted on the wall with its cable clipped high and at least an arm's length back from the ...

SORT 313 / 684

NURSERY

Changing Station

Decide what stays.

Clear the whole dresser top. What earns its way back is only what your hand touches during an actual change: diapers, wipes, cream, a burp cloth. The lamp, the framed scan photo, and the bottle of lotion nobody has opened all move off.

STRAIGHTEN 314 / 684

NURSERY

Changing Station

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Stand at the pad and sweep your free arm through its full arc. Everything inside that arc is the station and everything outside it is storage. Diapers go on the side your dominant hand lands, wipes beside them, cream where your thumb can flip the cap without looking.

SHINE 315 / 684

NURSERY

Changing Station

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Wipe the pad after every change and pull its cover off for a hot wash weekly. Once a month take the drawer under the pad right out; that is where crusted cream lids and dried-out wipes collect underneath the spare outfits.

SAFETY 316 / 684

NURSERY

Changing Station

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Keep one hand on your baby the whole time the strap is off, with no exception for reaching a shelf, because a roll off a dresser is a fall onto a hard floor from adult waist height. Anchor the dresser to the wall, and keep the wipe refill bags and the pail liner roll shut in a drawer rather than sitting on top where a hand can ...

STANDARDIZE 317 / 684

NURSERY

Changing Station

Write down what good looks like.

Tape a card on the wall beside the pad with the counts you restock to: eight diapers in the caddy, one wipe pack open, one sealed behind it. The card tells you the station is running low before a bare baby does.

SUSTAIN 318 / 684

NURSERY

Changing Station

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

Restock the caddy back up to the numbers on the card during the last change before bed, by whoever is doing that change. One minute, once a day. The card is the check, eight diapers and one open wipe pack, so a caddy under the numbers shows itself before you need it rather than while you have a bare baby on the pad. Recovery is ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Diapers, wipes, and cream all touchable without moving your feet or lifting your hand off your baby, a lined pail within one step, two spare outfits in the drawer directly beneath the pad, and a pad surface ...

SORT 319 / 684

NURSERY

Baby Clothing Zone

Decide what stays.

Hold up each garment and read the size on the label rather than judging by eye, then check it against the size your baby is wearing today. Anything smaller leaves the drawer now, and there are exactly two destinations: the outgoing bag, or the keepsake box.

STRAIGHTEN 320 / 684

NURSERY

Baby Clothing Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

One size per drawer, largest size in the lowest drawer, and file sleepers upright on their spines so you can see the whole drawer at a glance instead of digging. Gifts in bigger sizes go straight into the next-size bin, never into a drawer you open half asleep.

SHINE 321 / 684

NURSERY

Baby Clothing Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Empty each drawer down to the base and wipe it out, because baby drawers collect sock lint and dried spit-up in the corners. Check hand-me-downs for stains that have set and wash them before they go in, not after you have pulled one out at 6 a.m. and found it.

SAFETY 322 / 684

NURSERY

Baby Clothing Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Bolt the chest of drawers to the wall and never leave two drawers open at once, because an open drawer turns the chest into a ladder and a crush risk the moment your baby is climbing. Cut off decorative buttons, ribbon ties, and hood drawstrings from hand-me-down cardigans before they ever reach a drawer.

STANDARDIZE 323 / 684

NURSERY

Baby Clothing Zone

Write down what good looks like.

A written size label on the front of every drawer, changed the same day the size changes, so anyone dressing your baby picks the right drawer without opening three.

SUSTAIN 324 / 684

NURSERY

Baby Clothing Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

The moment a snap will not close over the diaper, that garment goes into the outgoing bag on the door hook rather than back into the wash basket, and whoever is dressing your baby makes the call on the spot. Slip is two sizes sharing one drawer, visible from above without lifting anything, and it always means the drawer label ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Each drawer holds one size only with the size written on the drawer front, sleepers and bodysuits filed upright so you read every collar from above, a next-size bin on the closet shelf, and an outgoing bag on ...

SORT 325 / 684

NURSERY

Feeding Station

Decide what stays.

Line up every bottle, teat, valve, membrane, and pump part on the surface at once. Teats gone cloudy or split at the slit go in the bin rather than back in the drawer, and so does every part belonging to a pump or bottle brand you have stopped using.

STRAIGHTEN 326 / 684

NURSERY

Feeding Station

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Two bins in obviously different colors, one for clean and ready, one for used and waiting. Assemble bottles fully as they come out of the sterilizer, teat and collar on, so the middle of the night is a grab rather than a hunt for a matching collar.

SHINE 327 / 684

NURSERY

Feeding Station

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Wash and sterilize on the schedule your kit calls for, then let parts air dry completely before they go into the clean bin, because a damp valve in a closed bin is where mold starts. Descale the kettle or sterilizer monthly and wipe the surface under the drying rack where drips collect.

SAFETY 328 / 684

NURSERY

Feeding Station

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Kettles, bottle warmers, and sterilizers sit at roughly the same height as the changing pad, so a pulled cord brings scalding water down at child height. Loop every cable short and run it behind the appliance, and keep the kettle and the water jug well clear of the socket and the monitor plug so nothing wet stands next to ...

STANDARDIZE 329 / 684

NURSERY

Feeding Station

Write down what good looks like.

Write the formula scoop-to-water numbers you actually use on a card taped above the station, so a grandparent or a night visitor mixes it right the first time. A standard is the best way you know today, written down.

SUSTAIN 330 / 684

NURSERY

Feeding Station

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

When the kitchen light goes off for the night, the used bin goes down to be washed and the clean bin comes back stocked to four assembled bottles, by whoever is closing the kitchen. Fifteen minutes, once. The signal is a used part sitting in the clean bin, and that is the one thing this zone must never do, because the whole ...

> **THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN**
> One bin of clean bottles assembled with teats and collars on, a second bin of used parts waiting, a drying rack standing empty, the formula scoop inside the tin with the lid shut, and a stack of burp cloths ...

SORT 331 / 684

NURSERY

Diaper and Care Backstock

Decide what stays.

Pull every pack off the shelf and read the printed size rather than trusting the picture on the front. Anything smaller than the size in use today comes off, including packs you have already opened, because a half-used pack of size 1 is still size 1.

STRAIGHTEN 332 / 684

NURSERY

Diaper and Care Backstock

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Write the size in marker on the short end of every pack so it reads from the doorway, then shelve the current size at the front with the next size directly behind it. Creams, teething gel, and the thermometer go into one lidded box rather than loose between the cartons.

SHINE 333 / 684

NURSERY

Diaper and Care Backstock

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Wipe the shelf down and check the undersides of the cartons for damp, since packs stored against an outside wall wick moisture up through the cardboard. While the shelf is empty, read the dates on every cream and infant medicine and bin what has passed.

SAFETY 334 / 684

NURSERY

Diaper and Care Backstock

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Nothing heavy goes on a shelf above or beside the crib, because a carton that works its way off lands exactly where your baby sleeps. Keep the outer plastic wrap and the pail liner roll out of reach, and keep diaper creams, teething gels, and any infant medicine in a closed box a standing toddler cannot open.

STANDARDIZE 335 / 684

NURSERY

Diaper and Care Backstock

Write down what good looks like.

Write the minimum and maximum on the shelf edge itself: never fewer than one unopened pack of the current size, never more than two packs of any one size.

SUSTAIN 336 / 684

NURSERY

Diaper and Care Backstock

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

When the last diaper comes out of an open pack, the reserve moves forward and the size goes onto the shopping list in the same motion, by whoever took that diaper. The shelf edge carries the numbers, so slip is countable from the doorway: fewer than one unopened pack of the current size, or more than two of any size. Recovery ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

One unopened pack of the current size and no more than two of the next size on a low shelf, each size written large in marker on the short end, a wipes carton with its count visible, creams and thermometer in ...

SORT 337 / 684

NURSERY

Books and Quiet Play Zone

Decide what stays.

Sit on the floor at your baby's eye level and pick up every book and toy in reach. Board books stay; paper-page books, torn spines, loose stitched eyes, and any battery flap that will not screw shut come out or go up on a high shelf until later.

STRAIGHTEN 338 / 684

NURSERY

Books and Quiet Play Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Covers face out along the ledge, because a pre-reader chooses by picture and cannot read a spine. Fill the soft toy basket to its rim and treat the rim as the limit, with everything above it going into the rotation box in the closet.

SHINE 339 / 684

NURSERY

Books and Quiet Play Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Wipe the board book covers and the ledge, since chewed corners and drool are essentially the whole cleaning job in this zone. Run soft toys through a monthly wash and check tags, seams, and stitched eyes as you pull each one out of the machine.

SAFETY 340 / 684

NURSERY

Books and Quiet Play Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Bolt the shelf or ledge to the wall, because the day your baby pulls to standing it becomes the nearest handhold and a tip-over risk. Check every light-up or musical toy for a battery compartment that needs a screwdriver, and remove anything with a loose button battery or a ribbon tag long enough to wind around a wrist.

STANDARDIZE 341 / 684

NURSERY

Books and Quiet Play Zone

Write down what good looks like.

Twelve covers on the ledge, one basket level with its rim. Anything new that arrives means something goes into the rotation box the same day, not the same month.

SUSTAIN 342 / 684

NURSERY

Books and Quiet Play Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

When you switch the lamp off after the bedtime story, stand the books back cover out and swap two off the ledge for two out of the rotation box, by whoever read. Under a minute, while you are already there. Slip is visible from the door: a book lying spine out or stacked flat means the ledge is over twelve, and a basket proud ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Twelve board books standing cover out on a low ledge, one basket of soft toys filled level with the rim and no higher, the rest boxed in the closet as rotation stock, and a clear stretch of floor big enough ...

SORT

343 / 684

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Vanity Counter

Decide what stays.

Pull everything off the counter onto a towel and put back only what your hands touched today and yesterday. The travel bottles, the sample sachets, and the hair tie graveyard go into a drawer or out of the room entirely.

STRAIGHTEN

344 / 684

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Vanity Counter

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Give the daily set one tray, on the side you reach with your dominant hand. The heat tool gets a heat-safe rest and its cord parks behind the basin rather than draped across it.

SHINE

345 / 684

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Vanity Counter

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Wipe the tray, then the counter under it, then the base of the faucet where toothpaste dries into a crust. Finish with the mirror and the light switch plate, the thing in this room nobody ever wipes.

SAFETY

346 / 684

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Vanity Counter

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Water and a plugged-in dryer share one small surface in here. Keep the cord on the far side of the basin from the faucet, and pull the plug at the wall the moment you set the tool down, not once your hair is finished.

STANDARDIZE

347 / 684

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Vanity Counter

Write down what good looks like.

Write the four-product limit on a strip of tape stuck under the tray, and tape a photo of the cleared counter inside the vanity door. A fifth bottle then has something to argue with before it lands.

SUSTAIN

348 / 684

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Vanity Counter

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

The tray goes back to match the photo when you rinse your toothbrush at night, same moment every night, each adult resetting their own products. Twenty seconds. Slip is a fifth bottle standing on bare stone, seen from the door before anything else, because this counter's whole standard is the emptiness either side of the basin ...

> **THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN**
> One tray you can lift with one hand, holding soap, the toothbrush holder, and no more than four daily products. Bare stone on both sides of the basin, a mirror with no splatter, and no cord crossing the sink.

SORT

349 / 684

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Vanity Drawers

Decide what stays.

Empty one drawer at a time onto a towel and turn every tube, jar, and bottle over to find a date or an open-jar symbol. Mascara, liquid foundation, and sunscreen are the usual offenders; dead hair ties and orphan bobby pins are the usual volume.

STRAIGHTEN

350 / 684

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Vanity Drawers

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Divide by routine rather than by product type: a morning compartment, an evening compartment, and one for weekly and occasional. Combs, brushes, and dental supplies stand upright in their own section so nothing has to be dug through.

SHINE

351 / 684

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Vanity Drawers

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Lift the dividers out and tip the drawer over a bin, because loose powder, hair, and grit collect underneath where you never look. Wipe the drawer bottom and the runners, then wipe the dividers before they go back in.

SAFETY 352 / 684

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Vanity Drawers

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Loose blades and razor cartridges in a drawer you reach into blind will find a fingertip. Cap every blade, or give all razors one lidded box in a fixed corner you never grope past.

STANDARDIZE 353 / 684

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Vanity Drawers

Write down what good looks like.

Write a count on each divider label: two lipsticks in rotation, one comb, one brush. A third lipstick has to beat one of the two already in the slot before it gets to stay.

SUSTAIN 354 / 684

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Vanity Drawers

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

On laundry day, while you are already carrying towels in, pull the top drawer and lift out anything empty or dried out. One drawer, one look, a week of drift undone, by whoever is doing that laundry run. Slip is a drawer you cannot read in a single look, or a count on a divider label that no longer matches the slot. Recovery is ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Every drawer divided, nothing past its open-jar window, razor blades capped or in a lidded box in one corner, and a top drawer you can read in a single look without moving anything.

SORT 355 / 684

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Under-Sink Cabinet

Decide what stays.

Take it all out and line it up on the floor by job: glass, tub and tile, toilet, drain, polish. You will find three half-full bottles of the same thing and one you cannot identify, and the one you cannot identify goes.

STRAIGHTEN 356 / 684

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Under-Sink Cabinet

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Build the bins around the P-trap instead of fighting it, keeping the joint and the valves visible. Paper goods and bulk toiletries take the side with headroom, and sprays sit at the front where you can read a label without kneeling.

SHINE 357 / 684

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Under-Sink Cabinet

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Wipe the cabinet floor and look hard for a dark ring or a soft patch in the board, which is what a slow leak looks like before it looks like water. Wipe the neck of every bottle before it goes back so the pale tray never turns sticky.

SAFETY 358 / 684

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Under-Sink Cabinet

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Never store bleach where it can tip into an ammonia-based cleaner, and never decant anything into a drink bottle. This cabinet sits at toddler height, so if small children come through the house, fit a magnetic catch or move the chemistry above the sink line.

STANDARDIZE 359 / 684

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Under-Sink Cabinet

Write down what good looks like.

One open container per job, backstock capped at two. Label the front edge of each bin with the job rather than the brand, so the bowl cleaner cannot quietly end up among the glass sprays.

SUSTAIN 360 / 684

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Under-Sink Cabinet

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

Every hand soap refill is a leak check: crouch, run your eyes over the cabinet floor and the trap joint, then close the doors. Ten seconds, by whoever refilled the soap. Slip is anything stacked on the pale tray or standing where it hides the trap, because the tray only works if it can show you a drip you were not expecting ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Two pull-out bins clear of the P-trap, a pale tray on the cabinet floor with nothing stacked on it, one open bottle per job, and both shut-off valves in plain sight when the doors swing open.

SORT 361 / 684

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Medicine Cabinet or Wall Storage

Decide what stays.

Read every label and every date, including the small print on the boxes you kept because the box was still good. Anything expired, anything unlabeled, and anything prescribed for a condition nobody here has now goes straight into a bag for the pharmacy take-back.

STRAIGHTEN 362 / 684

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Medicine Cabinet or Wall Storage

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Group by the reason you come to this cabinet: headache, stomach, cut, cold, eyes. Put the two things you reach for at two in the morning on the shelf you can find without turning the light on.

SHINE 363 / 684

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Medicine Cabinet or Wall Storage

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Take the shelves out and wash off the sticky rings left by cough syrup and the dust of old blister foil. Dry them all the way through before they go back, because a damp shelf is what turns tablets chalky in here.

SAFETY 364 / 684

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Medicine Cabinet or Wall Storage

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Bathroom humidity breaks tablets and capsules down faster than a bedroom shelf does, so move anything you take daily out of this room entirely. Whatever stays gets a child-secure catch, and nothing ever goes down the toilet.

STANDARDIZE 365 / 684

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Medicine Cabinet or Wall Storage

Write down what good looks like.

Bins are labeled by symptom rather than brand, so a guest or a sitter can find what they need without asking which box the cold tablets are in. The first aid bin holds plasters, tape, gauze, and one pair of scissors, and it never becomes a home for spare vitamins.

SUSTAIN 366 / 684

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Medicine Cabinet or Wall Storage

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

Every time you come home from the pharmacy the new box goes into its bin and you read the dates of everything already in that bin before shutting the door. One bin, not three, which keeps it two minutes, and the take-back bag rides back with you next time. Slip is anything in the wrong symptom bin or loose on the shelf ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Three labeled bins, pain relief, stomach and cold, first aid, each holding only in-date items. Prescriptions grouped by the name on the label, the first aid bin small enough to carry one-handed to whoever is ...

SORT 367 / 684

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Shower or Tub

Decide what stays.

Line every bottle along the tub edge and shake each one. The ones you cannot remember using this month, the conditioner that did nothing, and the hotel bottles all leave, and the nearly-empty ones get finished this week or poured together.

STRAIGHTEN 368 / 684

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Shower or Tub

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Give each person their own shelf or corner of the caddy instead of one mixed crowd, and hang the squeegee where a wet hand meets it without leaning out over the tub wall. Bottles go cap-down only if they truly seal, otherwise they ring the shelf.

SHINE 369 / 684

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Shower or Tub

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Spray the walls and the tray, then step out and do the counter or the toilet while the cleaner works. Come back, wipe, rinse, squeegee glass and tile from the top down, and leave the door standing open.

SAFETY 370 / 684

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Shower or Tub

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Wet glaze under a film of soap is the most slippery surface in the house, so the mat or the grip strips are not optional, and a grab bar is a morning's work to fit. Razors go on a high hook, never on the tub edge where a small hand reaches for balance.

STANDARDIZE 371 / 684

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Shower or Tub

Write down what good looks like.

Hold the caddy to a bottle limit: a new bottle comes in only on the day an empty goes out. The squeegee has one hook and hangs on it wet, every time.

SUSTAIN 372 / 684

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Shower or Tub

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

Whoever gets out last runs the squeegee over the glass and the walls, props the door open and leaves the fan going, while they are still wet and standing there. Thirty seconds. Two signals show from outside the enclosure: a dark line where the wall meets the tray, and a bottle nobody has picked up in two weeks. Recovery is a ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

One shampoo, one conditioner, one wash, and one bar per person in the caddy. A squeegee on its hook inside the enclosure, grip strips or a mat with real suction on the floor, and no dark line where the wall ...

SORT 373 / 684

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Toilet Area

Decide what stays.

Clear the cistern top down to the porcelain: the candle, the spare hand cream, the phone charger, the stack of reading. Everything stored up there has been sitting inside the fine spray a flush throws, and most of it does not belong in this room at all.

STRAIGHTEN 374 / 684

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Toilet Area

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Two reserve rolls go in a holder you can reach sitting down, and the rest of the pack goes to the linen cupboard. The brush and the bin each get a marked spot on the floor so a mop has a clean run around the pedestal.

SHINE 375 / 684

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Toilet Area

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Treat the bowl and let it sit while you do the rest of the room, then work the outside in order: handle, lid, seat top, seat underside, rim, pedestal, and the floor around the base where drips land. One cloth, one color, this job only.

SAFETY 376 / 684

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Toilet Area

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Bowl cleaner is the harshest chemistry in the house and must never meet bleach in the same bowl. Store it high or in the under-sink cabinet behind a catch, not on the floor beside the pedestal where a child stands to reach the flush.

STANDARDIZE 377 / 684

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Toilet Area

Write down what good looks like.

The toilet cloth and the toilet gloves are a color no other job in the house uses, and they hang apart from every other cloth. Two reserve rolls is the floor; dropping to one is the restock signal.

SUSTAIN 378 / 684

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Toilet Area

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

Whoever hangs the last roll carries two more in from the cupboard on their next trip through, so the empty holder does the remembering. Dropping to one reserve roll is the restock signal, and it is visible from the seat, which is where that information is needed. Recovery is a trip to the cupboard, thirty seconds. The other ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Two reserve rolls within reach from a seated position and the rest of the pack in the cupboard. The brush in a holder that has been emptied and dried, a lined bin with a lid, and a completely bare cistern lid.

SORT 379 / 684

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Linen and Towel Storage

Decide what stays.

Take every towel out and rank them by which one your hand actually goes to after a shower. The thin, the stiff, the shedders, and the odd single from a lost set all leave, with the best of the rejects becoming cleaning rags and the rest going to a shelter that takes textiles.

STRAIGHTEN 380 / 684

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Linen and Towel Storage

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Fold everything to one width so the stack squares up, then keep bath towels, hand towels, and washcloths in their own columns rather than one mixed pile. Each guest set goes inside a pillowcase so the whole set lifts off the shelf in one grab.

SHINE 381 / 684

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Linen and Towel Storage

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Wipe the shelves and press the back wall for damp, because a towel put away not quite dry will scent the whole cupboard within days. Anything sour goes back through a hot wash with no softener before it returns.

SAFETY 382 / 684

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Linen and Towel Storage

Fix what could hurt somebody.

A deep stack of linens on a shelf held by four small brackets is a load nobody ever weighed. Check the brackets and the wall fixings, and keep the heavy bath towels on the lower shelves so nothing tall comes down on your head.

STANDARDIZE 383 / 684

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Linen and Towel Storage

Write down what good looks like.

The count is the standard: three bath towels per person, folded to one width, one label per column. When a column is full and clean laundry arrives, the most worn towel in that column becomes a rag that day.

SUSTAIN 384 / 684

PRIMARY BATHROOM

Linen and Towel Storage

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

Every laundry fold is the reset: clean towels to the bottom of their column so the oldest keeps coming to your hand, and the column count checked in the same motion by whoever is folding. Nothing goes onto the shelf damp, ever, because that costs you the whole column. Slip is a column standing above its count, readable at eye ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Three bath towels per person, one in use, one in the wash, one folded on the shelf. Each guest set nested in its own pillowcase, hand towels and washcloths in separate labeled columns, and a spare bath mat ...

SORT 385 / 684

GUEST BATHROOM

Guest Vanity Counter

Decide what stays.

Take everything off the counter and put back only what a visitor would use: soap, tissues, hand towel. The travel conditioner, the spare contact lens case, and the razor that ended up here because the main bathroom ran out of room all go back where they belong or into the trash.

STRAIGHTEN 386 / 684

GUEST BATHROOM

Guest Vanity Counter

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Set the soap on the side your hand reaches without crossing over the basin, tissues at the back corner clear of splash, and the hand towel on a ring or hook visible from the door. A guest should never have to open a cabinet to find a towel.

SHINE 387 / 684

GUEST BATHROOM

Guest Vanity Counter

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Wipe the counter, then the faucet and the drain lip where toothpaste film and hard water scale build up, including the collar at the base of the faucet where a chalky ring hides. Do the mirror last, top to bottom, so drips land on surfaces you have not finished yet.

SAFETY 388 / 684

GUEST BATHROOM

Guest Vanity Counter

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Water and electricity: a shaver or hair dryer left plugged in beside a full basin is a live cord within splash reach, so unplug it and put it away rather than coiling it on the counter. Swap any glass tumbler or glass trinket dish for ceramic, because glass on a wet counter slides and it breaks onto a tile floor where feet are ...

STANDARDIZE 389 / 684

GUEST BATHROOM

Guest Vanity Counter

Write down what good looks like.

Three things live on this counter permanently: soap, tissues, hand towel. Photograph that exact arrangement and tape the picture inside the vanity door, so anyone in the house can reset the counter without asking you which three.

SUSTAIN 390 / 684

GUEST BATHROOM

Guest Vanity Counter

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

The moment someone confirms they are coming over, walk in, top up the soap and hang a fresh hand towel, both done before you have put the phone down. The laundry version is smaller: when you put fresh towels away, the guest hand towel swaps in the same motion. Slip is a soap pump below half or a towel that has hung there since ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

A soap pump above half full, one folded hand towel on the ring where you can see it from the doorway, a box of tissues at the back corner, and enough bare counter to set down a phone and a pair of glasses. No ...

SORT 391 / 684

GUEST BATHROOM

Guest Vanity Storage

Decide what stays.

Pull everything out and be honest about the hotel miniatures: the shampoos from three trips, the lotion nobody opened, the free conditioner samples. Keep the unopened ones a guest would actually use, throw out the started ones, and send household backstock that drifted in here back to the bathroom it came from.

STRAIGHTEN 392 / 684

GUEST BATHROOM

Guest Vanity Storage

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Two bins, not five. Guest supplies in one, cleaning products in the other, both light enough to lift out with one hand so the cabinet base stays visible. Toilet paper stacks on its own, where it can be seen the second the door opens, because a guest who is hunting for it will not come and ask.

SHINE 393 / 684

GUEST BATHROOM

Guest Vanity Storage

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Empty the cabinet completely and wipe the base, looking for dark rings or softened board that mean the trap has been weeping. Wipe the neck and cap of every bottle, since dried cleaner running down the side is what makes a cabinet sticky.

SAFETY 394 / 684

GUEST BATHROOM

Guest Vanity Storage

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Poison, choke, or strangle: bowl cleaner and bleach sitting under this sink are at exactly the height of a visiting toddler who has been sent in to wash their hands alone. Either lift the cleaning bin to a high shelf elsewhere or fit the cabinet with a latch, and never let bleach share a bin with an acid limescale or bowl ...

STANDARDIZE 395 / 684

GUEST BATHROOM

Guest Vanity Storage

Write down what good looks like.

Write the two bin labels by hand in plain words a guest can read, Guest Supplies and Cleaning, and draw a line on the shelf at the toilet paper minimum. When the stack falls below the line it goes on the shopping list, no counting required.

SUSTAIN 396 / 684

GUEST BATHROOM

Guest Vanity Storage

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

When you restock your own bathroom after a shop, open this cabinet on the same trip and build the toilet paper stack back to the drawn line. Two minutes, by whoever shopped. The weekly bowl clean gives the second look, since you are already crouched here, so run a hand across the cabinet base. Slip is a stack below the line, or ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Open the door and see two lift-out bins and nothing loose: one labeled for guest supplies holding a new toothbrush, a wrapped bar of soap, and four unopened travel toiletries in a small dish, and one labeled ...

SORT 397 / 684

GUEST BATHROOM

Shower or Tub

Decide what stays.

Take out every bottle and turn it over. This is where the household's rejected products retire: the shampoo nobody liked, the body wash that smells wrong, the conditioner welded to the shelf. Keep one shampoo, one conditioner, one body wash, all readable and more than a third full. The rest go, along with the old razor and the ...

STRAIGHTEN 398 / 684

GUEST BATHROOM

Shower or Tub

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Hang the caddy or fit a corner shelf so nothing stands directly on the tub floor collecting water underneath it. A bar of soap gets a draining dish, never a puddle. Put a hook inside the door at a height someone can reach with wet hands and no glasses on.

SHINE 399 / 684

GUEST BATHROOM

Shower or Tub

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Start with the mold, because it needs time you should not spend standing there: spray the grout lines and the bottom band of the curtain liner, go clean the rest of the room, then come back and rinse. A fabric liner goes in the washing machine rather than getting scrubbed by hand.

SAFETY 400 / 684

GUEST BATHROOM

Shower or Tub

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Fall: your guest is stepping into an unfamiliar tub, probably at night, on a surface they cannot judge the grip of. Put a non-slip mat or adhesive strips on the tub floor and make sure there is one thing solidly anchored to grab, because a towel bar screwed into drywall will tear straight out the moment it takes a person's ...

STANDARDIZE 401 / 684

GUEST BATHROOM

Shower or Tub

Write down what good looks like.

Three bottles, one soap, one mat, one anchored grab point, and no personal items. If the shower has stood unused for a month, run it hot for a minute before a guest arrives, which clears the stale water sitting in the line and proves the drain is still running freely.

SUSTAIN 402 / 684

GUEST BATHROOM

Shower or Tub

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

Whoever used it last squeegees the glass or shakes out the liner and drapes the bath mat over the tub rim. Since that person is often a guest who will not know, the host has a second version on departure: whatever they left in the shower comes out with the sheets. Slip is a pink line along the bottom edge of the liner or the ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Three bottles in the caddy, all recognizable and more than a third full, a curtain liner or glass screen with no pink film along the bottom edge, a bath mat folded over the tub rim rather than lying wet on the ...

SORT 403 / 684

GUEST BATHROOM

Toilet Area

Decide what stays.

Clear everything from the top of the tank and the floor behind the bowl: the collection of air fresheners, the second brush, the magazines, the box of something nobody has identified in years. One reserve roll stays in the open. Nothing else.

STRAIGHTEN 404 / 684

GUEST BATHROOM

Toilet Area

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Put the reserve roll where a seated person can reach it without getting up, since that is the entire point of a reserve roll. Set the brush and the trash can on the side away from the door swing so nobody kicks either one on the way in.

SHINE 405 / 684

GUEST BATHROOM

Toilet Area

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Treat the bowl first and let it sit under the rim and at the water line while you work outward: seat hinges, then the base of the pedestal, then the floor behind it, which is where splash and dust collect and where the smell in a guest bathroom actually comes from. Use a cloth in a color you use nowhere else in the house.

SAFETY 406 / 684

GUEST BATHROOM

Toilet Area

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Poison, choke, or strangle: a bottle of bowl cleaner parked behind the pedestal sits at a crawling child's eye level, usually with the cap loose. It goes back in the cleaning bin with the cap tight every time. It never shares a shelf with bleach, because bleach and an acid bowl cleaner mixed in a small room with the door shut ...

STANDARDIZE 407 / 684

GUEST BATHROOM

Toilet Area

Write down what good looks like.

One visible reserve roll, backstock in the cabinet, brush dry in its holder, liner in the can, no ring at the water line. Write those five lines on a card and stand it in the cleaning bin, so the person holding the brush reads the standard at the moment they are able to meet it.

SUSTAIN 408 / 684

GUEST BATHROOM

Toilet Area

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

Trash collection night is liner night in here. You are already standing in the room with a bag in your hand, so drop in a new liner and check the reserve roll is upright before you leave. Under a minute. Slip is a can with no liner, or a missing reserve roll, both visible from the door without bending. Recovery is those two ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

One spare roll standing in plain sight on the tank or in a holder a seated person can reach without standing up. A brush that is dry, resting in a holder with no liquid pooled in the bottom. A small trash can ...

SORT 409 / 684

GUEST BATHROOM

Guest Linen Zone

Decide what stays.

Unfold every towel and look at it in daylight rather than closet light. Anything thin along the fold line, permanently gray, stiff from too much softener, or carrying a hair dye or nosebleed stain comes out of the guest stack. It becomes a rag or a car towel today. It does not go back just in case.

STRAIGHTEN 410 / 684

GUEST BATHROOM

Guest Linen Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Store as complete sets rather than in stacks of like with like. Bath towel, hand towel, and washcloth folded into a single bundle so setting up for a visitor is one lift instead of three searches. Two bundles ready covers most households, and the bath mat lives underneath them.

SHINE 411 / 684

GUEST BATHROOM

Guest Linen Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Wash the stored set hot even though nobody has used it, because a towel that has sat folded in a closed closet all season carries a musty note that appears the instant it gets wet. Wipe the shelf, then run your hand along the back wall of the closet, since damp there is what the towels have been drinking.

SAFETY 412 / 684

GUEST BATHROOM

Guest Linen Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Burn or fire: if this closet also holds the water heater, towels pressed against the tank, a hot pipe, or the heater's cable are a scorch and fire risk that no amount of neat folding fixes. Leave a hand's width of clearance around anything that gets hot, and never let a stack lean on the unit or trap its cable behind it.

STANDARDIZE 413 / 684

GUEST BATHROOM

Guest Linen Zone

Write down what good looks like.

Two complete bundles on the marked shelf with the bath mat beneath, and a mark on the shelf edge showing where the second bundle ends. When one is missing, the gap reads as a gap without anyone counting.

SUSTAIN 414 / 684

GUEST BATHROOM

Guest Linen Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

Departure is the trigger and it covers both rooms at once, so the used bathroom set comes off the rail into the same wash as the sheets. One load, one afternoon. The mark on the shelf edge shows where the second bundle ends, so slip is a gap rather than a count, read with the door open. Recovery is completing the missing bundle ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

One bundle per expected guest, each holding a bath towel, a hand towel, and a washcloth folded together, matching in color, smelling of nothing at all. A clean bath mat folded flat beneath the bundles. A ...

SORT 415 / 684

LAUNDRY ROOM

Washer and Dryer

Decide what stays.

Clear the tops of both machines and the inside of both drums. The single sock behind the agitator, the hardened box of dryer sheets, the bottle of softener you stopped using: all of it comes off the machines now rather than being shuffled sideways.

STRAIGHTEN 416 / 684

LAUNDRY ROOM

Washer and Dryer

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Machine lids carry nothing. Put the vent brush and the pack of machine cleaner tablets on the shelf above, so the lids open freely and a knocked cap cannot roll down behind the drum where nobody retrieves it.

SHINE 417 / 684

LAUNDRY ROOM

Washer and Dryer

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Lift the folds of the door gasket and wipe out the coins, hairpins, and gray slime that collect in there. Wash the detergent drawer in the sink, then run a hot cycle with a cleaner tablet in the empty drum.

SAFETY 418 / 684

LAUNDRY ROOM

Washer and Dryer

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Clear the lint screen every single load, then check the duct behind the dryer for the soft gray packing that builds where the pipe bends. Lint plus heat is a fire, and a crushed foil accordion duct traps far more of it than a smooth rigid pipe does.

STANDARDIZE 419 / 684

LAUNDRY ROOM

Washer and Dryer

Write down what good looks like.

Write the month on masking tape stuck to the side of the dryer each time you clear the duct, so the next check is a glance instead of an argument with your memory. A standard is the best way you know today, written down.

SUSTAIN 420 / 684

LAUNDRY ROOM

Washer and Dryer

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

When the dryer buzzer sounds the lint screen gets cleared before the door closes again, by whoever is unloading. That one motion, every load, is the whole machine standard. The tape on the side of the dryer carries the month you last cleared the duct, so the bigger job has a written date. Slip is a screen with a visible mat on ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Both drums empty with the washer door propped ajar, nothing at all sitting on either lid, a clean lint screen back in its slot, and a strip of masking tape on the side of the dryer with the month you last ...

SORT 421 / 684

LAUNDRY ROOM

Detergent and Treatment Zone

Decide what stays.

Line every bottle, stick, spray and pod tub up on the floor. Anything crusted shut at the neck, anything with the label washed off, and anything bought for one stain that already came out goes to the disposal pile. Two open jugs of the same detergent become one jug in use and one refill.

STRAIGHTEN 422 / 684

LAUNDRY ROOM

Detergent and Treatment Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

The everyday detergent and its dosing cap sit within arm's reach of the open washer lid, because that is where you use them. Bleach and the stain sprays go behind them on a tray, and the pod tub goes higher than a child can reach on tiptoe from an upturned laundry basket.

SHINE 423 / 684

LAUNDRY ROOM

Detergent and Treatment Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Detergent drips, always. Wipe the spigot on the jug and the shelf under it, then stand every container on a shallow tray so the next drip lands on plastic you can rinse rather than a shelf that stays tacky for a year.

SAFETY 424 / 684

LAUNDRY ROOM

Detergent and Treatment Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Bleach and any ammonia based cleaner never share a shelf, and never share a bucket. The pod tub gets a latched lid or a high shelf without exception, because a detergent pod looks exactly like a sweet to a toddler and bursts in the mouth.

STANDARDIZE 425 / 684

LAUNDRY ROOM

Detergent and Treatment Zone

Write down what good looks like.

Mark the true dose line on the cap with a permanent marker, since the molded cap is bigger than the dose almost every time. Write the job on the tray edge under each bottle, wash, whites, stains, so a returned bottle lands back in its own footprint.

SUSTAIN 426 / 684

LAUNDRY ROOM

Detergent and Treatment Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

When you pour the last dose out of a jug, the empty goes straight to recycling and the replacement onto the shopping list before you press start on that load. Whoever emptied it does both, while it is still in their hand. Slip is an unlabeled bottle on the tray, or two open jugs of the same product, seen without picking ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

One working detergent, one bleach, one tub of oxygen powder and one stain treatment standing on a wipeable tray, the pod tub latched and above shoulder height, the true dose line inked on the cap, and not one ...

SORT 427 / 684

LAUNDRY ROOM

Sorting and Hamper Zone

Decide what stays.

Empty every hamper and see what a real week actually produces: whites, darks, towels, delicates, work clothes. Any stream that never fills on its own gets merged into another, and the spare hampers you were holding for those streams leave the room.

STRAIGHTEN 428 / 684

LAUNDRY ROOM

Sorting and Hamper Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

One bag per stream, standing where clothes are actually taken off rather than where the bags happen to fit. Add a small dish on the shelf for pocket contents, because coins, hair ties and the occasional memory stick need somewhere to land that is not the drum.

SHINE 429 / 684

LAUNDRY ROOM

Sorting and Hamper Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Damp gym kit is what makes a hamper smell, not dirt. Wipe the inside of each bin while it is empty, and never let a wet towel spend the night in a lined bag with the lid down.

SAFETY 430 / 684

LAUNDRY ROOM

Sorting and Hamper Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

A hamper parked on a landing or at the top of a step is a fall you take with your arms full and your view blocked. Keep the bags out of the walking line entirely, and never carry a basket loaded higher than your eyeline.

STANDARDIZE 431 / 684

LAUNDRY ROOM

Sorting and Hamper Zone

Write down what good looks like.

Label each bag with the load it makes rather than the color it holds: hot towels, cold darks, gentle. Anyone in the house can then start a machine without asking which setting the bag wants.

SUSTAIN 432 / 684

LAUNDRY ROOM

Sorting and Hamper Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

Pockets get checked as the item goes into the bag, not later at the machine, and every person does their own. The dish on the shelf is where a lip balm stops being a ruined load. Slip is a bag past half full, or a bag standing in the walking line, visible as you come through the door. Recovery is running that load now, because ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Three labeled bags standing clear of the walking line, each below half full, a small dish on the shelf holding nothing older than today, and bare floor in front of the washer door.

SORT

433 / 684

LAUNDRY ROOM

Folding Surface

Decide what stays.

Clear the counter right down, including everything that was never laundry: the post, the toolbox, the parcel waiting to be returned, the vase from Christmas. Whatever is parked here is the reason a dry load goes back in for a second tumble.

STRAIGHTEN

434 / 684

LAUNDRY ROOM

Folding Surface

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Keep one basket per person or per bedroom under the counter, so folding and delivering are the same motion rather than two separate jobs. Hangers live on a rail at the end, not in a tangled heap you have to unpick before you can use one.

SHINE

435 / 684

LAUNDRY ROOM

Folding Surface

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Wipe the counter before you fold, not after. Clean clothes pick up whatever detergent dust and lint the last load shed here, and a folding board skates badly over grit.

SAFETY

436 / 684

LAUNDRY ROOM

Folding Surface

Fix what could hurt somebody.

If you iron on this counter, the iron gets one heatproof rest and the cord runs behind it where no arm can hook through. When you step away, unplug at the wall rather than trusting the switch or the auto shutoff.

STANDARDIZE

437 / 684

LAUNDRY ROOM

Folding Surface

Write down what good looks like.

The counter is either completely empty or holding exactly one load in progress. There is no third state. Photograph it empty and tape the photo inside the cupboard door so nobody has to guess what clear means.

SUSTAIN

438 / 684

LAUNDRY ROOM

Folding Surface

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

Tip the basket out onto the counter rather than setting it down full, by whoever carried it in. A heap on the counter gets dealt with because the surface is needed, ten minutes a load, while a full basket on the floor keeps its clothes another day. Slip has one absolute definition here: any clean clothing in this room that is ...

> **THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN**
> A counter bare enough to roll pastry on, one empty basket per bedroom stacked underneath it, six spare hangers on the rail at the end, and no clean clothing anywhere in the room.

SORT

439 / 684

LAUNDRY ROOM

Hanging and Air-Dry Zone

Decide what stays.

Strip the rack completely. Anything still damp goes back on, anything dry goes to its drawer right now, and the wool sweater that has been draped over the end rung since spring either goes away properly or leaves the house.

STRAIGHTEN

440 / 684

LAUNDRY ROOM

Hanging and Air-Dry Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

The rack gets one spot with a drip tray underneath, not wherever the last load abandoned it. Hang bras, wool and swimwear on the top rungs where air actually moves, and keep the bottom rungs for flat items that can take the slower dry.

SHINE

441 / 684

LAUNDRY ROOM

Hanging and Air-Dry Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

A rack that is stored damp grows a musty smell and passes it straight to the next load hung on it. Wipe the bars dry when you strip it, and fold it flat so both faces get air rather than pressing wet metal against wet metal.

SAFETY 442 / 684

LAUNDRY ROOM

Hanging and Air-Dry Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Water on a hard floor under a drying rack is a slip you take in socks with an armful of laundry. Keep the drip tray in place, and never stand the rack where drips can reach a wall outlet or a plugged in extension lead running along the baseboard.

STANDARDIZE 443 / 684

LAUNDRY ROOM

Hanging and Air-Dry Zone

Write down what good looks like.

The rack is either in use holding one set of damp items, or folded flat against the wall. Nothing has permanent residence on the rungs, and no garment starts a second night up there without a reason you could say out loud.

SUSTAIN 444 / 684

LAUNDRY ROOM

Hanging and Air-Dry Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

Before you open the washer to start the next load, you clear the rack. Anything dry comes off first, so the rack is always ready for the load you are about to run, and it belongs to whoever is starting it. Slip is anything hanging that was washed before today, and you can tell by touch in two seconds. Recovery is carrying those ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

The rack folded flat against the wall with dry bars, its drip tray wiped out and empty, the rail holding six spare hangers, and nothing hanging that was washed before today.

SORT 445 / 684

LAUNDRY ROOM

Utility and Cleaning Zone

Decide what stays.

Stand every tool up in the open: the broom, the mop, the dustpan, the vacuum hose and its attachments, the sack of rags. Two brooms become one broom. The crevice tool that fits no vacuum you still own goes out today.

STRAIGHTEN 446 / 684

LAUNDRY ROOM

Utility and Cleaning Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Hang the broom, mop and dustpan on a wall rail with the heads uppermost and clear of the floor, because bristles resting on concrete splay and then re-soil the floor they touch. Vacuum attachments live in one labeled caddy, so a missing one is visible rather than assumed.

SHINE 447 / 684

LAUNDRY ROOM

Utility and Cleaning Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Rinse the mop head and hang it to dry before it goes back on the rail, and empty the vacuum canister before you store it. A mop put away wet and gray spreads that water back down the next floor it touches.

SAFETY 448 / 684

LAUNDRY ROOM

Utility and Cleaning Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

A broom handle leaned against the wall behind a door swings and falls at head height the moment the door opens. Everything is hung or in a bin, nothing leans. Drain cleaner and bleach in this corner sit on a shelf above the mop bucket, never inside it where a rinse could mix them.

STANDARDIZE 449 / 684

LAUNDRY ROOM

Utility and Cleaning Zone

Write down what good looks like.

Paint or tape an outline behind each hook so a missing tool shows from the doorway, and give the bucket a taped square of floor that belongs to it alone. The room then reports its own state without anyone opening a cupboard.

SUSTAIN 450 / 684

LAUNDRY ROOM

Utility and Cleaning Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

When you clear the lint screen at the end of a wash day, sweep the strip of floor in front of the machines with the broom hanging an arm's length away. Two minutes, by whoever finished the wash day. The painted outlines do the reporting, because a visible outline with nothing in front of it means that tool is elsewhere in the ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Broom, mop and dustpan hanging heads up with painted outlines showing behind each one, a single labeled caddy holding every vacuum attachment, a mop head that is dry to the touch, and the bucket sitting inside ...

SORT 451 / 684

HOME OFFICE

Primary Desk

Decide what stays.

Take everything off the surface and onto the floor, then put back only what the task in front of you needs, plus the inbox tray. The dead pens, the second mug, and the fringe of sticky notes around the screen do not go back up.

STRAIGHTEN 452 / 684

HOME OFFICE

Primary Desk

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Keyboard square in front of the monitor, notebook on your writing-hand side, phone face down beyond it, and the whole sweep the mouse travels left bare so you are never steering around a stapler.

SHINE 453 / 684

HOME OFFICE

Primary Desk

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Power down, wipe the screen with cleaner sprayed onto the microfiber cloth, then do the desk edge and the underside lip where your forearms rest, which is the grubbiest part of the whole room.

SAFETY 454 / 684

HOME OFFICE

Primary Desk

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Lift the power strip off the floor onto a hook on the desk leg, and check that no charging cable crosses the arc the chair rolls through. Your feet should find nothing under there.

STANDARDIZE 455 / 684

HOME OFFICE

Primary Desk

Write down what good looks like.

Photograph the cleared desk and tape the print inside the top drawer, so the word clear stops being a matter of opinion in this household.

SUSTAIN 456 / 684

HOME OFFICE

Primary Desk

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

When you shut the laptop lid at the end of the working day, reset the surface to match the photo before you stand up. Two minutes, and it is yours alone. Next morning is too late, because by then the pile has been there since last night and reads as normal. Slip is the photo comparison plus one number, since an inbox tray ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

The monitor, keyboard, and mouse in fixed positions, one notebook, one inbox tray holding fewer than a dozen sheets, no sticky notes on the monitor bezel, and the power strip hooked off the floor so the chair ...

SORT 457 / 684

HOME OFFICE

Desk Drawers and Pedestal

Decide what stays.

Tip the top drawer onto the cleared desk and test every pen on scrap paper. Dried highlighters, bent paperclips, loose staples, dead batteries, and chargers whose device you cannot point at in this house all go now.

STRAIGHTEN 458 / 684

HOME OFFICE

Desk Drawers and Pedestal

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Daily hand tools live in the divided tray up top, hanging files fill the deep pedestal drawer, and the two never mix. The stapler does not end up riding on the folders, and no folder gets laid flat across the pens.

SHINE 459 / 684

HOME OFFICE

Desk Drawers and Pedestal

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Vacuum the drawer bottoms, which collect eraser crumbs, loose staples and paperclip fuzz, then wipe the runners so the drawer closes without a shove. Lift the divided tray out and clean under it rather than around it, because that is where the ink and the pencil dust settle. Finish at the drawer fronts, wiping around the ...

SAFETY 460 / 684

HOME OFFICE

Desk Drawers and Pedestal

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Scissors and the letter opener get their own slot with points facing the back of the drawer, because you reach into this drawer blind while looking at the screen.

STANDARDIZE 461 / 684

HOME OFFICE

Desk Drawers and Pedestal

Write down what good looks like.

Write what each drawer front holds, in the words this house actually uses, so tape and stamps are found without pulling three drawers. One purpose per drawer, and the scissors keep a fixed slot point-down rather than floating among the pens. The test of a label is not whether you can read it. It is whether somebody else in the ...

SUSTAIN 462 / 684

HOME OFFICE

Desk Drawers and Pedestal

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

When you sit down to pay the household bills, put back into the drawers anything that migrated onto the desk that week. Five minutes inside a job already booked. Two signals are worth acting on: a pen that does not write on the first stroke, and file tabs that no longer run in one straight line. Recovery is testing the pen cup ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

A top drawer with a divided tray holding pens that all write, one stapler, one pair of scissors point-down in its own slot, and a deep pedestal drawer of hanging files with tabs all standing in one line.

SORT 463 / 684

HOME OFFICE

File Storage

Decide what stays.

Work one drawer at a time into three piles: keep as paper, scan then shred, shred now. Tax paper by year, warranties and manuals only for machines still in this house, and no folder for anything the issuer will reprint on request.

STRAIGHTEN 464 / 684

HOME OFFICE

File Storage

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

File by the question you will ask when you go hunting, so "car", "house", "health", "school", rather than by document type. Nobody has ever gone looking for a folder called Correspondence.

SHINE 465 / 684

HOME OFFICE

File Storage

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Filing is where you inspect: check the drawer bottom for damp, look for silverfish, and photograph any thermal receipt that has started to fade before the print disappears entirely.

SAFETY 466 / 684

HOME OFFICE

File Storage

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Get the permanent originals out of a cardboard box on top of the cabinet and into a closed fireproof box at floor level, and keep the paper mass away from the power strip and any heater.

STANDARDIZE 467 / 684

HOME OFFICE

File Storage

Write down what good looks like.

Write your retention rule on a card and tape it inside the top drawer, naming which categories are permanent, which run by tax year, and which get scanned. A standard is the best way you know today, written down.

SUSTAIN 468 / 684

HOME OFFICE

File Storage

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

When the new tax paperwork arrives each year, that is the signal to pull and shred the oldest year past your retention period. One in, one out, and the drawer never overflows again. About an hour, by whoever handles the tax. Slip is physical: a drawer you compress to file into, or a shred bag by the door that has been full ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Hanging folders labeled by the question you would ask when looking, tabs all in the same position so your eye runs one straight line, a closed fireproof box holding the permanent originals, and a full shred ...

SORT 469 / 684

HOME OFFICE

Bookshelf and Reference Zone

Decide what stays.

Take every book, binder, and manual off the shelves. Appliance manuals for machines that left the house, superseded editions with a year in the title, and binders from projects that finished all go out in one pass.

STRAIGHTEN 470 / 684

HOME OFFICE

Bookshelf and Reference Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Group by why you reach: working reference at eye level from where you sit, occasional reading at standing height, archive boxes highest, heavy binders lowest.

SHINE 471 / 684

HOME OFFICE

Bookshelf and Reference Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Dust from the top shelf down with a dry cloth, wipe the front edge of each shelf, and vacuum the top edges of the books themselves, which is where the dust in this room actually settles.

SAFETY 472 / 684

HOME OFFICE

Bookshelf and Reference Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Screw the unit into the wall studs, and move the box files, binders, and any framed glass award off the high shelf that sits above where your head is when you are working.

STANDARDIZE 473 / 684

HOME OFFICE

Bookshelf and Reference Zone

Write down what good looks like.

A bookend closes every group, and a hand's width of empty shelf stays at the end of each row. When a shelf has no slack left, that is the visible signal that a book has to leave, not that you need another shelf.

SUSTAIN 474 / 684

HOME OFFICE

Bookshelf and Reference Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

When you finish a book or close out a project binder, it does not go back on the shelf by reflex. It gets the keep-or-go question at that moment, while the answer is still obvious. The slack is the gauge, so a shelf with no hand's width left is telling you a book has to leave rather than that you need another shelf. Recovery is ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Working reference at seated eye level from the desk chair, heavy binders and box files on the bottom two shelves, a bookend closing each group, a hand's width of empty shelf left at the end of every row, and ...

SORT 475 / 684

HOME OFFICE

Printer and Scanning Station

Decide what stays.

Keep only ink or toner that matches the model number on the printer currently plugged in. The half reams of odd paper, the letterhead with the old address, and the envelopes from two houses ago go out.

STRAIGHTEN 476 / 684

HOME OFFICE

Printer and Scanning Station

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Paper goes directly under the printer, the spare cartridge in a labeled box beside it, and the scan pile gets one tray with a to-do side and a done side, so you can tell at a glance what has already been through the glass.

SHINE 477 / 684

HOME OFFICE

Printer and Scanning Station

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Powered off, lift the lid and clean the scanner glass with cleaner on the cloth, never sprayed onto the glass where it can run inside. Use a dry cloth for toner dust and vacuum the paper lint around the feed tray.

SAFETY 478 / 684

HOME OFFICE

Printer and Scanning Station

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Leave clear air at the back of the machine, because the fuser runs genuinely hot, and plug the printer straight into a wall outlet rather than into a strip chained off another strip. Nothing sits on top of the lid, not the plant and not your drink.

STANDARDIZE 479 / 684

HOME OFFICE

Printer and Scanning Station

Write down what good looks like.

Draw a min line and a max line inside the paper bin. When the stack drops to the min line, the next ream goes on the shopping list that day, not the day it runs out mid-job.

SUSTAIN 480 / 684

HOME OFFICE

Printer and Scanning Station

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

When you pull the last sheet from the bin, refill it from the shelf before you walk away, while you are already standing there. Ten seconds, by whoever took that sheet. The min line inside the bin is the earlier signal, because at the line the next ream goes on the shopping list that day. Anything on the machine lid is the ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Paper in a bin directly beneath the printer with a min line and a max line drawn inside it, one spare cartridge in a labeled box beside it, a single scan tray with a to-do side and a done side, clear air ...

SORT 481 / 684

HOME OFFICE

Supply Cabinet

Decide what stays.

Bring everything out and line it up on the floor in categories so you can see the true count, because a dozen packs of sticky notes look like nothing until they stand side by side. Dried glue sticks, dead markers, cracked folders, and adapters nobody can identify leave.

STRAIGHTEN 482 / 684

HOME OFFICE

Supply Cabinet

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

One open pack of each consumable at hand height, its backstock immediately behind it on the same shelf, so restocking the pen tray is a single reach rather than a hunt through three boxes of envelopes.

SHINE 483 / 684

HOME OFFICE

Supply Cabinet

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Wipe the shelves and check for a pen that has leaked, a split toner pouch, or the sticky ring under a roll of tape that has gone soft.

SAFETY 484 / 684

HOME OFFICE

Supply Cabinet

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Reams of paper and boxes of envelopes are heavy and they belong on the bottom shelf, not overhead. Put an actual step stool in this room and stop standing on the rolling chair to reach the top shelf.

STANDARDIZE 485 / 684

HOME OFFICE

Supply Cabinet

Write down what good looks like.

Write min and max on a card at the front edge of each shelf, so a low stock is visible from the doorway and anyone in the house can read the cabinet without asking you.

SUSTAIN 486 / 684

HOME OFFICE

Supply Cabinet

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

When you open the last pack of something, it goes onto the household shopping list on the fridge before you break the seal, not after it runs out. Fifteen seconds, by whoever opened it. The min and max cards on the shelf edges are the visible check, so anyone can read this cabinet from the doorway without asking you. Recovery ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

One open pack of each consumable at hand height with its backstock directly behind it, reams of paper on the bottom shelf, min and max written on a card at the front edge of each shelf, and a step stool ...

SORT 487 / 684

GARAGE

Primary Workbench

Decide what stays.

Clear the top down to bare wood. Every screw living in a jar lid, every glue bottle with a plugged nozzle, and every offcut you saved because the grain looked too good to bin gets a verdict before anything is allowed back up.

STRAIGHTEN 488 / 684

GARAGE

Primary Workbench

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Give the vise its own corner and keep a full arm's length of open top in front of it, because that is the space a long board swings through. Clamps go on the rail within reach and fasteners in the drawer directly beneath. The post that comes in, the half-tin of paint, and the parcel waiting to go back are not bench items and ...

SHINE 489 / 684

GARAGE

Primary Workbench

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Vacuum sawdust and metal filings out of the bench dog holes and the seam where the top meets the back wall, then wipe the vise screw down and put a drop of oil on it.

SAFETY 490 / 684

GARAGE

Primary Workbench

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Check the bench outlet and the task light cord for nicks, and confirm you can plug the sander in without a lead crossing the strip of floor you stand on. Chisels and utility blades never rest edge-up on the top, where a hand sweeps sawdust without looking.

STANDARDIZE 491 / 684

GARAGE

Primary Workbench

Write down what good looks like.

Tape a photo of the cleared bench, vise and task light and nothing else, on the wall directly behind it at eye height. When you look up and see a paint tin or a coil of wire that the photo does not show, that is the next thing to leave.

SUSTAIN 492 / 684

GARAGE

Primary Workbench

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

A project is not over when the glue sets. It is over when the clamps are back on the rail, the offcuts are in the scrap bin and the top is swept, all before the task light goes off. Pulling the last plug out of the bench outlet is the signal to sweep, not the clock on your phone. Ten minutes, by whoever ran the job. Slip is ...

> **THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN**
> A bare bench top holding only the vise and the task light, one tray with the current job in it, clamps racked on the rail, and swept concrete visible under the bench.

SORT 493 / 684

GARAGE

Hand Tool Wall and Cabinets

Decide what stays.

Pull every hammer, screwdriver, plier, and wrench onto one sheet on the floor and count the duplicates honestly. Pliers rusted shut, wrenches with rounded jaws, and drivers with chewed tips are scrap metal, not spares, and keeping them means hunting past them forever.

STRAIGHTEN 494 / 684

GARAGE

Hand Tool Wall and Cabinets

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Hang by how often your hand reaches, not by tool family. Tape measure, utility knife, and the number two driver go at chest height nearest the door, because those three come off the wall for jobs that take under a minute. Pipe wrenches and socket sets sit lower and further along.

SHINE 495 / 684

GARAGE

Hand Tool Wall and Cabinets

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Wipe each tool with an oiled rag as it goes back up, and wipe the pegboard behind it. Rust starts at the handle end, where hands leave salt.

SAFETY 496 / 684

GARAGE

Hand Tool Wall and Cabinets

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Handsaws and chisels get a sheath or a blade guard before they touch the wall. Seat every pegboard hook properly, because a heavy wrench knocked off a shallow hook lands on a foot, and put a latch on the low cabinet if children ever come out here.

STANDARDIZE 497 / 684

GARAGE

Hand Tool Wall and Cabinets

Write down what good looks like.

Trace the silhouette of every tool onto the board in marker or paint. An empty outline tells you the tenon saw is missing without you having to remember that you own one.

SUSTAIN 498 / 684

GARAGE

Hand Tool Wall and Cabinets

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

The driver goes back on its outline before you fold the step ladder away, not at the weekend, and the person who took it down puts it back, which costs the five seconds of hanging it. Slip is a blank outline, needing no memory at all, because the wall tells you the tenon saw is missing without you remembering you own one ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Every hand tool hanging on its own drawn outline with no blank silhouettes, one hammer and one adjustable wrench at chest height nearest the door, saw teeth sheathed, and the cabinet latched.

SORT 499 / 684

GARAGE

Power Tool and Battery Zone

Decide what stays.

Line every pack up and run it in the tool it belongs to until you know which ones still hold a charge. Packs that die in a minute, chargers for the drill you sold, and the sander with the taped cord all leave today.

STRAIGHTEN 500 / 684

GARAGE

Power Tool and Battery Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Group by battery system rather than by task, so one shelf carries the tools, packs, and charger of a single platform and you stop carrying a green pack to a red tool. Blades, drill bits, and sanding discs go in a shallow drawer directly beneath the tools that take them.

SHINE 501 / 684

GARAGE

Power Tool and Battery Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Brush or blow the motor vents on each drill and saw clear of packed dust, and clean the battery contacts and the charger terminals. A vent clogged with plaster dust runs a motor hot enough to shorten its life.

SAFETY 502 / 684

GARAGE

Power Tool and Battery Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Packs come off the charger once they are full and sit at partial charge on a shelf well clear of the fuel can and the rag bin. Confirm every blade guard springs back freely on its own, and retire any tool with a cracked case rather than pushing it behind the others.

STANDARDIZE 503 / 684

GARAGE

Power Tool and Battery Zone

Write down what good looks like.

One shelf label per battery system, charger mounted at the front edge, so a pack left charging shows as a lump on the shelf edge you can see from the doorway without walking in.

SUSTAIN 504 / 684

GARAGE

Power Tool and Battery Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

Pulling a full pack off the charger is part of finishing the job, the same as putting the drill back in its case. The second net is the side door, because locking up at night takes you past the charger shelf and anything still on a charger comes off on the way. Slip is a lump on the shelf edge, visible from the doorway, which ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

One shelf per battery system with its charger mounted at the front edge and no pack sitting on it, every drill and saw in its case or on a labeled hook with guards down, and bits, blades, and sanding discs in ...

SORT 505 / 684

GARAGE

Automotive Care Zone

Decide what stays.

Line every bottle up and read the label out loud. Oil in a weight your current engine does not take, coolant for the van you sold, and the half bottle whose label has soaked away into unreadable gray all come out of the row.

STRAIGHTEN 506 / 684

GARAGE

Automotive Care Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Fluids stand upright on a shallow drip tray at waist height, where a weeping cap shows as a ring rather than soaking into a shelf. Jumper cables, tire gauge, and lug wrench live together in one bag right by the door, because you go for those with a dead engine, in the dark, in a hurry.

SHINE 507 / 684

GARAGE

Automotive Care Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Wipe every bottle shoulder and check the tray for the ring that says something is seeping. Wash the wash mitts and microfibre towels on their own, never with house laundry, so grit and old wax stay out of the good towels.

SAFETY 508 / 684

GARAGE

Automotive Care Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Petrol and any can that has ever held it stays out of the house envelope, capped tight, and never on a shelf near the water heater's pilot flame. Polish and oil rags go into a metal can with a lid, not the plastic bin.

STANDARDIZE 509 / 684

GARAGE

Automotive Care Zone

Write down what good looks like.

Label the tray shelf with exactly what belongs on it, and mark every bottle with the month you opened it. Brake fluid pulls water out of the air and coolant goes off once the seal is broken, and the date is the only way you will ever know which is which.

SUSTAIN 510 / 684

GARAGE

Automotive Care Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

You already lift the bonnet to check the oil. While it is up, look along the tray for a fresh ring, and an empty bottle goes into the bin instead of back into the row. Twenty seconds, by whoever does the oil check. A ring on the tray is the leak signal, which is why the tray is pale, and the second check is ownership, because a ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Every fluid bottle standing upright on a clean drip tray with its opened date written on the shoulder, jumper cables and tire gauge together in one bag by the door, rags in a closed metal can, and not a single ...

SORT 511 / 684

GARAGE

Sports and Recreation Zone

Decide what stays.

Carry every helmet, ball, racket, and pair of cleats out onto the driveway and match each one to a person who plays that sport now. Cleats a size too small and the paddle from that one river trip do not come back through the door.

STRAIGHTEN 512 / 684

GARAGE

Sports and Recreation Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Bikes hang on wall hooks nearest the door so nobody unhooks three to get one out on a Saturday morning. Balls go in a tall bin or a bungee-front rack rather than loose on the floor where they roll under the car, and this season's kit sits at the front of the shelf with the off-season behind it.

SHINE 513 / 684

GARAGE

Sports and Recreation Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Air out and wipe down helmet liners and shin pads, hose the mud off cleats and dry them right through before they go back, and leave the cooler propped open with a rag of baking soda inside so it does not come out smelling of last summer.

SAFETY 514 / 684

GARAGE

Sports and Recreation Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

A helmet that has taken one real impact is finished even if the shell looks perfect, and so is one past the date molded inside it. Overhead bike hooks must be rated and driven into studs, never drywall anchors, and never hung where a car door swings open into a hanging wheel.

STANDARDIZE 515 / 684

GARAGE

Sports and Recreation Zone

Write down what good looks like.

One labeled bin per activity, and the label carries the sport plus the name of the person it belongs to. Gear that fits no named bin has no owner in this house and does not stay in it.

SUSTAIN 516 / 684

GARAGE

Sports and Recreation Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

The front and back of the shelf trade places the first weekend you turn the heating on, and again the first weekend you leave the windows open all day. Weather calls it, one adult announces it, half an hour. Slip in between is out of season kit at the front, or a bin whose label carries no person's name, which means that gear ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Bikes on wall hooks with bare floor beneath them, one labeled bin per activity, this season's kit at the front of the shelf, and every helmet in the garage belonging to a head that still wears it.

SORT 517 / 684

GARAGE

Lawn and Garden Tool Zone

Decide what stays.

Out go the rake with three tines left, the hose with the split you have meant to patch for two summers, and the cracked nursery pots kept for seedlings you never started. Count your spades honestly, because most garages hold four and dig with one.

STRAIGHTEN 518 / 684

GARAGE

Lawn and Garden Tool Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Long handles hang head-up on a rail so no fork stands loose in a corner waiting to be trodden on. The hose lives on a reel beside the door it goes out of, not coiled on the slab. Fertiliser, weed killer, and seed share one shelf with a lip on it, well away from the cooler and anything else that touches food or skin.

SHINE 519 / 684

GARAGE

Lawn and Garden Tool Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Scrape caked soil off the spade and hoe blades, wipe them with an oily rag, and run a file along the spade edge so it bites next time. Empty and rinse the spreader hopper, because leftover fertiliser eats the metal from the inside out over a winter.

SAFETY 520 / 684

GARAGE

Lawn and Garden Tool Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Garden chemicals stay in their original labeled containers on a latched shelf above child and pet height, never decanted into a drink bottle. String trimmers and hedge shears go up with guards fitted and cutting ends pointing away from the aisle you walk down.

STANDARDIZE 521 / 684

GARAGE

Lawn and Garden Tool Zone

Write down what good looks like.

A painted or taped strip on the wall behind each long handle, so a bare strip is a question you answer before you close the door. One sign on the chemical shelf reading "garden chemicals only, nothing else on this shelf."

SUSTAIN 522 / 684

GARAGE

Lawn and Garden Tool Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

The mower needs to cool before it goes away anyway, and that is the window when the spade gets scraped, wiped and hung back on its strip, by whoever cut the grass. Slip is a bare taped strip, or any long handle leaning in a corner, both read from the doorway. Recovery is scrape, wipe, hang, about a minute a tool. Wet is what ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Every long-handled tool hanging head-up on the rail with nothing leaning in a corner, the hose coiled on its reel beside the door it goes out of, and all garden chemicals in their original labeled containers ...

SORT 523 / 684

GARAGE

Bulk and Overhead Storage

Decide what stays.

Bring the bins down to the floor before you judge them, because nobody sorts honestly from the third step of a ladder with one arm through a lid. Start with the holiday bin that has not come down in three Decembers and the box marked "misc".

STRAIGHTEN 524 / 684

GARAGE

Bulk and Overhead Storage

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Heavy bins go on the lowest rack and light bulky things, folding chairs and the artificial tree, go highest. Group by the time of year they come down, so one December trip up the ladder brings the lights, the tree, and the wrapping bin down together.

SHINE 525 / 684

GARAGE

Bulk and Overhead Storage

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Wipe the lids. The depth of dust on an overhead lid tells you exactly how many years it has been since anything came out of that bin. While you are up there, look at the rack underside and the ceiling above it for the brown stain that means the roof is letting water in.

SAFETY 526 / 684

GARAGE

Bulk and Overhead Storage

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Nothing goes overhead that you cannot lift down with both hands on a stable ladder, and nothing you might need in the dark or in a hurry. Check that the rack bolts land in joists, not just in the plasterboard, and that loaded bins sit fully inside the rails rather than overhanging the roof of a parked car.

STANDARDIZE 527 / 684

GARAGE

Bulk and Overhead Storage

Write down what good looks like.

Every bin gets a large label you can read from the slab plus the month and year it was last opened. A map taped beside the light switch says which bay holds what, so nobody climbs a ladder simply to find out.

SUSTAIN 528 / 684

GARAGE

Bulk and Overhead Storage

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

The moment a bin is on the floor with its lid off, write the new month and year on the end before it goes back up. Ten seconds with the marker that lives by the switch. The dates read from the slab, so slip is a bin whose newest date is two Decembers old, and that bin comes down at the next clear-out rather than being lifted ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Every overhead bin labeled in letters you can read standing on the slab, a last-opened month and year on the end of each one, the heaviest bins on the lowest rack, nothing overhanging the parking bay, and a ...

SORT 529 / 684

WORKSHOP

Main Workbench

Decide what stays.

Clear the bench top and the shelf beneath it completely, then give every half-finished project a verdict: back on the bench with a date, or broken down into parts and stock. Snapped blades, glue bottles gone solid, and brackets you cannot identify leave now.

STRAIGHTEN 530 / 684

WORKSHOP

Main Workbench

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Hang the tools your hand reaches for mid-cut, the marking knife, the combination square, the block plane, within arm's reach of the vise, and put everything you use once a project on the wall behind. Traced silhouettes mean a missing chisel shows up before you finish vacuuming.

SHINE 531 / 684

WORKSHOP

Main Workbench

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Vacuum the bench top and the dog holes rather than brushing them out, then scrape dried glue drips off the surface before they telegraph into the next workpiece. Wipe the vise screw and give it a drop of oil.

SAFETY 532 / 684

WORKSHOP

Main Workbench

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Check the vise jaws still bite a test piece without slipping, and move the lamp cord so it does not lie across the part of the bench a handsaw crosses. A chisel lying edge up in an open tray is what your hand finds when you reach across the bench without looking.

STANDARDIZE 533 / 684

WORKSHOP

Main Workbench

Write down what good looks like.

Trace the outlines on the tool wall in permanent marker so a gap reads as a missing chisel, then take one photo of the cleared bench and tape it at eye level where you stand, because that photo is what bare means here.

SUSTAIN 534 / 684

WORKSHOP

Main Workbench

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

The last part of every session is the bench clear down, done before you take your safety glasses off, because once the glasses come off you are finished for the day and you know it. Ten minutes, by whoever was working. The photo taped at eye level settles what bare means, so slip is a comparison rather than a judgment, and ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

A bare bench top except the vise and the task lamp, one project tray holding the current job's parts, and a clear run of bench in front of the vise long enough to lay a board across. Every chisel and square ...

SORT 535 / 684

WORKSHOP

Power Tool Storage

Decide what stays.

Line up the duplicates and be honest about the second drill and the sander you replaced but kept. Battery packs that no longer hold a charge through one job are not spares, they are recycling, and taped cords are not tools.

STRAIGHTEN 536 / 684

WORKSHOP

Power Tool Storage

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Store each tool with the parts that make it usable: the circular saw with its rip fence and blade wrench, the router with its collet spanners and the bits it actually takes. Hunting for a collet spanner is how a router ends up used without one.

SHINE 537 / 684

WORKSHOP

Power Tool Storage

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Blow or brush the motor vents clear of packed sawdust, take the pitch off saw blades with resin remover so they stop burning cuts, and pull the clogged sanding pads.

SAFETY 538 / 684

WORKSHOP

Power Tool Storage

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Work the retracting guard on every saw with your thumb and confirm it snaps back on its own; a sticky guard is the injury waiting in this zone. Flex each cord at the strain relief where the sheath cracks first, and never leave a corded tool stored plugged in.

STANDARDIZE 539 / 684

WORKSHOP

Power Tool Storage

Write down what good looks like.

Label each tool's home on the wall or the shelf edge, and set one charge rule for the batteries: partial charge, off the charger when the job ends, resting on a shelf that is not wood.

SUSTAIN 540 / 684

WORKSHOP

Power Tool Storage

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

When a battery goes onto the charger at the end of a job, the tool it came off goes onto its hook in the same motion. The two travel together or neither happens, and the person who used the tool does both. Locking the shop door is the backstop, since no charger is left running behind it. Slip is a labeled home standing empty ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Each tool in a labeled home with its guard closed and its blade wrench or chuck key attached to it, not floating in a drawer. Batteries sitting on a shelf off the chargers, no bare circular saw blade loose in ...

SORT 541 / 684

WORKSHOP

Fastener and Hardware Zone

Decide what stays.

Empty the mixed jars onto a tray and keep only what you can name confidently by size and type. Rusted screws, bent nails, and the anchors that came free with a shelf you no longer own are not a stock of hardware.

STRAIGHTEN 542 / 684

WORKSHOP

Fastener and Hardware Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Sort by type first and size second, with the sizes you drive weekly at hand height and the specialty hinges and threaded rod up high. The sample fastener on the drawer face is the label that still works when your hands are dusty.

SHINE 543 / 684

WORKSHOP

Fastener and Hardware Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Vacuum the drawers of metal filings and grit, and look for rust bloom in the bottom corners; if you find it, the cabinet is against a cold outside wall and needs moving before you refill it.

SAFETY 544 / 684

WORKSHOP

Fastener and Hardware Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

A wall cabinet full of steel fasteners is far heavier than it looks, so fix it into studs rather than plasterboard anchors before you load it. Spilled screws on a concrete floor put you on your back holding something sharp.

STANDARDIZE 545 / 684

WORKSHOP

Fastener and Hardware Zone

Write down what good looks like.

One compartment per size, no exceptions and no shared drawers, with a minimum line marked inside so a low bin announces itself the moment you slide it open.

SUSTAIN 546 / 684

WORKSHOP

Fastener and Hardware Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

The handful of leftover fasteners in your pocket goes back into its compartment before the tools go back on the wall, or into the scrap metal tin if you cannot name it. Thirty seconds, and it has to happen while you still remember the job. The minimum lines inside the compartments announce a low bin as you slide it open, so ...

> **THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN**
> One fastener type and size per compartment, with a sample screw glued to the outside of each drawer face so you match by eye rather than by reading. Deck screws separate from drywall screws, no coffee tin of ...

SORT 547 / 684

WORKSHOP

Material Rack

Decide what stays.

Take the offcut bin apart piece by piece against a written size floor. Twisted or badly cupped boards, anything with hidden nails or an unknown coating, and pressure treated scrap all leave, and the coated stock does not go on the fire.

STRAIGHTEN 548 / 684

WORKSHOP

Material Rack

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Group by length and thickness so you can pull a board without unstacking three others, put pipe, trim, and dowel upright in a vertical bin, and support flat stock at intervals close enough that nothing sags between brackets.

SHINE 549 / 684

WORKSHOP

Material Rack

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Sweep out the gap behind the rack where sawdust, spider webs, and mouse droppings collect out of sight, then wipe surface rust off steel stock and give it a light oil before it goes back.

SAFETY 550 / 684

WORKSHOP

Material Rack

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Fix the rack into structural framing, not just the wall skin, and load it heaviest at the bottom. A full sheet of ply leaning at too shallow an angle will slide flat without warning, and it will take out whatever is in front of it.

STANDARDIZE 551 / 684

WORKSHOP

Material Rack

Write down what good looks like.

Mark the lengths on the rack rails so stock returns to the right bay, write the size floor on the offcut bin, and mark a fill line above which the bin is full and the shortest piece leaves.

SUSTAIN 552 / 684

WORKSHOP

Material Rack

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

Before you unplug the saw at the end of a cutting session, every offcut gets a verdict: the bin or the fire bucket. Not the bench, not the floor, not the top of the rack. Five minutes, by whoever made the cuts. The fill line on the bin is the signal, and anything stored directly on the shop floor is the other, both readable ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Boards lying flat and supported along their length with the longest and heaviest at the bottom, sheet goods standing on edge against the wall rather than leaning out into the room, and an offcut bin with its ...

SORT 553 / 684

WORKSHOP

Finishing and Chemical Zone

Decide what stays.

Open and judge each container. Paint with a thick skin or a sour smell is finished, wood glue that has gone stringy or granular will not hold a joint, and cured polyurethane in a half bottle is a rock. Take all of it to household hazardous waste, never the bin, never the drain.

STRAIGHTEN 554 / 684

WORKSHOP

Finishing and Chemical Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Separate what should never meet: solvents and thinners on their own shelf, water based finishes on another, and hardeners kept away from the resins they cure. Keep the stir sticks and the brushes for each family with them.

SHINE 555 / 684

WORKSHOP

Finishing and Chemical Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Wipe the rim of every can before the lid goes back on, because a rim full of dried finish is why the can skins over. Clean brushes right through to the ferrule and wipe down the spill tray.

SAFETY 556 / 684

WORKSHOP

Finishing and Chemical Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

A rag soaked in oil finish generates its own heat as it cures and can ignite with nothing touching it, so it goes in a lidded metal can or gets spread flat outdoors to dry. Keep flammable liquids away from any pilot light or heater, and ventilate before you spray, not after.

STANDARDIZE 557 / 684

WORKSHOP

Finishing and Chemical Zone

Write down what good looks like.

Date every container with a marker the day it arrives, and write the shelf layout on the inside of the cabinet door so the solvents and the water based finishes stay apart even when you are putting things away in a hurry.

SUSTAIN 558 / 684

WORKSHOP

Finishing and Chemical Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

When you wash out a brush at the end of a finishing job, that is when the can gets its date checked and the rag goes into the metal can with the lid down. Both happen at the faucet, by whoever did the finishing. Slip is an undated lid, a container that is not the original, or an oily rag anywhere outside that can. Recovery is a ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Every product in its original labeled container inside a closed metal cabinet, each lid dated in marker, water based paint on one shelf and solvents and thinners on another. Oily rags in a self-closing metal ...

SORT 559 / 684

WORKSHOP

Safety and PPE Station

Decide what stays.

Scratched, hazed safety glasses are the reason people stop wearing safety glasses, so bin them. Perished gloves, respirator cartridges past their date, and a first aid kit you have quietly been raiding for household plasters all get replaced rather than rearranged.

STRAIGHTEN 560 / 684

WORKSHOP

Safety and PPE Station

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Hang the gear at the door on the path you walk in, not on the far wall past the bench, and sized to the actual people who work here. Silhouettes behind each item show at a glance which pair is missing.

SHINE 561 / 684

WORKSHOP

Safety and PPE Station

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Wash the lenses in soap and water rather than wiping them on a dusty shop rag, which is what scratches them in the first place. Wipe the sweat and sawdust off the earmuff cushions so they still seal.

SAFETY 562 / 684

WORKSHOP

Safety and PPE Station

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Lift the extinguisher, check the gauge sits in the green, and confirm nothing has crept into the space in front of it. Then put your hand on the shop's power cutoff and confirm you could reach it with sawdust in your eyes and the lights off.

STANDARDIZE 563 / 684

WORKSHOP

Safety and PPE Station

Write down what good looks like.

Put an inspection date on masking tape on the extinguisher bracket and the first aid kit lid, and hang your safety glasses over the plug of the saw so you cannot power up without handling them first.

SUSTAIN 564 / 684

WORKSHOP

Safety and PPE Station

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

The gear goes back on the board as you switch off the shop light, never into a drawer or a jacket pocket, so the next person in finds a full board. Each user owns their own labeled set, and hanging it up costs the seconds you are already standing there. Slip is a gap in the silhouettes, plus the two dated tapes, because the ...

> **THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN**
> Safety glasses on hooks at the door you come in through, one labeled pair per regular user, hearing protection beside them, and dust masks in a dated box. An extinguisher mounted on the wall with its gauge in ...

SORT 565 / 684

MUDROOM

Family Hook Zone

Decide what stays.

Take every coat, bag, hat and scarf off the wall into one pile and hand each item to its owner to keep or release. Anything nobody has worn since the last change of season leaves the door and goes up to a wardrobe.

STRAIGHTEN 566 / 684

MUDROOM

Family Hook Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Give each person a vertical strip of wall rather than a shared rail, and set their hooks at their own reach so a child never has to ask for their coat. Bag on the lower hook, coat on the upper, so a backpack is never lifted over a wet jacket.

SHINE 567 / 684

MUDROOM

Family Hook Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Wipe the rail and the wall behind it where shoulders and sleeves leave a gray smear, then vacuum the narrow strip of floor directly under the hooks where hood fluff and door grit gather.

SAFETY 568 / 684

MUDROOM

Family Hook Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

A hook carrying four wet coats will pull a screw straight out of plasterboard, so check that every hook sits in a stud or a proper anchor before you reload the wall. Keep scarves, cords and drawstrings off the lowest hooks where a small child plays alone.

STANDARDIZE 569 / 684

MUDROOM

Family Hook Zone

Write down what good looks like.

Write each name on its column at that person's eye height, and say the limit out loud so everyone hears it: one coat, one bag, one hat. A standard is the best way you know today, written down.

SUSTAIN 570 / 684

MUDROOM

Family Hook Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

When you hang your own coat up at the end of the day, look along the wall and move anything on the wrong column back to its owner's. Everyone does their own, and it costs the seconds you are already standing there. The floor is the honest signal: bare floor along the whole run means the hooks are holding what they were given ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Two coats and one bag per person, each on their own named column, the lowest hooks set at the height of the shortest person in the house, and bare floor along the whole run of wall beneath them.

SORT 571 / 684

MUDROOM

Bench and Transition Surface

Decide what stays.

Clear the bench down to bare wood in one go. Most of what is on it belongs in another room, so carry those things there now rather than sliding them to the far end, where they will sit for another month.

STRAIGHTEN 572 / 684

MUDROOM

Bench and Transition Surface

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Protect the seat itself as empty space and give the strays one outbound basket: the library books, the parcel to return, the form waiting for a signature. Nothing that lives in this house permanently gets to sit on this bench.

SHINE 573 / 684

MUDROOM

Bench and Transition Surface

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Wipe the seat and the front edge where boot heels scuff it, then pull the bench away from the wall and sweep out the drift of grit, receipts and single socks underneath.

SAFETY 574 / 684

MUDROOM

Bench and Transition Surface

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Nothing heavy stores on a shelf above the seat, because a bike helmet or a paint tin landing on someone bent over a bootlace is exactly how that shelf fails. Keep the seat clear enough to actually sit on, because balancing on one leg to pull off a wet boot is how people go down.

STANDARDIZE 575 / 684

MUDROOM

Bench and Transition Surface

Write down what good looks like.

Three objects maximum on the surface, and the outbound basket empties on the next trip out of the door. Photograph the cleared bench and tape the picture inside the nearest cupboard door as the reference.

SUSTAIN 576 / 684

MUDROOM

Bench and Transition Surface

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

When you sit down to change your shoes, take one thing off the bench into the house with you as you stand up. Everybody who sits does it, nobody makes a special trip, and the bench drains itself. Slip is the seat: if two people cannot sit and lace boots at once, it has become a shelf. Recovery is one armful, plus the outbound ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

A bare seat wide enough for two people to lace boots at once, no more than three objects on the surface, and one labeled basket at the end holding only what is leaving tomorrow.

SORT 577 / 684

MUDROOM

Shoe and Boot Storage

Decide what stays.

Bring every pair in the house down to this floor and match them up. Outgrown pairs, split soles and unmatched singles leave today, and anything for the opposite season goes up to its owner's wardrobe rather than back on the rack.

STRAIGHTEN 578 / 684

MUDROOM

Shoe and Boot Storage

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

One row per person, heaviest boots on the bottom row so nobody lifts them, lightest slippers on top. Cleats and caked walking boots live on the tray only, never on a shelf where the dried mud drops onto the pair below.

SHINE 579 / 684

MUDROOM

Shoe and Boot Storage

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Tip the tray out into the garden and wash it, because dried mud on a boot tray turns to dust and gets walked straight back inside. Wipe the rack rails and vacuum the floor of the rack where the grit lands.

SAFETY 580 / 684

MUDROOM

Shoe and Boot Storage

Fix what could hurt somebody.

A wet boot sole on a hard floor is the surest slip in this house, so the tray sits exactly where boots actually come off, not two steps further in. Keep the line from the door to the bench completely empty, because a shoe left out in a dark hallway is what people fall over at night.

STANDARDIZE 581 / 684

MUDROOM

Shoe and Boot Storage

Write down what good looks like.

Two pairs per person at the door, wet on the tray, dry on the rack. Mark the tray's footprint on the floor with tape so it goes back to the same spot after every clean.

SUSTAIN 582 / 684

MUDROOM

Shoe and Boot Storage

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

Boots go soles down on the tray when you step in, and when they are dry they move up to the shelf that evening, each person handling their own. The tray is the signal, and what you look for is dry boots still on it, because that means the second half of the habit stopped happening. Recovery is lifting them to the rack, ten ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Two pairs per person on the rack, soles down and toes out, one lipped tray by the door holding whatever came in wet, and clear floor between the tray and the doorway.

SORT 583 / 684

MUDROOM

Pet Station

Decide what stays.

Lay out every lead, collar, harness and chewed toy you can find in this room. Keep the lead you genuinely walk with plus one spare, then let the outgrown collar, the harness that never fitted and the retired long line go.

STRAIGHTEN 584 / 684

MUDROOM

Pet Station

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Hang the walking kit as one connected unit, lead clipped to collar with the bag roll threaded on, so leaving the house is one grab and not a search of three rooms. Towel on top of the food bin, treats up high where a nose cannot reach them.

SHINE 585 / 684

MUDROOM

Pet Station

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Wash the scoop and wipe the crumbs and oils out of the bin before you refill it, rather than tipping fresh food onto stale, and put the paw towel through the wash with the door mats so one load covers both.

SAFETY 586 / 684

MUDROOM

Pet Station

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Flea, tick and worming treatments are poison to a child and to an animal of the wrong size, so they live in a closed box above reach, never loose in the caddy beside the bags. Coil the lead on its hook instead of leaving a loop hanging low, because a hanging loop at a toddler's height is a strangling risk.

STANDARDIZE 587 / 684

MUDROOM

Pet Station

Write down what good looks like.

Refill the bin when the level drops to the scoop, and keep one spare bag roll behind the one in use. Write the daily food amount on a label taped to the bin lid so whoever feeds gets the same answer.

SUSTAIN 588 / 684

MUDROOM

Pet Station

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

When you clip the lead back on its hook after a walk, check the bag roll and swap it if it is down to the last few. Five seconds while your hands are already there. The scoop is the second gauge, because when the food level drops to it the bin gets refilled, and the daily amount written on the lid means whoever feeds gets the ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Lead clipped to collar on one hook with a full roll of waste bags attached, an old towel folded within arm's reach of the door, food sealed in a bin with the scoop inside it, and every treatment behind a ...

SORT 589 / 684

MUDROOM

Seasonal Outdoor Gear

Decide what stays.

Tip every glove, mitten and hat onto the floor and match them into pairs. Put the singles in one bag, and read the dates on the sunscreen and the insect repellent, because a bottle opened two summers ago is no longer doing the job printed on the label.

STRAIGHTEN 590 / 684

MUDROOM

Seasonal Outdoor Gear

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Open bins with no lids, one per person, set at their own reach so a child can get their own gloves without asking anyone. Umbrellas go in the stand and never in a bin, because one wet umbrella soaks everything it lies against.

SHINE 591 / 684

MUDROOM

Seasonal Outdoor Gear

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Everything goes into off-season storage washed and bone dry, because damp wool packed away in April comes out smelling in October. Wipe out the empty bins and get the sand out of the corners before you refill them.

SAFETY 592 / 684

MUDROOM

Seasonal Outdoor Gear

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Insect repellent and sunscreen sitting in a low open bin will find their way into a small mouth, so anything carrying a warning on the label goes in a closed box above child reach. Store umbrellas points down, because a spike stood upright sits at a toddler's eye height.

STANDARDIZE 593 / 684

MUDROOM

Seasonal Outdoor Gear

Write down what good looks like.

Two changeovers a year, spring and autumn, and the month you closed a bin goes on its lid. Write the same short order on that lid as well: gloves matched, hats washed, creams checked for date, umbrellas emptied out.

SUSTAIN 594 / 684

MUDROOM

Seasonal Outdoor Gear

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

The first cold morning you reach into the bin for gloves and find it empty is the signal, and the changeover happens that weekend, run by one adult from the short order written on the lid. An hour, twice a year. Slip in between is two seasons within reach at once, or a bin holding unmatched singles. Recovery is matching pairs ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

One open bin per person at their own height holding this season's gloves and hat with every pair matched, umbrellas standing points down in one stand by the door, and the other season's bin closed, labeled ...

SORT 595 / 684

MUDROOM

Cleaning and Utility Zone

Decide what stays.

Line every bottle up on the floor and read them. Keep the floor cleaner, the glass spray, the disinfectant and the pet stain remover you actually reach for, and send out the last inch in the six other bottles, following the disposal line printed on each label.

STRAIGHTEN 596 / 684

MUDROOM

Cleaning and Utility Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Clip each long-handled tool near its head so the bristles hang clear of the floor and the handle points down. A broom stood on its bristles bends them out of shape and holds on to whatever it swept last.

SHINE 597 / 684

MUDROOM

Cleaning and Utility Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Rinse the mop head and let it dry fully before it goes back on its clip, cut the hair off the vacuum's brush bar, and empty the dustpan rather than storing it loaded.

SAFETY 598 / 684

MUDROOM

Cleaning and Utility Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Never keep bleach and an ammonia-based cleaner in one closed caddy, because a leaking cap in a shut box mixes them into a gas you cannot get away from fast enough. This corner also holds a mains vacuum next to wet boots and a damp mop, so the socket and the flex stay up off the floor and dry.

STANDARDIZE 599 / 684

MUDROOM

Cleaning and Utility Zone

Write down what good looks like.

The mop, broom and dustpan hang, and the vacuum parks inside its outline; nothing in this corner stands on the floor and nothing goes back on its clip wet. Paint or tape that outline so the empty space reads as a job done rather than a gap.

SUSTAIN 600 / 684

MUDROOM

Cleaning and Utility Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

When you shake the door mats out, hang the broom back on its clip and feel whether the mop head has dried. Twenty seconds, by whoever shook them. Slip is a tool standing on the floor rather than hanging, or a mop head still damp to the touch, both within reach at the moment you are checking. Recovery is hanging it clear of the ...

> **THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN**
> Broom, mop and dustpan clipped to the wall with their heads hanging clear of the floor, the vacuum parked flat against the wall inside a marked outline, and one caddy holding the four cleaners you genuinely ...

SORT 601 / 684

HALL CLOSET

Linen Shelf Zone

Decide what stays.

Unfold every set and check it is complete and fits a bed you still own. The flat sheet whose fitted half vanished, fitted sheets with slack elastic that pop off a corner at three in the morning, and towels that smell sour an hour after drying all leave.

STRAIGHTEN 602 / 684

HALL CLOSET

Linen Shelf Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Fold each set to one uniform footprint and bundle it inside its own pillowcase so a bed change is one grab, not four. Queen and king low, everyday towels at chest height, guest blankets on top.

SHINE 603 / 684

HALL CLOSET

Linen Shelf Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Pull every stack right out, wipe the shelf boards with a barely damp cloth, and let the wood dry fully before linens return. Watch for the gray line along the shelf lip that means dust is drifting down onto clean sheets.

SAFETY 604 / 684

HALL CLOSET

Linen Shelf Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

A tall stack on a high shelf comes down as one mass when you tug the bottom towel. Keep no stack taller than your forearm, and keep the heavy blankets at waist height rather than overhead.

STANDARDIZE 605 / 684

HALL CLOSET

Linen Shelf Zone

Write down what good looks like.

The shelf label carries the count, not just the name: "Queen, 3 sets." Anyone opening this door can see the shelf is short before laundry day rather than at bedtime.

SUSTAIN 606 / 684

HALL CLOSET

Linen Shelf Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

Stripping a bed sends you here for the fresh bundle, and the count on the shelf edge tells you on the spot whether you are down to your last set. Ten seconds, no stock take, no list. Slip is a shelf holding fewer bundles than its label says, visible with the door open. Recovery is running that load today rather than at bedtime ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Three sheet sets per bed, each nested inside one of its own pillowcases, with the bed size written on the shelf edge underneath. Everyday towels folded to one width in a stack no taller than your forearm. Two ...

SORT 607 / 684

HALL CLOSET

Cleaning Equipment Zone

Decide what stays.

Stand every handle up and look at the working end. Brooms with splayed bristles that push dust rather than gather it, the mop head that no longer twists off its plate, and the old vacuum you keep for parts you have never once harvested all go out this week.

STRAIGHTEN 608 / 684

HALL CLOSET

Cleaning Equipment Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Fit a rail and hang each tool so bristles and mop heads swing free, because heads left standing on the floor bend over and re-soil what you just cleaned. Tape an outline for the vacuum's footprint and keep the attachments in one labeled bag clipped to its handle.

SHINE 609 / 684

HALL CLOSET

Cleaning Equipment Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Empty the canister, cut the wound hair off the beater bar with scissors, rinse the mop head and dry it outside the closet. Sweep out the grit that drops off the vacuum wheels into the closet floor corners.

SAFETY 610 / 684

HALL CLOSET

Cleaning Equipment Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

A broom leaned against the wall slides and lands across the doorway in the dark. Clip every handle to the rail, and never shut a damp mop head or a wet bucket into this closet.

STANDARDIZE 611 / 684

HALL CLOSET

Cleaning Equipment Zone

Write down what good looks like.

The taped outline is the standard: if you can see floor inside the tape, the vacuum is out and not yet put away. The attachment bag rides on the handle, never loose on a shelf.

SUSTAIN 612 / 684

HALL CLOSET

Cleaning Equipment Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

Switching the vacuum off is the signal to wrap the cord, not to lean it against the wall for later. Whoever ran it wraps it, bags the attachments on the handle and parks it inside the tape before sitting down, two minutes. The taped outline is the whole check, because floor visible inside the tape means the vacuum is out and ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

The vacuum standing inside a taped floor outline with its cord wrapped and every crevice tool and brush head zipped in one bag clipped to its handle. Broom, mop, and duster hanging handle-down from wall clips ...

SORT 613 / 684

HALL CLOSET

Cleaning Supply Zone

Decide what stays.

Line every bottle up on the hallway floor. Anything decanted into an unmarked spray bottle gets disposed of according to its own instructions, and the specialty cleaner bought for one stain years ago goes with it. Only identical products get poured together.

STRAIGHTEN 614 / 684

HALL CLOSET

Cleaning Supply Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Build a bathroom caddy and a kitchen caddy so you carry the whole job in one hand instead of walking back here twice. Gloves and cloths ride inside the caddy with the sprays, not in a drawer down the hall.

SHINE 615 / 684

HALL CLOSET

Cleaning Supply Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Wipe the crusted ring off the base of each bottle before it goes back, and lay a wipeable liner on the shelf so the next slow drip lands on plastic instead of soaking into the board.

SAFETY 616 / 684

HALL CLOSET

Cleaning Supply Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Chlorine bleach and ammonia products release a choking gas if they leak onto each other, so give them separate shelves. Keep every product in its original labeled container, and put this zone out of a small child's reach or behind a latch.

STANDARDIZE 617 / 684

HALL CLOSET

Cleaning Supply Zone

Write down what good looks like.

Each caddy end reads the room it belongs to. The written rule is one line: a bottle without a legible original label is not stored, it is emptied.

SUSTAIN 618 / 684

HALL CLOSET

Cleaning Supply Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

Setting the caddy back on the shelf is when you notice what ran dry, and the empty goes on the shopping list before the door shuts. Ten seconds inside a trip already made. Slip is a bottle without a legible original label, and the rule for it is one line: it is not stored, it is emptied. Recovery is that, today, rather than a ...

> **THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN**
> Two or three caddies, each labeled on the end with the room it serves, every bottle wearing its original label, bleach products and ammonia products on separate shelves, and the whole zone up out of a small ...

SORT 619 / 684

HALL CLOSET

Paper and Household Backstock

Decide what stays.

Take the lot out. Loose batteries you cannot vouch for, bulbs for fittings you replaced when you went over to LED, and the bulk paper towel pack too big to lift down alone all leave now.

STRAIGHTEN 620 / 684

HALL CLOSET

Paper and Household Backstock

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Toilet roll goes into the clear bin loose so you can see the level drop, bulbs stay in their boxes grouped by fitting, and batteries stand upright in a shallow tray by size so you read AAA from AA without picking one up. Heaviest packs at waist height, every label turned to the door.

SHINE 621 / 684

HALL CLOSET

Paper and Household Backstock

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Wipe the shelf and check the tray bottom for the white crust that means a cell has leaked. Press the underside of paper packs stored against a cold outside wall to feel for damp before you restock them.

SAFETY 622 / 684

HALL CLOSET

Paper and Household Backstock

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Loose batteries whose terminals touch metal or each other can short and heat up, and a button cell dropped on a closet floor is exactly the size a toddler swallows. Keep cells in their packs, tape the terminals of any loose 9-volt, and store nothing at floor level here.

STANDARDIZE 623 / 684

HALL CLOSET

Paper and Household Backstock

Write down what good looks like.

The minimum and maximum go on the shelf edge in front of each bin, not in your head. Below the minimum puts it on the shopping list; at the maximum you stop buying it regardless of the offer.

SUSTAIN 624 / 684

HALL CLOSET

Paper and Household Backstock

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

Lifting the last toilet roll out of the bin is the moment you are below the minimum, and it goes on the list before you leave the hallway, which is ten seconds. The min and max cards on the shelf edge do the deciding, so nobody holds a number in their head, and at the maximum you stop buying regardless of the offer. Slip is a ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Toilet roll in one clear bin with a card on the shelf edge reading "min 6, max 24". Bulbs in a labeled bin sorted by fitting. Batteries standing in their original packs in a shallow tray, sizes readable ...

SORT 625 / 684

HALL CLOSET

Seasonal and Guest Zone

Decide what stays.

Every lid comes off, on the floor, in daylight. Decorations for a tree you no longer put up, the guest pillow gone flat and yellow, and the bin marked "misc" whose contents you cannot name without looking all go.

STRAIGHTEN 626 / 684

HALL CLOSET

Seasonal and Guest Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

One bin per occasion, not one bin per overflow. Tape a shelf map inside the door so you can send someone else for the guest bedding without them unstacking the whole shelf to find it.

SHINE 627 / 684

HALL CLOSET

Seasonal and Guest Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Guest bedding gets washed before it goes into the bin rather than after it comes out, because a year sealed in a box is what your guests will smell. Wipe the dust off each lid while it is open, and put your nose to the bottom of every bin for the mustiness that means something went in damp last season.

SAFETY 628 / 684

HALL CLOSET

Seasonal and Guest Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

A heavy lidded bin lifted down from above your head is how ankles and backs go, especially when the lid blocks your view of your own feet. Keep the heaviest bins at chest height, and keep a proper step stool in this closet so nobody stands on a hallway chair.

STANDARDIZE 629 / 684

HALL CLOSET

Seasonal and Guest Zone

Write down what good looks like.

Every bin carries its contents and the date it was last closed. Photograph each bin packed and tape the picture to the lid, so repacking has a target instead of a guess.

SUSTAIN 630 / 684

HALL CLOSET

Seasonal and Guest Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

Taking the guest bed apart after a visit sends the bedding to the wash and then straight back into its own labeled bin, never onto the linen shelf. One load, and the repack happens while it runs. Slip is a bin with no closing date, or guest bedding that has quietly joined the everyday linen, both showing as soon as the door ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Three or four lidded bins on the upper shelf, each labeled with what is inside and the month it was last closed. Guest pillows sealed in a zip bag. A shelf map taped inside the door showing which bin sits ...

SORT 631 / 684

STAIR LANDING

Landing Surface or Console

Decide what stays.

Take everything off the console top and out of its drawer in one sweep. Sort into three: things that genuinely live on this floor, things headed up or down (straight into the stair basket now), and the drift a landing collects, loose screws, dry pens, keys to nothing, mail you already read.

STRAIGHTEN 632 / 684

STAIR LANDING

Landing Surface or Console

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Put the tray at the end of the console nearest the top step, where your hand lands as you turn, not at the decorative center. Clip the lamp cord to the back leg so it never crosses the side people walk.

SHINE 633 / 684

STAIR LANDING

Landing Surface or Console

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Wipe the console top, the front edge where hips and bags push past, and the top rim of the lamp shade, which catches the dust the stairwell draft keeps lifting. Then press one corner of the console: if it rocks, shim it now, because a wobble beside an open stairwell is how a lamp goes over the edge.

SAFETY 634 / 684

STAIR LANDING

Landing Surface or Console

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Nothing on this surface may overhang the stair side, not by a centimetre. A book with its spine past the edge ends up on a tread, and a tread with a book on it is how people fall down stairs at night.

STANDARDIZE 635 / 684

STAIR LANDING

Landing Surface or Console

Write down what good looks like.

Write the count into the surface itself: three permanent items plus one tray on top, and one basket on the floor. Photograph the console in that state and tape the photo inside the console drawer, where the next person to open it will see it.

SUSTAIN 636 / 684

STAIR LANDING

Landing Surface or Console

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

Whoever switches off the landing light at night carries the stair basket up or down and brings it back empty. The switch is the trigger, so the basket never sleeps loaded and the trip is one you were making anyway. Slip is a tray holding something that was there yesterday, or a basket that came back with something in it ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Three permanent things on the console top, say a lamp, a framed photo and one tray, with the tray holding nothing that was there yesterday. The lamp cord runs down the back leg in a clip, not across the ...

SORT 637 / 684

STAIR LANDING

Wall and Display Zone

Decide what stays.

Take down anything hanging from a single nail or a sawtooth hanger, any frame with cracked glass, and the pictures you honestly last looked at years ago. You watch your feet on stairs, not the wall, so this wall only earns what you stop on the landing to look at.

STRAIGHTEN 638 / 684

STAIR LANDING

Wall and Display Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Set the spacing by measuring from each frame's center down to the nose of the tread beneath it and holding that number constant up the flight. Equal gaps between frames, and one consistent bottom edge across the flat landing section.

SHINE 639 / 684

STAIR LANDING

Wall and Display Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Dust the top edge of each frame first, then the glass, then wipe the wall along the turn where shoulders, bags and laundry baskets rub a gray line. As you take your hand off each frame, look behind it at the wire for kinks and at the hook for a bent lip.

SAFETY 640 / 684

STAIR LANDING

Wall and Display Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Stair walls take constant vibration, and single nails and sawtooth hangers work loose in them. Everything here hangs from two points on hardware rated well above the item's weight, and the mirror goes into a stud or a proper wall anchor. Never straighten a high frame while standing on a tread. Do it from the flat landing or a ...

STANDARDIZE 641 / 684

STAIR LANDING

Wall and Display Zone

Write down what good looks like.

One hanging system across the whole wall, two hooks and a wire, so a replacement frame never quietly reintroduces a nail. Put a dated sticker on the back of the lowest frame recording the last time you press-tested the flight.

SUSTAIN 642 / 684

STAIR LANDING

Wall and Display Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

Handrail day is also frame day. As you work up the rail with your cloth, push up and out on the two frames within arm's reach, so over a season the whole wall gets checked, ten seconds at a time, without ever becoming a job you had to plan. Slip is a frame that moves under your hand, or one gone out of level, and the dated ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Every frame level and hung from two points, each one the same vertical distance above the tread nose below it, so the gallery climbs on the stair's diagonal rather than fighting it. No sawtooth hanger and no ...

SORT 643 / 684

STAIR LANDING

Stair and Floor Path

Decide what stays.

Nothing lives on stairs. Clear the folded laundry, the shoes, the box that has sat on step four since the weekend, all of it in one trip, and put each thing where it belongs on its own floor rather than restaging it on the landing above.

STRAIGHTEN 644 / 684

STAIR LANDING

Stair and Floor Path

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

The one thing that must stay reachable here is the handrail, so strip both newel posts of coats, bags and leads. If a stair gate is fitted, set the top gate to swing away from the flight and never out over it.

SHINE 645 / 684

STAIR LANDING

Stair and Floor Path

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Vacuum the tread noses, the crevice where each tread meets its riser, and along the stringer where a runner is tucked. That trapped grit is what polishes a runner slick under a stocking foot. Wipe the handrail its full length, including the underside your fingers wrap around.

SAFETY 646 / 684

STAIR LANDING

Stair and Floor Path

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Walk the flight slowly and test as you go: press each tread nose for movement, tug each runner edge, and grip the rail hard at top, middle and bottom to find a loose bracket. Then stand at the bottom in the dark and look at the top step, and stand at the top and look at the bottom. A burnt-out bulb over a top step is the single ...

STANDARDIZE 647 / 684

STAIR LANDING

Stair and Floor Path

Write down what good looks like.

The standard is one sentence anyone in the house can check: bare treads, full width, lit at both ends, rail clear. Photograph the empty flight from the bottom and put that picture where the staging happens, which is almost always beside the bottom step.

SUSTAIN 648 / 684

STAIR LANDING

Stair and Floor Path

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

The last person up at night takes the flight with one hand on the rail and carries whatever is sitting on a tread. If their hands are too full to hold the rail, that is the signal to make two trips, and two trips is the right answer rather than a failure. Slip is anything on a step, or a runner corner lifted at the turn, both ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Every tread bare from nose to riser, including the bottom three steps that usually stage things. The runner lies flat with no lifted corner at the turn. The handrail runs unbroken and unobstructed from the top ...

SORT 649 / 684

PATIO OR DECK

Outdoor Seating Zone

Decide what stays.

Sit in every chair. The one that wobbles, the one with the cracked resin arm, and the cushion you would not offer a guest are decisions, not furniture. Count who actually sits out here on an ordinary evening and keep that many chairs plus two.

STRAIGHTEN 650 / 684

PATIO OR DECK

Outdoor Seating Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Chairs face each other close enough to talk without raising your voice, and no chair sits in the swing of the back door. Cushions live in the deck box, not stacked on a seat under a towel that stays wet underneath.

SHINE 651 / 684

PATIO OR DECK

Outdoor Seating Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Hose the frames and scrub the webbing where grit packs into the joints, then stand each chair on its side so water runs out of the tubing instead of sitting inside it all summer. Check the underside of every cushion for black speckling while it dries.

SAFETY 652 / 684

PATIO OR DECK

Outdoor Seating Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Resin and plastic chairs go brittle from years of sun long before they look it. Flex each arm and press the seat pan hard with your palm; a chair that creaks or shows fine white cracks around a leg joint leaves today, not after someone drops through it onto the boards.

STANDARDIZE 653 / 684

PATIO OR DECK

Outdoor Seating Zone

Write down what good looks like.

One cushion per seat and none spare, so a gap in the box tells you a cushion is still out on a chair. A photo of the chairs in their usual evening arrangement, taped inside the deck box lid, is what the last person out puts them back to.

SUSTAIN 654 / 684

PATIO OR DECK

Outdoor Seating Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

When you carry the last glass inside for the night, the cushions come in with you in the same trip. The box does the counting, one cushion per seat and none spare, so a gap in the deck box means one is still out on a chair. Recovery is fetching it tonight, because a cushion that gets rained on takes days to dry and comes in wet ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Four chairs you can sit in without testing, set close enough to talk across, every cushion in the deck box, and no cover crumpled on the ground behind a planter.

SORT 655 / 684

PATIO OR DECK

Grill and Outdoor Cooking Zone

Decide what stays.

Empty the side shelf and the cabinet under the grill. Out comes a bag of dried-out lighter cubes, three sets of tongs, a thermometer with a dead battery, and sauce bottles that spent a whole summer at outdoor temperature. Keep one long-handled tong, one spatula, one instant-read thermometer, and one basting brush.

STRAIGHTEN 656 / 684

PATIO OR DECK

Grill and Outdoor Cooking Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Hang the tongs and spatula on the grill's own hooks so you never walk away from a lit grill to go looking. Fuel keeps its distance from heat: the propane tank upright and outdoors, the charcoal bag sealed and off the ground, the chimney starter beside it.

SHINE 657 / 684

PATIO OR DECK

Grill and Outdoor Cooking Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Burn the grates off, then pull the flavorizer bars and scrape the grease tray and drip pan out into the bin rather than leaving a rendered layer to feed the next flare-up. While the burners are exposed, look up into the tubes; a spider web in a venturi tube is exactly why the flame runs yellow and lazy along one side.

SAFETY 658 / 684

PATIO OR DECK

Grill and Outdoor Cooking Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Brush soapy water onto the propane hose and the regulator fitting, then open the valve. Bubbles mean replace the hose, not tighten it and hope. Retire any wire brush whose bristles you can pull free with your fingers, because a loose bristle ends up in food, and switch to a scraper or a coiled brush.

STANDARDIZE 659 / 684

PATIO OR DECK

Grill and Outdoor Cooking Zone

Write down what good looks like.

The grease tray gets emptied on a fixed count of cooks, marked off on a card taped inside the cabinet door. A tank is written full or empty in marker on its collar the same day it changes state, so nobody has to guess by lifting it.

SUSTAIN 660 / 684

PATIO OR DECK

Grill and Outdoor Cooking Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

Every time you close the lid at the end of a cook, scrape the grates while they are still hot and glance into the tray before you walk away. A minute, by whoever cooked. The card inside the cabinet door counts the cooks between grease tray emptyings, so that job has a written trigger rather than a smell. Slip is a fifth tool ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Grates scraped bare, grease tray emptied and back in its rails, four tools on the grill's own hooks and no fifth anywhere, the propane tank upright with its level written on the collar, and a clear arm's ...

SORT 661 / 684

PATIO OR DECK

Outdoor Dining Zone

Decide what stays.

Clear the table down to bare surface and face what has been living on it: a citronella bucket burned to the rim, a lighter that no longer sparks, placemats gone pale on the upper side only, and the melamine plates from a barbecue two summers ago. Settle the dishware question below before anything goes back.

STRAIGHTEN 662 / 684

PATIO OR DECK

Outdoor Dining Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Chairs tuck fully under the table so nobody has to sidestep a chair leg carrying a hot dish. One weighted tray holds the salt, the pepper, and the napkin weight, so laying the table is one trip out rather than four.

SHINE 663 / 684

PATIO OR DECK

Outdoor Dining Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Wash the tabletop along the grain and pay attention to the collar where the umbrella pole passes through, since that ring collects grit and holds water against the table. Wipe the underside edges too, which is where hands go and where wasps like to start building.

SAFETY 664 / 684

PATIO OR DECK

Outdoor Dining Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

An open umbrella is a sail. Match the base weight to the canopy size, crank the umbrella down whenever you leave the table, and close it before wind arrives rather than during it. Run string lights on hooks along the rail using outdoor-rated cord on a socket with a residual current device, never a household extension lead lying ...

STANDARDIZE 665 / 684

PATIO OR DECK

Outdoor Dining Zone

Write down what good looks like.

The table's resting state is bare except for the umbrella and the one weighted tray. Anything else arrives with a meal and leaves with it, including the candles.

SUSTAIN 666 / 684

PATIO OR DECK

Outdoor Dining Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

Whoever carries the last plate inside closes the umbrella and lifts the tray on the way past. One pass, no extra trip. Slip reads from the kitchen window as anything on the table other than the umbrella and the one weighted tray, including the candles that arrived with dinner. Recovery is a single clearing pass, two minutes ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

A bare tabletop except the umbrella and one weighted tray, six chairs tucked fully under, string lights clipped along the rail with no cord crossing the floor, and nothing stored beneath the table.

SORT 667 / 684

PATIO OR DECK

Garden and Plant Care Zone

Decide what stays.

Turn out every empty pot. A pot with no drainage hole and a pot still holding last year's dead root ball both go; keep the pots you will actually plant this season plus two, nested by size. Bagged potting soil that has gone solid and sour gets emptied into a bed rather than stored for a spring that will not want it.

STRAIGHTEN 668 / 684

PATIO OR DECK

Garden and Plant Care Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Hand tools stand in one caddy you can carry in the hand that is not holding the watering can. Long tools hang head up on a rail so no blade waits at shin height. Fertilizer and every concentrate sit above the tools, never in the row beside the watering can where a tired hand reaches.

SHINE 669 / 684

PATIO OR DECK

Garden and Plant Care Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Empty every saucer, then scrub the white mineral crust from the pot rims and scrape soil off the trowel and pruner blades before they go back damp. Wipe the pruner blades and put a drop of oil on the pivot while you have them open.

SAFETY 670 / 684

PATIO OR DECK

Garden and Plant Care Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

The concentrates, slug pellets, and fertilizer are the real hazard on this patio, and pellets look like food to a dog. They stay in a latched box, up high, in the container they came in, never decanted into a drink bottle or a jam jar. Empty standing water from saucers, the wheelbarrow, and the upturned pot lid after rain so ...

STANDARDIZE 671 / 684

PATIO OR DECK

Garden and Plant Care Zone

Write down what good looks like.

Every pot carries a small tag with what is in it and the month it went in, so anyone in the house can decide whether it needs water without coming to find you.

SUSTAIN 672 / 684

PATIO OR DECK

Garden and Plant Care Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

When you fill the watering can, look along the row of saucers before you start pouring. Ten seconds, and it happens while the can is filling. Slip is standing water in a saucer, or a pot with no tag, both visible from where you stand with the hose. Recovery is tipping the saucers out, not repotting anything. Standing water is ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Every saucer empty, pots nested by size along the wall with drain holes clear, one tool caddy holding trowel, pruners, and gloves, and a latched chemical box above the tools with no more in it than you can ...

SORT 673 / 684

PATIO OR DECK

Outdoor Storage Zone

Decide what stays.

Empty the deck box onto the boards, all of it. You will find cushions that went in damp last autumn, a croquet set missing two mallets, four covers for furniture you no longer own, and a bag of charcoal that has drawn moisture and will never light properly again. Anything that still smells of mildew after a wash does not go ...

STRAIGHTEN 674 / 684

PATIO OR DECK

Outdoor Storage Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Cushions load last and come out first, because they are the only thing in this box that has to move in a hurry. Games and covers go into flat-bottomed totes underneath, so nothing loose migrates into the corners where hands do not reach.

SHINE 675 / 684

PATIO OR DECK

Outdoor Storage Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Scrub the interior and prop the lid open on a dry, breezy day until the corners are genuinely dry rather than just cool to the touch. Check that the drain holes in the base are clear, and tip the box forward to sweep out the layer of leaf mulch that has packed underneath it.

SAFETY 676 / 684

PATIO OR DECK

Outdoor Storage Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

A deck box lid is heavy and hinged at exactly a child's hand height. Lift it and let go halfway; if it drops on its own, fit a lid stay before anything else, because crushed fingers in that hinge is the injury this zone reliably produces. Mouse droppings or shredded nesting material in stored fabric means you wash before ...

STANDARDIZE 677 / 684

PATIO OR DECK

Outdoor Storage Zone

Write down what good looks like.

Two totes, one written games and one written covers, labeled on the short end you can read once the cushions are lifted out. The lid is the measure: if someone has to sit on it to close it, something leaves the box that day.

SUSTAIN 678 / 684

PATIO OR DECK

Outdoor Storage Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

When the cushions go in at the end of an evening, the lid gets latched, not just lowered. The latch is the difference between a dry box and a wet one in the first real wind. The lid is also the measure, so if somebody has to sit on it to close it, something leaves the box that day. Recovery is one tote out rather than a repack ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

The lid closes flat without anyone pressing down, cushions in one layer on top, two labeled totes beneath them, and the floor of the box visible the moment the cushions come out.

SORT 679 / 684

PATIO OR DECK

Surface, Rail, and Safety Zone

Decide what stays.

This zone earns its state by having nothing stored in it. The planter that has drifted into the walking route, the hose coiled across the top step, and the bag of paving sand leaning on a rail post all come off the deck entirely, because each of them holds damp against the wood it sits on as well as standing in your way.

STRAIGHTEN 680 / 684

PATIO OR DECK

Surface, Rail, and Safety Zone

Give what stayed a home you can reach.

Walk the route from the door to the steps to the gate carrying a full laundry basket in both arms so you cannot see your feet. Whatever you have to step around gets moved. The mat sits square at the threshold with its edges lying flat, not curling up at a corner.

SHINE 681 / 684

PATIO OR DECK

Surface, Rail, and Safety Zone

Clean it, and see what the cleaning tells you.

Rake the gaps between boards clear with a putty knife or a paint stirrer, because a blocked gap holds water against the board ends and that is precisely where rot begins. Then scrub the green algae film off the shaded boards and the stair treads, which is the slipperiest surface anywhere on the property after rain.

SAFETY 682 / 684

PATIO OR DECK

Surface, Rail, and Safety Zone

Fix what could hurt somebody.

Grab the top rail at every post and push hard, outward and then down. Any movement, any softness under your thumb, any screw head standing proud is a stop and fix today. Check that every stair tread rises the same height as the ones above and below it, and that the step lights still come on, because one odd riser in the dark is ...

STANDARDIZE 683 / 684

PATIO OR DECK

Surface, Rail, and Safety Zone

Write down what good looks like.

A dated tag inside the back door records when the rail was last pushed and the boards last probed, so the next check starts from a written date rather than an argument about whether you did it in spring.

SUSTAIN 684 / 684

PATIO OR DECK

Surface, Rail, and Safety Zone

Attach the reset to something that already happens.

Sweeping the deck is also the rail check, so push hard at two posts before the broom goes away. Ten seconds, and the whole rail gets tested across a season without a job ever being booked. Slip is a post that gives under your hand, or a green film on the shaded treads, which is the surface telling you it is staying wet ...

THE ZONE IS DONE WHEN

Nothing on the deck that is not furniture, daylight visible through the gaps between boards, no green film on the shaded treads, and every rail post immovable when you push it hard.